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THIS IS A PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT FOR INFORMATION PURPOSES ONLY AND IS NOT A PROSPECTUS ANNOUNCEMENT AND DOES NOT CONSTITUTE AN INVITATION OR OFFER TO ACQUIRE, PURCHASE OR SUBSCRIBE TO SECURITIES. NOT FOR RELEASE, PUBLICATION OR DISTRIBUTION DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY OUTSIDE INDIA. INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF EQUITY SHARES OF JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE BSE LIMITED ("BSE") AND THE NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED ("NSE" AND TOGETHER WITH BSE, THE "STOCK EXCHANGES") IN COMPLIANCE WITH CHAPTER II OF THE SECURITIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018, AS AMENDED ("SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS").

JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED

(Please scan this QR code to view the Red Herring Prospectus, and the Abridged Prospectus)

(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Jio Platforms Limited was incorporated on November 15, 2019, at Ahmedabad, Gujarat, as a public company limited by shares under the Companies Act, 2013, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation issued by the Registrar of Companies, Central Registration Centre. For further details, see "History and Certain Corporate Matters" on page 249 of the red herring prospectus dated October 14, 2026 (**"RHP"**).

Corporate Identity Number: U72900GJ2019PLC110816
Registered Office: Office-101, Saffron, Nr. Centre Point, Panchwati 5 Rasta, Ambawadi, Ahmedabad 380 006, Gujarat, India
Corporate Office: TC-22, 5th Floor, A Wing, Reliance Corporate Park, Thane Belapur Road, Ghansoli, Navi Mumbai 400 701, Maharashtra, India
Contact Person(s): Ms. Savithri Parekh, Company Secretary and Mr. Venkataraman Ramachandran, Compliance Officer
E-mail: jpl.investorrelations@jio.com; **Tel:** +91 22 7967 0000; **Website:** www.jio.com

OUR PROMOTER: RELIANCE INDUSTRIES LIMITED

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO 270,000,000 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED ("THE COMPANY" OR "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SECURITIES PREMIUM OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("ISSUE PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ [●] MILLION (THE "ISSUE"). THE ISSUE INCLUDES A RESERVATION OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] EACH, AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 5,000 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [●]% OF THE ISSUE), FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES ("EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION") AND A RESERVATION OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] EACH, AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 25,000 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [●]% OF THE ISSUE), FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE RIL SHAREHOLDERS ("RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION"). THE ISSUE LESS THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION AND THE RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION IS HEREINAFTER REFERRED TO AS THE "NET ISSUE". THE ISSUE AND THE NET ISSUE SHALL CONSTITUTE [●]% AND [●]% OF THE POST-ISSUE PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF THE COMPANY, RESPECTIVELY. THE COMPANY, IN CONSULTATION WITH THE BRLMs, IS OFFERING A DISCOUNT OF ₹ 54 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION ("EMPLOYEE DISCOUNT")

PRICE BAND: ₹ 1,065 TO ₹ 1,119 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH.

THE FLOOR PRICE IS 106.50 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND THE CAP PRICE IS 111.90 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.

BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 12 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 12 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH THEREAFTER

THE PRICE TO EARNING RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EARNINGS PER SHARE ("EPS") FOR FISCAL 2026 FOR THE COMPANY AT THE LOWER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 31.71 TIMES, AND AT THE UPPER END OF THE PRICE BAND IS 33.31 TIMES, AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 22.35 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.

A DISCOUNT OF ₹ 54 PER EQUITY SHARE IS BEING OFFERED TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION

BID/ISSUE PERIOD

BID/ISSUE OPENS TODAY

BID/ISSUE CLOSES ON(1): FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2026

(1) UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 7:00 p.m. IST on the Bid/ Issue Closing Date.

Jio Platforms Limited, is a technology platform, built on proprietary digital technology and pan-India digital connectivity as its foundational layer, driving digital transformation in India. Our Material Subsidiary, Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited, served 533.3 million customers in India as of June 30, 2026.

THE ISSUE IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES. NSE IS THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.

QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE NET ISSUE | NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE NET ISSUE | RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE NET ISSUE

EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 5,000 MILLION
RIL SHAREHOLDERS RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ 25,000 MILLION

The details of the Fresh Issue and the post Issue market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

ISSUE SIZE AND MARKET CAPITALIZATION

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹ 1,065 per Equity Share		At Cap Price of ₹ 1,119 per Equity Share	
	Up to no. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	Up to Amount (In ₹ Million)	Up to no. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	Up to Amount (In ₹ Million)
Fresh Issue	270,000,000	287,282.94^	270,000,000	301,876.48^
Post Issue Market Capitalisation	**9,209,030,830**	**9,807,617.83**	**9,209,030,830**	**10,304,905.50**

^ Considers the impact of Employee Discount of ₹ 54 per Equity Share

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST RELY ONLY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RED HERRING PROSPECTUS AND THE TERMS OF THE ISSUE, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE ISSUE AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THE PRE-ISSUE AND PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT DATED OCTOBER 14, 2026, AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES / REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE ISSUE ("BRLMs").

In accordance with the recommendations of the Committee of Independent Directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated October 14, 2026, the above Price Band is justified based on quantitative factors /KPIs disclosed in the 'Basis for Issue Price' section on page 126 of the RHP vis-à-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary issuances / secondary transactions as disclosed in 'Basis for Issue Price' section on page 126 of the RHP and provided below in the advertisement and other relevant factors.

RISK TO INVESTORS

For details refer to the section titled "Risk Factors" section on page 30 of the RHP.

1. **Risk relating to telecommunication license and spectrum:** The unified licence for providing telecom services held by Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited ("RJIL") across circles in India is due for renewal in October 2033. Further, the spectrum held by RJIL is valid for a period of 20 years with the majority of the spectrum expiring between 2041 and 2042. Any inability to maintain or renew such licences or to successfully bid for any spectrum required for our operations, could have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.

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2. **Dependence on Reliance Industries Limited, Reliance Retail Limited and other Reliance Group entities:** The Company and its subsidiaries have entered into various non-exclusive agreements with the Promoter, Reliance Retail Limited, a subsidiary of the Promoter and other Reliance Group entities for certain key aspects of the business. Disruption of these arrangements could significantly impact our business, financial condition and results of operations. The following table provides an overview of our significant transactions with the Promoter, Reliance Retail Limited and Sanmina-SCI India Private Limited, for the periods/Fiscals indicated.

Particulars	Parent[1]/ fellow subsidiary / joint venture of the Parent	Three months ended June 30,		Fiscal		
		2026	2025	2026	2025	2024
		(in ₹ million, unless otherwise indicated)				
Purchase of Property, Plant and Equipment and Other Intangible Assets	Parent[1] (A)	19,440	14,237	39,040	37,099	62,246
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (B = A/U)	46.46%	11.82%	11.42%	8.38%	11.63%
	Reliance Retail Limited (C)	750	2,352	5,867	14,720	9,458
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (D = C/ U)	1.79%	1.95%	1.72%	3.33%	1.77%
	Sanmina-SCI India Private Limited (E)	414	192	5,339	5,190	1,107
	As a percentage of Cash Capex (F = E/ U)	0.99%	0.16%	1.56%	1.17%	0.21%
Revenue from Operations	Parent[1] (G)	9,322	7,972	36,442	35,997	35,449
	As a percentage of Revenue from Operations (H = G/ V)	2.38%	2.28%	2.48%	2.81%	3.24%
	Reliance Retail Limited (I)	3,001	4,279	16,374	10,416	7,244
	As a percentage of Revenue from Operations (J = I/ V)	0.77%	1.22%	1.11%	0.81%	0.66%
Revenue Received in Advance[2]	Reliance Retail Limited	292,480	271,663	1,129,351	1,023,958	890,587
Professional Fees	Parent[1] (K)	5,797	7,520	26,254	29,614	23,364
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (L = K/ W)	1.95%	2.88%	2.40%	3.14%	2.87%
	Reliance Retail Limited (M)	1,082	3,232	7,671	6,730	4,601
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (N = M/ W)	0.36%	1.24%	0.70%	0.71%	0.57%
Network Operating Expenses	Parent[1] (O)	3,131	4,312	18,761	15,807	15,388
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (P = O/ W)	1.05%	1.65%	1.71%	1.68%	1.89%
Selling and Distribution Expenses	Parent[1] (Q)	-	-	-	6,299	9,449
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (R = Q/ W)	-	-	-	0.67%	1.16%
	Reliance Retail Limited (S)	10,527	11,858	43,551	35,158	30,008
	As a percentage of Total Expenses (T = S/ W)	3.54%	4.54%	3.98%	3.73%	3.69%
Cash Capex[3] (U)		41,838	120,481	341,843	442,680	535,096
Revenue from Operations (V)		391,729	350,323	1,468,853	1,282,184	1,095,581
Total Expenses (W)		297,708	261,350	1,094,060	942,057	813,674

Notes:

(1) *Parent, in this table, means the Promoter.*

(2) *Recharge vouchers sold to Reliance Retail Limited are accounted as 'Advance against services' which is disclosed as a related party transaction under the head 'Revenue received in advance'. When Reliance Retail Limited or its distributor/ sub-distributor further sells the vouchers to our customers by way of recharge to the digital connectivity services, RJIL recognises such transfer as 'Deferred revenue' and thereafter, based on the type of tariff plan, it is accounted as operating revenues in the profit & loss account. In light of the above, revenue received in advance has not been presented as a percentage of revenue from operations.*

(3) *Cash Capex refers to the cash outflow towards expenditure for property, plant and equipment, spectrum and other intangible assets less proceeds from disposal of property, plant and equipment and other intangible assets.*

3. **Dependency on Reliance Retail Limited for distribution of prepaid connectivity services:** RJIL has a master distribution agreement and a master collection agreement with RRL. RRL is the sole distributor of our pre-paid connectivity services. Our revenue from pre-paid connectivity services constituted 76.37%, 77.88%, 77.08%, 78.57% and 79.35% of our consolidated Revenue from Operations for the three months period ended June 30, 2026, June 30, 2025 and Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Any disruption in this relationship or distribution channel could adversely impact our business, financial condition and results of operations. The following table provides the details of the Revenue Received in Advance attributed to the above arrangement with RRL:

Particulars	Three months ended / As of June 30		Fiscal / As of March 31		
	2026	2025	2026	2025	2024
	(in ₹ millions)				
Revenue Received in Advance	292,480	271,663	1,129,351	1,023,958	890,587

4. **Dependency on RJIL that contributes significantly to our Revenue from Operations, EBITDA and PAT and KPIs relating to digital connectivity services:** RJIL contributed significantly to our Revenue from Operations, EBITDA and PAT in periods / Fiscals as indicated below:

Fiscals / period	RJIL's revenue from operations (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated Revenue from Operations	RJIL's EBITDA (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated EBITDA	RJIL's profit after tax (in ₹ million)	% of our consolidated PAT
Three months ended June 30, 2026	342,121	87.34%	195,904	93.89%	71,669	92.31%
Three months ended June 30, 2025	308,821	88.15%	173,013	95.40%	67,110	94.39%
Fiscal 2026	1,288,714	87.74%	723,544	94.88%	281,732	93.76%
Fiscal 2025	1,141,413	89.02%	612,334	95.42%	247,948	94.97%
Fiscal 2024	1,001,194	91.38%	528,784	96.21%	204,656	95.53%

Note: The financial information of RJIL provided above is on a standalone basis.

Any material adverse impact on the business, financial conditions or results of operations of RJIL would have a corresponding material adverse impact on our consolidated business, financial condition and results of operations. Further, while we operate as a technology platform, our key operational indicators ("KPIs") are primarily pertaining to our digital connectivity services provided by RJIL and do not reflect the technology platform specific metrics. Our competitors may perform more favourably on certain operational or financial KPIs, which could affect our competitive position. For details of comparison of the KPIs of our Company with listed peers, see *"Basis for Issue Price - Comparison of KPIs with Listed Industry Peers"* on page 135 of the RHP.

5. **Network, Infrastructure and Service Disruption Risk:** The uninterrupted performance, reliability and availability of our network, passive infrastructure, technology, products and services are critical to our operations and our ability to consistently deliver our digital services. Any disruption to our network, passive infrastructure and technology could impair our ability to ensure consistent performance and deliver uninterrupted customer experience, which could have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations, and could lead to increased churn in our customer base.

6. **Risk related to Technology change:** The connectivity industry is subject to rapid and continuous technological change, and our connectivity infrastructure faces the risk of technological obsolescence. If we are unable to respond to changes in technologies, including for instance, more competitive satellite-based broadband services and the evolving demands of our customers, we may face technological obsolescence, which would have a material adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.

7. **Risk relating to negative publicity of 'Jio' Brand:** The "Jio" trademark is owned by the Promoter, and we do not control the use of this trademark by other companies in the Reliance Group. Negative publicity arising from actions outside its control, inability to protect intellectual property or infringement claims could have a material adverse impact on our reputation, business, financial condition and results of operations.

8. **Dependency on a limited group of passive infrastructure service providers:** We rely on a limited set of passive infrastructure service providers for our operations. For instance, of the 360,537 Network Towers used by us for our operations, 174,451 Network Towers are owned by Summit Digitel Infrastructure Limited, as of June 30, 2026. Additionally, as of June 30, 2026, we rely on Jio Digital Fibre Private Limited, for substantially all our optic fibre network requirements (approximately 98%), aside from the last mile fibre network which is owned by RJIL. Any disruption in the availability of these passive infrastructure assets could have an adverse impact on our business, financial condition and results of operations.

9. **Cybersecurity, Data Privacy and Information Security Risk:** Our systems, platforms, network infrastructure, and the services provided by our Promoter and third-party technology partners are exposed to cybersecurity threats, security breaches, operational disruptions, and other technology-related risks. Any such incident or disruption could impair our operations, compromise data security, increase costs, expose us to regulatory and legal liabilities, and adversely affect our business, results of operations, financial condition, and reputation.

10. **Artificial Intelligence ("AI") and Machine Learning ("ML") Technologies Related Risk:** We rely on AI and ML technologies across our operations, including for network automation through our proprietary JioBrain platform, customer engagement and service delivery. The deployment of AI and ML technologies across our operations may not yield the desired results. Further, reliance on AI/ML technologies may expose us to inherent risks pertaining to algorithmic bias and model errors leading to inaccurate or biased outputs, which may cause reputational harm and adversely impact our business, financial condition and results of operations.

11. Our Price/Earning (P/E) ratio based on diluted EPS for Financial Year 2026 at the upper end of the price band is 33.31 as compared to the average industry peer group P/E ratio of 22.35, as of October 13, 2026.

12. Weighted Average Return on Average Net Worth for Financial Year ended 2026, 2025 and 2024 is 9.04%. Return on Average Net Worth for the three months ended June 30, 2026, and June 30, 2025 is 2.30% and 2.31% respectively (unannualized).

13. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all Equity Shares transacted in one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the RHP:

Period	Weighted average cost of Acquisition (in ₹)	Cap Price is 'X' times the weighted average cost of acquisition#	Range of acquisition price per Equity Shares: lowest price - highest price (in ₹)
Last one year / 18 months/ 3 years	N.A.	N.A.	N.A.

#As certified by D T S & Associates LLP, Chartered Accountants (FRN 142412W/W100595), by way of their certificate dated October 14, 2026, (UDIN 26136433YFEPPE7981).

Note: No Equity Shares were transacted in the last one year, 18 months and three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus.

14. The 19 BRLMs associated with the Issue have handled 160 public issues in the past three years, out of which 46 issues have closed below the issue price on the listing date

Book Running Lead Managers	Total public issues	Issues closed below issue price listing date
Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited*	-	-
Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited*	-	-
BofA Securities India Limited*	-	-
Axis Capital Limited*	2	-
BNP Paribas*	-	-
Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited*	-	-
CLSA India Private Limited*	-	-
DAM Capital Advisors Limited*	8	2
Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited*	-	-
HDFC Bank Limited*	-	-
HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited*	-	-
ICICI Securities Limited*	5	2
IIFL Capital Services Limited *(formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited)* *	5	1
Jefferies India Private Limited*	-	-
JM Financial Limited*	3	-
J.P. Morgan India Private Limited*	-	-
SBI Capital Markets Limited*	6	4
UBS Securities India Private Limited*	-	-
360 ONE WAM Limited*	-	-
Common issues handled by the BRLMs	131	37
TOTAL	**160**	**46**

** Issues handled where there were no common BRLMs*

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ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS

1. The Company has not undertaken any pre-IPO placement from the date of filing the DRHP till date.
2. The Promoter and the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of Equity Shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company from the date of filing the DRHP till date.
3. For the pre-Issue and post-Issue equity shareholding of the Promoter, Promoter Group and top 10 public Shareholders, refer to the section titled 'Capital Structure' on page 99 of the RHP.

BASIS FOR ISSUE PRICE

(You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Kotak Mahindra Capital Company)

*(The **"Basis for Issue Price"** section on page no. 126 of the RHP has been updated with the above price band. Please refer to the websites of the BRLMs: https://investmentbank.kotak.com, https://www.morganstanley.com/india, https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia, www.axiscapital.co.in, www.bnpparibas.co.in, www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking, www.india.clsa.com, www.damcapital.in, www.goldmansachs.com, www.hdfc.bank.in, www.business.hsbc.co.in, www.icicisecurities.com, www.iiflcapital.com, www.jefferies.com, www.jmfl.com, www.jpmipl.com, www.sbicaps.com, www.ubs.com/indiaoffers and www.360.one for the "Basis for Issue Price" section updated with the above price band)*

AN INDICATIVE TIMETABLE IN RESPECT OF THE ISSUE IS SET OUT BELOW:

Submission of Bids (other than Bids from Anchor Investors)

Particulars	Time
Bid/ Issue Period (except the Bid/ Issue Closing Date)	
Submission and revision in Bids	Only between 9:00 a.m. and 7:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time ("IST"))
Bid/ Issue Closing Date*^	
Submission of electronic applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) – For RIIs, other than QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors, Eligible Employees Bidding in Employee Reservation Portion and Eligible RIL Shareholders Bidding in RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Bank ASBA through online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications where Bid Amount is up to ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual applications for bids beyond ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 1:00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Syndicate Non-Retail, Non-Individual applications of QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors where Bid Amount is more than ₹ 500,000)	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 1:00 p.m. IST
Modification/ Revision/ cancellation of Bids	
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors categories#	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Issue Closing Date
Upward or downward revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by RIIs, Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion and Eligible RIL Shareholders Bidding in RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion	Only between 9:00 a.m. and up to 7:00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Issue Closing Date

** UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 7:00 p.m. IST on the Bid/ Issue Closing Date.*

QIBs and Non-Institutional Investors can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/ withdraw their Bids.

BID/ISSUE PERIOD

Event	Indicative Date
Anchor Investor Bidding	Monday, October 19, 2026
Bid/Issue Opens on	Wednesday, October 21, 2026
Bid/Issue Closes on	Friday, October 23, 2026
Finalization of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Monday, October 26, 2026
Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors) / unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Tuesday, October 27, 2026
Credit of Equity Shares to dematerialized accounts of Allottees	On or about Tuesday, October 27, 2026
Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Wednesday, October 28, 2026

**In case of (i) any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) for cancelled / withdrawn / deleted ASBA Forms, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date on which the request for cancellation/ withdrawal/ deletion is placed in the Stock Exchanges bidding platform until the date on which the amounts are unblocked; (ii) any blocking of multiple amounts for the same ASBA Form (for amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism), the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the total cumulative blocked amount except the original application amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such multiple amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iii) any blocking of amounts more than the Bid Amount, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the difference in amount, whichever is higher from the date on which such excess amounts were blocked till the date of actual unblock; (iv) any delay in unblocking of non-allotted/ partially allotted Bids, exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/ Issue Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹ 100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/ Issue Closing Date by the SCSB responsible for causing such delay in unblocking. The BRLMs shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. The post Issue BRLMs shall be liable for compensating the Bidder at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher from the date of receipt of the investor grievance until the date on which the blocked amounts are unblocked. The Bidder shall be compensated in the manner specified in the ICDR Master Circular, and the SEBI RTA Master Circular, which for the avoidance of doubt, shall be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs, to the extent applicable.*

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/ Issue Period will be extended by at least three additional Working Days after such revision in the Price Band, subject to the Bid/ Issue Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of force majeure, banking strike or similar unforeseen circumstances, our Company in consultation with the BRLMs, may, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/ Issue Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/ Issue Period not exceeding 10 Working Days in compliance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. Any revision in the Price Band and the revised Bid/ Issue Period, if applicable, shall be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the respective websites of the BRLMs and at the terminals of the Syndicate Members and by intimation to the Self-Certified Syndicate Banks ("**SCSBs**"), other Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Bank(s), as applicable. However, in case of revision in the Price Band, the Bid Lot shall remain the same.

The Issue is being made through the Book Building Process, in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the SCRR read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations and in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations, wherein not more than 50% of the Net Issue shall be allocated on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("**QIBs**") ("**QIB Portion**"), provided that our Company, in consultation with the Book Running Lead Managers may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations ("**Anchor Investor Portion**"), and 40% of such Anchor Investor Portion shall be reserved as under: (i) 33.33% for domestic Mutual Funds, and (ii) 6.67% for Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds, subject to valid Bids being received from domestic Mutual Funds, Life Insurance Companies and Pension Funds at or above the Anchor Investor Allocation Price. In the event of under-subscription, or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the QIB Portion ("**Net QIB Portion**"). Further, 5% of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price, and the remainder of the Net QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIBs, including Mutual Funds subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the Net QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in the Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining Net QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to all QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Net Issue shall be available for allocation to Non- Institutional Bidders and not less than 35% of the Net Issue shall be available for allocation to Retail Individual Bidders ("**RIBs**") in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. One-third of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹ 200,000 and up to ₹ 1,000,000 and two-thirds of the Non-Institutional Portion shall be available for allocation to Non-Institutional Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹ 1,000,000 provided that under-subscription in either of these two sub-categories of the Non-Institutional Portion may be allocated to Non-Institutional Bidders in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Portion in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Issue Price. Further, Equity Shares will be allocated on a proportionate basis to Eligible Employees Bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion, and Eligible Shareholders Bidding in the RIL Shareholders Reservation Portion subject to valid Bids received from them at or above the Issue Price. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are mandatorily required to participate in the Issue through the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("**ASBA**") process by providing details of their respective ASBA accounts and UPI ID in case of UPI Bidders, as applicable, pursuant to which their corresponding Bid Amount will be blocked by the Self Certified Syndicate Banks ("**SCSBs**") or by the Sponsor Bank(s) under the UPI Mechanism, as the case may be, to the extent of the respective Bid Amounts. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Issue through the ASBA process. For details, see *"Issue Procedure"* beginning on page 534 of the RHP.

Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) are correctly filled in the Bid cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID available in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/ Applicants should ensure that the beneficiary account provided in the Bid cum Application Form is active. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorised the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Issue, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic Details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Issue. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders'/Applicants' sole risk. Investors must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhaar and are in compliance with the CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 and press release dated June 25, 2021, read with press release dated September 17, 2021 and CBDT circular no.7 of 2022, dated March 30, 2022 read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press releases in this regard.

Contents of the Memorandum of Association of our Company as regards its objects: For information on the main objects of our Company, please see the section *"History and Certain Corporate Matters"* on page 249 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Issue. For further details, please see the section titled *"Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection"* on page 577 of the RHP.

Liability of the members of our Company: Limited by shares.

Amount of share capital of our Company and capital structure: As on the date of the RHP, the authorised share capital of our Company is ₹1,900,000,000,000 divided into 10,000,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each and 180,000,000,000 preference shares of face value of ₹10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up Equity share capital of our Company is ₹89,390,308,300 divided into 8,939,030,830 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each. For more details of the capital structure of the Company, see "Capital Structure" beginning on page 99 of the RHP.

Names of the initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company and the Number of Equity Shares Subscribed by them: The initial signatories to the Memorandum of Association of the Company is Reliance Industries Limited (including one Equity Share each allotted to six individuals as nominees of RIL) (10,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each). For more details of the share capital history of our Company please see "Capital Structure" beginning on page 99 of the RHP.

Listing: The Equity Shares offered through the RHP are proposed to be listed on the Stock Exchanges. Our Company has received 'in-principle' approvals from BSE and NSE for the listing of the Equity Shares pursuant to their letters each dated July 7, 2026. For the purposes of the Issue, the Designated Stock Exchange shall be NSE. A signed copy of the RHP and the Prospectus has been and shall be delivered to the RoC, as applicable, in accordance with Sections 26(4) and 32 of the Companies Act, 2013. For details of the material contracts and documents available for inspection from the date of the Red Herring Prospectus up to the Bid/ Issue Closing Date, see "Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection" beginning on page 577 of the RHP.

Disclaimer clause of the SEBI: SEBI only gives its observations on the Issue documents and this does not constitute approval of either the Issue or the specified securities stated in the Issue document. The investors are advised to refer to page 488 of the RHP for the full text of the disclaimer clause of SEBI.

Disclaimer clause of NSE (Designated Stock Exchange): It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by NSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by NSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 493 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of NSE.

Disclaimer clause of BSE: It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by BSE should not in any way be deemed or construed that the RHP has been cleared or approved by BSE nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the RHP. The investors are advised to refer to page 493 of the RHP for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of BSE.

General risk: Investments in equity and equity-related securities involve a degree of risk and investors should not invest any funds in the Issue unless they can afford to take the risk of losing their entire investment. Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Issue. For taking an investment decision, investors must rely on their own examination of our Company and the Issue, including the risks involved. The Equity Shares in the Issue have not been recommended or approved by SEBI, nor does SEBI guarantee the accuracy or adequacy of the contents of the RHP. Specific attention of the investors is invited to "**Risk Factors**" beginning on page 30 of the RHP.

BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS

Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited
1st Floor, 27 BKC, Plot No. C27, 'G' Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East) , Mumbai - 400 051
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4336 0000
E-mail: jio.ipo@kotak.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: kmccredressal@kotak.com
Website: https://investmentbank.kotak.com
Contact Person: Ganesh Rane
SEBI Registration No.: INM000008704

Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited
Altimus, Level 39 & 40
Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 018
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6118 1000
E-mail: jpl_ipo@morganstanley.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investors_india@morganstanley.com
Website: https://www.morganstanley.com/india
Contact Person: Keyur Thakar/ Hrithik Khanna
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011203

BofA Securities India Limited
Ground Floor, "A" Wing, One BKC, "G" Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6632 8000
E-mail: dg.jpl_ipo@bofa.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: dg.india_merchantbanking@bofa.com
Website: https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia
Contact Person: Sahil H. Jain
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011625

Axis Capital Limited
1st Floor, Axis House
P.B. Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4325 2183
E-mail: jio.ipo@axiscap.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: complaints@axiscap.in
Website: www.axiscapital.co.in
Contact Person: Sanaea Sumondy/ Simran Gadh
SEBI Registration No: INM000012029

BNP Paribas
1, North Avenue Maker Maxity
Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400 051
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 3370 4000
E-mail: LIST.CIB.JioIPO@asia.bnpparibas.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: indiainvestors.care@asia.bnpparibas.com
Website: www.bnpparibas.co.in
Contact Person: Ankur Thacker
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011534

Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited
1202, 12th Floor, First International Financial Center, G Block
Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 098
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6175 9999
E-mail: jio.ipo@citi.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investors.cgmib@citi.com
Website: www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking
Contact Person: Naman Kulshreshtha
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010718

CLSA India Private Limited
8/F Dalamal House
Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6650 5050
E-mail: jio.ipo@clsa.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investor.helpdesk@clsa.com
Website: www.india.clsa.com
Contact Person: Prachi Chandgothia
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010619

DAM Capital Advisors Limited
Altimus 2202, Level 22
Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 018
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4202 2500
E-mail: jio.ipo@damcapital.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: complaint@damcapital.in
Website: www.damcapital.in
Contact Person: Aanchal Wagle/ Jay Shah
SEBI Registration No.: MB/INM000011336

Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited
9th and 10th Floor, Ascent-Worli
Sudam Kalu Ahire Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6616 9000
E-mail: joipo@gs.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: india-client-support@gs.com
Website: www.goldmansachs.com
Contact Person: Saurav S
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011054

HDFC Bank Limited
Investment Banking Group
Unit no. 701, 702 and 702-A, 7th Floor, Tower 2 and 3
One International Centre, Senapati Bapat Marg, Prabhadevi
Mumbai - 400 013, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 3395 8233
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@hdfc.bank.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: investor.redressal@hdfcbank.com
Website: www.hdfc.bank.in
Contact Person: Bharti Ranga/ Souradeep Ghosh
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011252

HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited
52/60, Mahatma Gandhi Road, Fort, Mumbai - 400 001
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6864 1289
E-mail: jplipo@hsbc.co.in
Investor Grievance E-mail: investorgrievance@hsbc.co.in
Website: www.business.hsbc.co.in
Contact Person: Harsh Thakkar/ Harshit Tayal
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010353

ICICI Securities Limited
Appasaheb Marathe Marg, Prabhadevi, Mumbai - 400 025
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6807 7100
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@icicisecurities.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: customercare@icicisecurities.com
Website: www.icicisecurities.com
Contact Person: Ramesh Vaswana / Soumavo Sarkar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011179

IIFL Capital Services Limited
(formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited)
24th Floor, One Lodha Place
Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel (West), Mumbai - 400 013
Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4646 4728
E-mail: jio.ipo@iiflcap.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: ig.ib@iiflcap.com
Website: www.iiflcapital.com
Contact Person: Gaurav Mittal/ Pawan Kumar Jain
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010940

Jefferies India Private Limited
Level 16, Express Towers
Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4356 6000
E-mail: Jio.Platforms.IPO@jefferies.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: jipl.grievance@jefferies.com
Website: www.jefferies.com
Contact Person: Akshat Shah/ Meghna Biju
SEBI Registration No.: INM000011443

JM Financial Limited
7th Floor, Cnergy, Appasaheb Marathe Marg
Prabhadevi, Mumbai - 400 025, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6630 3030
E-mail: jpl.ipo@jmfl.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: grievance.ibd@jmfl.com
Website: www.jmfl.com
Contact Person: Prachee Dhuri
SEBI Registration No.: INM000010361

J.P. Morgan India Private Limited
J.P. Morgan Towers
Off C.S.T Road, Kalina, Santacruz (East),
Mumbai - 400 098 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6157 3000
E-mail: JIO_IPO@jpmorgan.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investorsmb.jpmipl@jpmorgan.com
Website: www.jpmipl.com
Contact Person: Shivam Goel/ Rishank Chheda
SEBI Registration No.: INM000002970

SBI Capital Markets Limited
1501, 15th Floor, A & B Wing, G Block,
Parinee Crescenzo, Bandra Kurla Complex,
Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 051 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4006 9807
E-mail: jio.ipo@sbicaps.com
Website: www.sbicaps.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: investor.relations@sbicaps.com
Contact Person: Krithika Shetty/ Prashant Patankar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000003531

UBS Securities India Private Limited
Unit 2901, Level 29, Altimus,
Dr. GM Gokhale Marg /
Pandurang Budhkar Road,
Worli, Mumbai - 400 018, Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 6155 6000
E-mail: OL-jioipo@ubs.com
Website: www.ubs.com/indiaoffers
Investor Grievance E-mail: igbmindia@ubs.com
Contact Person: Vidhit Patni
SEBI Registration No.: INM000013101

360 ONE WAM Limited
360 ONE Centre, Kamala City
Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel (West),
Mumbai - 400 013 Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 4031 7000
Email: jioplatforms.ipo@360.one
Investor Grievance E-mail: mbinvestorcomplaints@360.one
Website: www.360.one
Contact Person: Devesh Patkar
SEBI Registration No.: INM000012801

REGISTRAR TO THE ISSUE

KFin Technologies Limited
Selenium Tower-B, Plot No. 31 & 32, Gachibowli,
Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally
Hyderabad - 500 032, Telangana, India
Tel: + 91 40 6716 2222/ 1800 309 4001
E-mail: jioplatforms.ipo@kfintech.com
Investor Grievance E-mail: einward.ris@kfintech.com
Website: www.kfintech.com
Contact Person: Williams R
SEBI Registration No.: INR000000221

Company Secretary
Ms. Savithri Parekh

Compliance Officer
Mr. Venkataraman Ramachandran

TC-22, 5th Floor, A Wing, Reliance Corporate Park,
Thane Belapur Road, Ghansoli,
Navi Mumbai 400 701Maharashtra, India
Tel: +91 22 7967 0000
E-mail: jpl.investorrelations@jio.com

Investors may contact the Company Secretary or Compliance Officer or the Registrar to the Issue in case of any pre-Issue or post-Issue related grievances including non-receipt of letters of Allotment, non-credit of Allotted Equity Shares in the respective beneficiary account, non-receipt of refund orders or non-receipt of funds by electronic mode, etc. For all Issue related queries and for redressal of complaints, investors may also write to the BRLMs.

Continued on next page...

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AVAILABILITY OF THE RHP:

Investors are advised to refer to the RHP and the section titled **"Risk Factors"** on page 30 of the RHP, before applying in the Issue. A copy of the RHP is made available on website of SEBI at **www.sebi.gov.in**, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at **www.bseindia.com** and **www.nseindia.com**, respectively, and on the website of the Company at **https://www.jio.com**; and on the websites of the BRLMs, i.e. **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited** – https://investmentbank.kotak.com; **Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited** – https://www.morganstanley.com/india; **BofA Securities India Limited** – https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia; **Axis Capital Limited** – www.axiscapital.co.in; **BNP Paribas** – www.bnpparibas.co.in; **Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited** – www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking; **CLSA India Private Limited** – www.india.clsa.com; **DAM Capital Advisors Limited** – www.damcapital.in; **Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited** – www.goldmansachs.com; **HDFC Bank Limited** – www.hdfc.bank.in; **HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited** – www.business.hsbc.co.in; **ICICI Securities Limited** – www.icicisecurities.com; **IIFL Capital Services Limited** – www.iiflcapital.com; **Jefferies India Private Limited** – www.jefferies.com; **JM Financial Limited** – www.jmfl.com; **J.P. Morgan India Private Limited** – www.jpmipl.com; **SBI Capital Markets Limited** – www.sbicaps.com; **UBS Securities India Private Limited** – www.ubs.com/indiaoffers; **360 ONE WAM Limited** – www.360.one;.

AVAILABILITY OF THE ABRIDGED PROSPECTUS:

A copy of the abridged prospectus is made available on the website of the Company, the BRLMs and the Registrar to the Issue at **https://www.jio.com/platforms/** ; **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited** – https://investmentbank.kotak.com; **Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited** – https://www.morganstanley.com/india; **BofA Securities India Limited** – https://business.bofa.com/bofasindia; **Axis Capital Limited** – www.axiscapital.co.in; **BNP Paribas** – www.bnpparibas.co.in; **Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited** – www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/global-presence/india/regulatory-disclosures-investment-banking; **CLSA India Private Limited** – www.india.clsa.com; **DAM Capital Advisors Limited** – www.damcapital.in; **Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited** – www.goldmansachs.com; **HDFC Bank Limited** – www.hdfc.bank.in; **HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited** – www.business.hsbc.co.in; **ICICI Securities Limited** – www.icicisecurities.com; **IIFL Capital Services Limited** – www.iiflcapital.com; **Jefferies India Private Limited** – www.jefferies.com; **JM Financial Limited** – www.jmfl.com; **J.P. Morgan India Private Limited** – www.jpmipl.com; **SBI Capital Markets Limited** – www.sbicaps.com; **UBS Securities India Private Limited** – www.ubs.com/indiaoffers; **360 ONE WAM Limited** – www.360.one; Registrar to the Issue, **KFin Technologies Limited** – www.kfintech.com , respectively.

AVAILABILITY OF BID CUM APPLICATION FORMS:

Bid cum Application Forms can be obtained from the Registered and Corporate Office of **JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED**, **Tel:** +91 22 7967 0000; BRLMs: **Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4336 0000; **Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6118 1000; **BofA Securities India Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6632 8000; **Axis Capital Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4325 2183; **BNP Paribas,** Telephone: +91 22 3370 4000; **Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6175 9999; **CLSA India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6650 5050; **DAM Capital Advisors Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4202 2500; **Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6616 9000; **HDFC Bank Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 3395 8233; **HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6864 1289; **ICICI Securities Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6807 7100; **IIFL Capital Services Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4646 4728; **Jefferies India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4356 6000; **JM Financial Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6630 3030; **J.P. Morgan India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6157 3000; **SBI Capital Markets Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4006 9807; **UBS Securities India Private Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 6155 6000; **and 360 ONE WAM Limited,** Telephone: +91 22 4031 7000; **Syndicate Members: HDFC Securities Limited** Tel: +91 2230753400, **Investec Capital Services (India) Private Limited** Tel: + 91 2268497400, **JM Financial Services Limited** Tel: +91 22 6136 3400, **Kotak Securities Limited** Tel: +91 2242858484, **SBICAP Securities Limited** Tel: +91 22 6943 2521, **Sharekhan Limited** Tel: +91 22 6750 2000, **360 ONE Capital Market Private Limited** ***(Formerly known as Batlivala & Karani Securities India Private Limited)*** Tel: + 91 022 40317000 / +91 022 40076000 **and 360 ONE Distribution Services Limited** Tel: 9321332882 and at the select locations of the Sub-syndicate Members (as given below), SCSBs, Registered Brokers, RTAs and CDPs participating in the Issue. Bid cum Application Forms will also be available on the websites of BSE and NSE and the Designated Branches of SCSBs, the list of which is available at websites of the Stock Exchanges and SEBI.

Sub-Syndicate Members:

Almondz Global Securities Ltd, Ambit Capital Limited, Ambit Private Limited, Amrapali Capital & Finance Services Limited, Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Anand Share Consultancy, ANS Pvt Limited, Asit C Mehta Financial Services Limited, Asit C Mehta Investment Intermediates Limited, Axis Securities Limited, Bajaj Financial Securities Limited, Bob Capital Markets Limited, Centrum Broking Limited, Centrum Capital Advisors Limited, Centrum Finverse limited, Centrum Wealth Management Ltd, Choice Equity Broking Private Limited, Dalal & Broacha Stock Broking Pvt Limited, DB(International) Stock Brokers Ltd, Eureka Stock & Share Broking Services Ltd, G Raj & Co. (Consultants) Limited, Globe Capital Market Limited, IDBI Capital Market Services Limited, Inga Ventures Pvt Ltd, Innovate Securities Pvt Limited, Intensive Fiscal Services Private Limited, Jhaveri Securities, Jobanputra Fiscal Services Private Limited, Kalpataru Multiplier Limited, Kantilal Chhaganlal Securities Pvt Ltd, Keynote Capitals Limited, KJMC Capital Market Services Limited, Lakshmishree Investment & Securities Pvt Limited, LKP Securities Limited, Marwadi Shares & Finance Ltd, Mehta Equities Limited, Monarch Networth Capital Limited, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Limited, Motilal Oswal Securities Limited, Nextbillion Technology Private Limited, Nirmal Bang Securities Pvt Limited, Nuvama Wealth and Investment Limited (Edelweiss Broking Limited), Nuvama Wealth Management Limited, Pantomath Financial Services Limited, Patel Wealth Advisors Pvt Limited, Paytm, Prabhudas Lilladher Pvt Limited, Pravin Ratilal Share & Stock Brokers Limited, Religare Broking Limited, Religare Securities Limited, Rikhav Securities Ltd, RR Equity Brokers Private Limited, SMC Global Securities Limited, Standard Chartered Securities, Sundae Capital, Sunidhi Securities & Finance Ltd, Sushil Financial Services Pvt. Ltd., Systematix Shares & Stocks (India) Limited, Tanna Financial Services, Tradebulls Securities Private Limited, Trust Securities Limited, Viren M Shah, YES Securities (India) Limited, Zerodha

Escrow Collection Banks: Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited

Refund Banks: Axis Bank Limited and ICICI Bank Limited

Public Issue Account Banks: Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and State Bank of India

Sponsor Banks: Axis Bank Limited, ICICI Bank Limited, Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited and State Bank of India

UPI: UPI Bidders can also bid through UPI mechanism

Jio Platforms Limited has provided a toll free number to address any queries related to the Issue.

Toll free number: 1800 309 4001

You may also address your queries related to the Issue by typing **'Hi'** or **'Hello'** on

WhatsApp to 7977222222

For JIO PLATFORMS LIMITED
On behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-
Ms. Savithri Parekh
Company Secretary

Place : Mumbai, Maharashtra
Date : October 21, 2026

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them In the RHP.

Jio Platforms Limited is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC on October 14, 2026. The RHP is made available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, i.e. BSE at www.bseindia.com and NSE at www.nseindia.com, on the website of the Company at www.jio.com and on the respective websites of the BRLMs. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk, and for details relating to such risk, please see the section titled **"Risk Factors"** on page 30 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment decision and should instead rely on the RHP, as filed with the RoC, for making investment decisions.

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INDIA, U.S. ALSO HOLD TRILATERAL MEETING WITH UAE MINISTER

Trade deal close, says Rubio, asks India to scale up purchase of US tech, energy

India a 'refining superpower', says US Secy of State, meets Jaishankar

Shubhajit Roy
Mumbai, October 20

AS INDIA and the US look to finalise their trade deal, stalled by tensions over American tariffs and India's purchase of Russian oil, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar sought to deepen energy and defence ties during their talks in Mumbai on Tuesday. Rubio said the two sides were "very, very close" on the trade deal, with a "small number of items to wrap up".

As the two sides re-affirmed the importance of advancing their strategic partnership, Rubio urged India to scale up energy trade and increase the purchase of American technologies and systems. This is significant since the US is looking at selling energy and defence equipment to meet its $500 billion trade target by 2030.

"We shared views on further advancement of our ties, focusing on trade, energy, technology, defence and people-to-people ties. Also exchanged views on regional developments," Jaishankar posted on X.

"In Mumbai, Indian External Affairs Minister @DrSJaishankar and I discussed energy security and defence cooperation while reaffirming the importance of advancing the US-India strategic partnership,"

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio at the 26/11 Memorial at the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel in Mumbai, Tuesday. PTI

Behind Jamnagar visit: Russia oil, RIL Texas refinery plan, Venezuela crude

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, October 20

US SECRETARY of State Marco Rubio will visit the world's largest single-location refinery complex — Reliance Industry Ltd's (RIL) twin refineries in Gujarat's Jamnagar — on Wednesday as part of his India trip. The Jamnagar visit — and likely meeting with RIL Chairman Mukesh Ambani — is being watched closely in connection with a range of energy related issues, given the Indian conglomerate's growing importance for the US in the current global environment.

On the table at Jamnagar could be RIL's planned investment in a new refinery project in Texas, the Donald Trump administration's efforts to secure fuel supplies amid global energy market turmoil ahead of the midterm polls in the US next month, the broader

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THE EDITORIAL PAGE
RUBIO IN JAMNAGAR, AND A CHANGING MAP OF THE NEW DIPLOMACY
PAGE 8

'99% work done (on trade deal)... tariffs and visa curbs not targeted at India'

Shubhajit Roy
Mumbai, October 20

SIGNALLING AN outreach towards India and seeking to assuage concerns, visiting US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Tuesday said the tariffs are not meant to "punish India" and the visa restrictions are "not targeted" at the country.

In an exclusive interview with *The Indian Express*, Rubio said the India-US trade deal is "incredibly close". The two countries have been holding negotiations for more than a year-and-a-half now.

"I think we're incredibly close. The way I would say it is, we are weeks, not months, away from, I think, finalising it. I think 99% of the work is done. The remaining factor, you have to have 100% done. But I feel very positive of the trajectory that it's on," he said.

"I don't want to get into the details of the sticking points. I can simply tell you that it's there. I won't call them technicalities, but it's language related. It's basically down to what certain words mean and what certain phrases mean," he said.

On the US's earlier decision to target countries importing Russian oil and gas with up to 100% tariffs — President Donald Trump announced a waiver last week — and whether it could affect economic ties, Rubio said: "I mean, it can. There's no doubt about it, and that's why it has to be managed. It has to be managed very carefully, and that's why the relationship we have is so critical. We certainly don't want to do things. None of these tariffs are done to punish or to harm India."

Speaking on the US administration's visa restrictions, he said, "We are trying to fix 20 years of neglect of an immigration system that was simply not being enforced, and that's not targeted at India."

Looking back at his almost two years as US Secretary of State, Rubio said India-US ties

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EXPRESS interview



MARCO RUBIO
U.S. SECRETARY OF STATE
PAGE 7

RSS CHIEF'S ADDRESS INSPIRATIONAL: PM

Bhagwat: Protests can be tool of political interests, storm from West targeting India

'They claim changing regime will change situation... that has never really happened'



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat in Nagpur, Tuesday. PTI

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, October 20

IN HIS Vijayadashami address Tuesday, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat called for vigilance against agitations that "seek to fan hatred for systems, ideologies and individuals" within the country.

Addressing the annual event in Nagpur, which marked the Sangh's 101st foundation day, Bhagwat accused global powers of trying to weaken India.

The RSS chief warned that disruptive protests could become tools of political interests and fuel divisions in society rather than providing solutions. "They claim that changing a regime will change the situation, but that has never really happened," he said.

Bhagwat's remarks came at a time when the Opposition parties and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led students and youths have held a series of protests in Delhi and other parts of the country against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi hailed Bhagwat's address, calling it "highly inspirational". In a post on X, Modi said the RSS chief spoke at length on a range of issues, including national progress, social unity,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

- **POLISH PM** Donald Tusk will begin his India trip.

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Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



THE BIG PICTURE
THE GREAT DESPERATION
A YEAR AFTER 104 INDIANS WERE DEPORTED P 12

Day after three Meiteis gunned down, Kuki-Zo man killed in Manipur

Jimmy Leivon
Imphal, October 20

A 45-YEAR-OLD Kuki-Zo man was shot dead while another man escaped unhurt when armed miscreants opened fire in a forested area between P Molding and Molhoi villages in Manipur's Kangpokpi district on Tuesday, police said.

The incident occurred around 8 am when the two men were travelling to the forested area to collect bamboo shoots.

The deceased was identified as Paolen Khongsai, a resident of P Molding village, while the survivor was identified as Laldenga.

Khongsai sustained fatal gunshot injuries and died on the spot, about 13 kilometres from Leimakhong police station, where a case has now been registered.

The incident comes a day after three Meitei men were killed and three others injured in an attack by suspected Kuki militants near Nongsum Hills in Imphal East district on Monday, raising fears of renewed violence between the two communities after a brief period of relative calm between them. The victims had gone to the forests to collect dried firewood

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Shops closed during a shutdown in Imphal, Tuesday. ANI



'Stand together in national interest'

Prime Minister Narendra Modi participates in Vijayadashami celebrations in New Delhi, Tuesday. PTI

THE PM said institutions and political parties should stand together in national interest. He urged citizens to adopt 'Nation First' pledge.

"WE MUST unite against enemies of the nation. Those forces that attack the honour and dignity of the country," he said.

FAITH IN our strength and proper use of resources the mantra for a self-reliant and developed India, he said. REPORT, P 5

Tiger Shroff shooting: Probe traces link of bike rider to gang led by Lawrence Bishnoi



An accused at Railway Colony Police Station in Kota, Tuesday. ANI

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, October 20

HRITHIK MAHTO alias Roshan, the 22-year-old who was among the three arrested for the attack on Tiger Shroff in Mumbai's Juhu, allegedly joined the Lawrence Bishnoi gang a year ago — and was deployed to assist the two shooters who fired five rounds at the Bollywood actor, police sources told *The Indian Express* citing preliminary probe findings.

Mahto was allegedly riding the motorcycle used in the attack on Sunday evening. He was arrested in Kota on Monday morning along with the two shooters — Phool Singh (18) and Rehan Rahisuddin (18). Hours after the attack,

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INSIDE PAGE 6
TWO WOMEN AMONG FOUR HELD IN DELHI

• LESS THAN 10% OF INTERNSHIP OPPORTUNITIES BEING FILLED UP

Two years later, PM internship revamp draws more youth, but quality gaps persist

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, October 20

•*Padma, 23, and from Vijayawada, didn't land a job despite an engineering degree. A friend told her about the PM Internship Scheme. A top IT company selected her in January 2025, and after a year's internship, she was absorbed.*

•*Sunil, 22, held a technical diploma from Ranchi and hoped PMIS would hone his skills. But a microfinance and rural banking company he interned with in 2025, put him on field work as a loan recovery agent. He left midway, and is still unemployed.*

PAGE 1 anchor

•*Mohit interned with a public sector oil refiner under Round I of the PMIS two years ago. He was given the task of visiting petrol pumps, but there was no other skills training. He left the internship after a month.*

EXPANDING THE scope of the Prime Minister Internship Scheme (PMIS) to MSMEs and sunrise sectors from top 500 companies, a near doubling of stipend to Rs 9,000, easing age and education criteria, and reducing the internship period to 6-9 months from 12 months earlier, has resulted in a sharp 67% to 100% increase in youth joining the scheme in the third round. The Round III, which was launched in April this year, will end in December.

Officials and industry executives, however, frame the challenge for the youth to take the internship offer seriously, complete it, imbibe skills and become employment ready. While over 40 per cent of the youth completed their internships in the first two rounds and some gained full-time jobs, there were many who didn't complete. Some of those who dropped out told *The Indian Express* that less focus on specialised skills or on-the-job training were the key reasons for leaving mid-way. But interns' experience in the manufacturing and IT sector was remarkably better.

Data available with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs shows that the joining rate — number of interns joining the scheme as against the total internship opportunities posted by companies — has improved to 9.5% in the ongoing Round III of the Scheme as against 6.1% and 6.9%, in Round II and Round I, respectively. The completion rate — number of interns completing the internship against the total number of interns joining — is still low i.e., 39.4% in Round II as against 42.6% in Round I. Round III is still ongoing and will get over in December.

Mohit, who interned with a public sector oil refiner under the first round two years ago, said he was assigned to go from one petrol pump to another and ask customers to make payments through the refiner's app for a cashback offer. "I was in the first year of my BBA course. I got to know about the PMIS through Instagram and joined it to learn some skills. But, there was no office work or skill training, just visits to petrol pumps. There was no knowledge or learning, so I dropped out," he said over a phone call from Lucknow.

Some others too faced similar experiences. Sunil, 22, a diploma holder in computer hardware maintenance from Ranchi, Jharkhand, had to make rounds as a loan agent in nearby villages. "I would have liked to learn some skills in the office as I have studied computer maintenance, but instead was assigned fieldwork for loan recovery. Village people wouldn't have money immediately to repay the loans and such visits would then take hours without any result. So I left," he said. Two other candidates said they got through other full-time job opportunities while pursuing the internship, or had personal reasons, and left midway.

For some candidates, the completion helped. Padma, who is an electronics and communication engineering graduate from Vijayawada, got a full-time job with the same IT major where she interned. The internship offered structured learning with four months of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM Internship Scheme since October 2024

	ROUND I	ROUND II	ROUND III
Internships opportunities posted by companies	1,27,508	1,18,948	1,54,366
Total applications	6,21,000	4,55,000	3,50,259
Number of companies that participated	280	327	340
Number of candidates who received offers	60,866	71,192	25,794
Joined	8,760	7,308	14,620**
Completed	3,731	2,880*	—

*Internships in Round II are ongoing *No internship has been completed in Round III ** data as on 06.08.2026

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Rubio

Rubio said on social media.

"The Secretary reiterated that increased energy trade with the United States can play a transformative role in diversifying India's supply chains while meeting its sizable consumer demand," a readout by the US State Department spokesperson said. "He also commended recent progress in bilateral defence and civil nuclear cooperation, and advocated for the increased purchase of US technologies and systems, which can enhance the security and prosperity of both our countries," it said.

"The Secretary and Minister discussed regional and global issues, including developments in the Middle East," it said, in a reference to the war between the US and Iran, which has been going on for eight months now, creating an energy crisis across the world including in India.

"The two sides reviewed the entire gamut of India-US relations and discussed ways to further strengthen the Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in its statement.

"Both sides had a detailed exchange of views on a wide range of areas, including trade, defence, technology and energy security. They welcomed the progress made in negotiations on the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) and reaffirmed their commitment to working towards its early conclusion," it said.

"The visit reflected the sustained momentum of high-level exchanges between the two countries, underscoring the importance both sides attach to further advancing the India-US COMPACT (Catalysing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce & Technology) for the 21st century," it said.

Later, Jaishankar and Rubio also met UAE's Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah Bin Zayed Al Nahyan. "Held a trilateral meeting... A useful exchange of perspectives on energy, connectivity and contemporary developments," Jaishankar posted on X. They discussed "regional energy security and advanced... shared economic priorities."

Jaishankar also participated as the chief guest at the US 'Freedom 250' reception hosted by the US Ambassador.

"Productive discussions between @SecRubio and External Affairs Minister @DrSJaishankar on deepening US-India cooperation across defence, energy, emerging technologies and trade, as we continue to build the unrivaled momentum in our bilateral partnership," US Ambassador Sergio Gor said on X.

Speaking to reporters in Mumbai on the India-US trade agreement, Rubio said: "Obviously, the State Department doesn't negotiate trade agreements, but we are very much involved in what's happening. In my perch as National Security Advisor, we care a lot about it. We're very, very close. I would say we're about as close as you can be without having executed the agreement... I think there's a small number of items to wrap up, so I think that will happen shortly — we're hoping, it should. And hopefully, I've got some good news to announce fairly soon, and perhaps... can sign it thereafter... we feel very optimistic that we will have something in place here very soon."

On India's import of energy from Russia, he said, "India has expressed repeatedly its desire to diversify its energy portfolio, which is a smart thing to do. It's not easy to do that from one day to the next... I think they've made some substantial progress in that regard, and we're happy to see that. But in the end, it's not just about Russian oil; it's about India's desire to diversify, and we think we can be a source of some of its energy inputs. We have discussed Venezuela and other countries, and I think it's in our interest to have strong allies with diverse energy portfolios."

On Monday, days after the US signed a diesel purchase deal with Russia and announced a pause on the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, Rubio said the decision to waive Russia oil sanctions also took into account the India-US trade deal.

Asked about India's possible role in meeting the world's energy demands and whether Indian companies can refine more Venezuelan crude, Rubio on Tuesday linked it to his scheduled visit to Jamnagar. "They can, and we'll talk about that tomorrow with Reliance. They've done so in the past. They have the capability to refine heavy crude. They've done so in the past, and I think as more and more Venezuelan oil comes online, it's something they can do," he said, explaining the decision to visit Reliance Industries Ltd's refinery in Jamnagar.

"Refining capacity — it's not just being able to produce oil. I think what a lot of people who have become experts in the energy field over the last few months are just learning, because of this conflict, refining capability's a key part of it. And India's a refining superpower, and they have the ability to do that. They have companies that know how to do that," he said.

"They also, by the way, have oil concessions in Venezuela; they can produce more themselves. So all these are positive things. And I'm not claiming to you that Venezuela alone can fill the hole that could be caused by some of the things that are happening around the world, but I think over time, it most certainly can, and in the short term it can somewhat provide relief. So that's one of the things we'll talk about with India. We talked about it in the past, and they sound ready to... they're ready to do it, they're willing to do it. There might be a few impediments that stand in the way in terms of sanctions and so forth that we have to work through, pre-existing sanctions on the Maduro regime," he said.

Talking about his second visit to India since May this year, Rubio said: "I would like to point out that the foreign minister of India flew to the United States four times this year. This is the most populous country in the world, it's the largest democracy in the world, it's an important commercial partner and business partner of the United States. We also do a lot of defence cooperation. They're a key member of the Quad. They're a strong strategic partner. So I actually don't think we come enough, and I think we need to have more..."

Listing the number of senior members of the Trump administration who have visited India, he said: "So this is a very important partner for us."

Rubio also paid tribute at the 26/11 memorial at the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel in Mumbai.

Earlier in the day, Rubio was received at the Mumbai airport by Maharashtra Minister Ashish Shelar, accompanied by MEA's Additional Secretary in charge of Americas division, K Nagaraj Naidu.

Welcoming Rubio to India, the MEA's official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in a post on X: "The visit provides an opportunity to further advance cooperation across the various pillars of the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership."

Rubio's visit comes amid the tension in India-US relations over visa restrictions and tariff threats. His meeting with Jaishankar is being seen as an attempt to repair ties. With Prime Minister Narendra Modi expected to travel to the US for the G20 leaders summit in December, the meeting also laid the groundwork for his visit.

The choice of venue is being seen as an outreach to India's business elite, which is based in Mumbai.

Mohan Bhagwat

self-reliance, and empowerment of society.

The PM said Bhagwat has stressed on service and nation-building which have been, he added, an integral part of the life of all RSS swayamsevaks.

'Storm from West'

In his speech, Bhagwat, while alleging global forces behind recent protests in the country, said some foreign powers wanted to prevent India from becoming stronger because it could challenge their own position of influence.

Referring to recent protests and unrest in France, Albania, Bangladesh and Nepal, the RSS chief called them "storm from the West", saying that such agitations were leading to instability in different parts of the world.

Bhagwat said similar attempts were being made in India, but added that the country has moved forward with a sound policy and leadership in recent decades.

Hinting at the countrywide protests, he said when "a movement becomes a tool of politics, driven by hostility and antagonism towards an individual, a group, or an ideology, forces seeking to undermine Bharat take advantage of the situation".

The RSS chief said: "It is clear that we must protect our mutual goodwill by remaining alert and safeguarding ourselves against the intellectual confusion created by such divisive tendencies. We must remain vigilant, avoid being disturbed or provoked in any way and with our aspiration and goal of seeing Bharat attain the status of Vishwaguru always firmly in our minds, continue striving in our efforts."

Call for unity

Bhagwat framed the national song Vande Mataram as an instrument of unity in Bengal when Lord Curzon had divided it on communal lines, saying the British had to revoke the decision. The same, however, did not happen in 1947 as people got consumed by hatred and forgot national unity.

"Why, then, could the same outcome not be achieved in 1947? Because those who wanted to divide us and keep us embroiled in conflict instilled in our minds the notion that because we are distinct, we are separate; because we appear different, we must indeed be different and apart. Under the influence of communal and extremist ideologies, we too came to believe that since we appear different, we are, in reality, not one but separate from one another," he said.

Bhagwat underlined that "we brought upon ourselves enduring unrest along the borders and within the country, mutual distrust, insecurity, and constant strife over even the smallest of issues".

He said, "Vande Mataram which defeated the divisive conspiracy of the division of Bengal continues to be a powerful source of the same inspiration of unity even today. It is our national song, and there should be no hesitation or objection to sing it in its entirety."

National identity

The RSS chief said, "The root of the problems that trouble and terrify the world today lie in its incomplete outlook on life", adding however that Indians should also learn from the world.

"Otherwise, when it comes to human effort and endeavour, we too have much to learn from the rest of the world. Along with learning from others, it is essential that we should clearly understand and embrace the distinct nature of our national identity, preserve our unity and quality, and devote ourselves to collective, organised endeavour," he added.

Bhagwat also said that the Preamble to the Constitution envisaged India as "a society that, despite its immense diversity, is bound together by a deep sense of emotional unity".

Seeking to combine Hindutva and social justice, he began his speech by paying tributes to Sant Ravidas – a 15th-16th century saint highly regarded among Dalits in Punjab and UP, both poll-bound states – and Swami Shraddhanand, an Arya Samaj leader who was instrumental in the "Shuddhi" (reconversion) movement.

Among the prominent guests at the RSS event were Jagdeep Dhankhar, former Vice-President of India, and Yaniv Revach, Consul General of Israel for India's Mid-West region, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, among others.

Internship

instructor-led training and two months of self-paced digital learning and mentoring, followed by six months of on-the-job training. After 12 months of PMIS, she appeared for recruitment exams and within a month, got a full-time job in March 2026.

"The PMIS internship taught me both technical and non-technical skills. It helped me become more confident and prepared for career opportunities. After completion of 12 months of PMIS journey (6 months training + 6 months on the job training) I also appeared for recruitment exams like NQT (national qualifier test) and within a month, I was employed for a full-time job in March 2026," she said.

Lack of adequate job opportunities has been a key hurdle in India making use of its high demographic dividend. In the first five months of the ongoing financial year 2026-27, youth unemployment rate has ranged between 15.1% and 16.2%. In August, it was 15.1%. Youth unemployment rate was 13.8% in April 2025, when the monthly Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) was published first. As per official figures, based on the PLFS for 2025, the not in employment, education, or training or NEET rate among youngsters in 2025 was 25% at an all-India level. As per a NITI Aayog report released in August, around 8.7 crore Indians aged 15-29 were not studying, working or undergoing training in 2021.

Announced with an aim to provide internship opportunities to 1 crore youth in top 500 companies over five years, the first pilot phase of the PMIS was launched on October 3, 2024. It was opened for youth between 21 years and 24 years, not employed full-time and not engaged in full-time education. Candidates who had passed high school, higher secondary school, who possess a certificate from an ITI, hold a diploma from a polytechnic institute, or are graduates with degrees such as BA, B.Sc, B.Com, BCA, BBA, B.Pharma, etc. were eligible to apply. A monthly amount of Rs 4,500 was to be provided by the Government of India through DBT with an additional Rs 500 by the company's CSR funds. The government also provided a one-time grant of Rs 6,000 per annum for incidentals to cover miscellaneous expenses.

Based on the feedback for Round I and Round II, the government then adopted a flexible duration of internships of either 6 or 9 months earlier in March this year. The monthly allowance was also hiked to Rs 9,000 from Rs 5,000 and the age requirement for youth was relaxed from 21-24 to 18-25 years.

Jamnagar visit today

issue of oil imports from Russia, Venezuelan oil imports by RIL, and potential for increasing American energy sales, according to experts.

Rubio's India visit — his second in five months — is significant as it comes at a sensitive time in bilateral ties as Washington and New Delhi are working to conclude a trade deal, even as disagreements over tariffs and India's hefty Russian oil imports continue to be points of friction. Last week, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor described Rubio's India trip in October as "a little more business-focused" than his May visit.

Apart from RIL's involvement in the Texas refinery project, Gor also underscored the company's importance in the global oil refining industry, as it is India's largest exporter of refined petroleum products and one of its two refineries at Jamnagar is an export-oriented unit. Rubio's visit to Jamnagar appears to signal that Washington views India's refining industry and its top private-sector player as important players in the global energy market. The US hasn't disclosed any detailed agenda for Rubio's Jamnagar trip. RIL also didn't comment on the planned visit.

In a press note last week on Rubio's visit, the US Department of State highlighted energy cooperation, commercial investments and economic cooperation among the topics of discussion during the tour. "He will meet with senior government officials to strengthen the US-India strategic partnership, exchange views on regional and global dynamics, and discuss prospects for enhanced energy cooperation. Secretary Rubio will also meet with business leaders to promote opportunities for commercial investment and economic cooperation," it said.

Notably, Rubio's visit to RIL's Jamnagar facility comes days after Elon Musk alleged "certain oligarchs" were intentionally blocking Starlink's licence approval to maintain a "monopolistic chokehold" on India. Musk, who is seen as a close ally of the Trump administration, had targeted Ambani on the issue. "Is Ambani the real boss of India," Musk had said in a post on X. Later, however, he posted "much appreciated" on X after RIL responded by saying that it welcomed competition in satellite communications, including Starlink, while noting that Reliance Jio's own satellite services awaited government clearances.

Reliance's Texas refinery partnership

One of the most significant potential talking points could be RIL's involvement in a proposed refinery project in Brownsville, Texas. For Rubio, a visit to Jamnagar would provide an opportunity to discuss the project's progress, the broader investment relationship, and the scope for further cooperation between American energy companies and RIL.

In March, US President Donald Trump announced plans for the refinery, to be built by America First Refining, and thanked RIL for its "tremendous investment" for the project. According to Trump, the Brownsville refinery — the first new refinery in the US in five decades — entails a $300-billion deal.

The $300 billion figure appears to be the value of crude oil that the refinery will process and the fuels it will produce over five years. According to America First Refining, 1.2 billion barrels of US light shale oil with an estimated value of $125 billion will be purchased and processed by the 60-million-barrels-per-year refinery, and 50 billion gallons of refined products — worth $175 billion — will be produced. The project offers Washington an opportunity to showcase foreign investment in American energy infrastructure, while Reliance could gain a strategic foothold in the world's largest oil-consuming economy.

Jamnagar's significance in global fuel supply

From a fuel supply perspective, the Jamnagar complex is an important production centre with refining capacity of 68.2 million tonnes per annum (mtpa), of which 35.2 mtpa is dedicated for exports. RIL is India's largest exporter of petroleum fuels like diesel and jet fuel and is seen as a major swing supplier in the global fuels market, particularly when disruptions affect supplies from other regions, as is the case currently with West Asia and Russia.

Ahead of the midterm polls in a few weeks' time, the Trump administration is under pressure over fuel prices and the availability of petroleum products, particularly diesel, amid geopolitical disruptions to energy flows. In this environment, India's refining capacity and RIL's status as a large fuel exporter could become a subject of strategic interest for Washington. Notably, Trump eased US sanctions on even Russian diesel exports, including to the US, in a bid to rein in runaway prices in the global market as well as American pumps.

Experts said that Rubio could use the visit to explore the broader role RIL, and even other Indian refiners, can play in strengthening energy trade between the two countries, although there is no confirmed indication that the Jamnagar visit is partly aimed at securing diesel shipments for the US. Beyond diplomatic and geopolitical considerations, decisions on fuel exports depend on various commercial factors like refining margins, shipping costs, product specifications, market prices, and the relative attractiveness of competing export markets.

The Russian oil question

Rubio's visit also comes against the backdrop of a shift in US approach to Russian energy sanctions. After signing into law last month a legislation that grants him powers to impose up to 100% tariffs on top buyers of Russian energy, including India, Trump last week waived the application of the law's provisions just days before they were to take effect. RIL has been a major Indian buyer of Russian oil.

The Russian oil issue has become especially sensitive as Washington and New Delhi attempt to advance their broader economic relationship. In fact, speaking in Uzbekistan on Monday, Rubio said the decision to waive the implementation of the new Russia sanctions law also took into account the India-US trade deal, which is close to conclusion. His Jamnagar visit could provide a further opportunity for a discussion on the commercial realities facing Indian refiners, particularly with regard to Russian oil imports.

India's oil imports from Russia increased after the Ukraine war broke out. With much of the West shunning Russian crude following Russia's February 2022 invasion of Ukraine, Moscow started offering discounts on its oil to willing buyers. Indian refiners were quick to avail the opportunity, leading to Russia -- earlier a peripheral supplier of oil to India -- emerging as India's biggest source of crude, displacing the traditional West Asian suppliers.

For Washington, Moscow's revenue from energy exports has been a problem. For over a year now, the Trump administration has tried to strong-arm New Delhi into pivoting away from Russian crude, including by imposing additional penal tariffs last year. Its argument has been that by buying Russian oil, India has been funding Russia's war in Ukraine.

For India, crude procurement is essentially linked to energy security, affordability and the refining sector's requirements. The country depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil requirement, with energy imports accounting for the lion's share of its merchandise imports and having significant implications for the economy.

More American, Venezuelan oil for RIL, India

Discussions are likely to also touch upon the possibility of further increasing American energy purchases by India, and RIL in particular, as per industry analysts. The US is already a major supplier of crude oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to India, and increasing energy exports to this market would serve Washington's commercial interests.

The Trump administration has publicly stated on various occasions that it wants India to buy more American energy, particularly as an instrument to rebalance bilateral trade and deepen economic cooperation.

RIL's massive refining complex is well positioned to evaluate a broad range of crude grades, including those from the US. As India's largest private sector refiner, if it steps up oil imports from the US, American energy exports could potentially capture a greater share of India's oil import slate. The US is currently India's fifth-largest supplier of crude oil, behind Russia, Iraq, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. While energy cooperation is bound to come up in Rubio's discussions with Jaishankar, his Jamnagar engagement could complement those discussions with a focus on RIL.

In this context, Venezuelan crude could also be a key point of interest. The US wants higher Venezuelan oil flows as that benefits Washington, which now effectively controls the motorisation of Venezuelan oil. RIL is already a major buyer of Venezuelan crude outside of the US and is expected to remain important for further expanding Venezuelan oil flows to India. RIL's refineries have very high complexity levels, making them apt to process heavy crudes like those from Venezuela.

'99% work done (on trade deal)'

have been "positive" and the Quad was an example of "very strong cooperation" with India, which is beginning to "actually turn ideas into action".

When asked about the Trump administration being soft on China, he rejected the perception. "Soft is not the right terminology...the attitude of this administration has been to try to find a level of strategic stability in our relationship with them," he said. He added that a US-China trade war would be "devastating to the global economy" and would "impact India".

Allaying Indian concerns on the Trump administration's relations with Pakistan's generals, Rubio said: "What everyone should be assured of in India is that our relationship, not just with Pakistan but with any country in the world, will never come at the expense of our relationship. We don't view it that way in our relationship with India."

Tiger Shroff

US-based gangster Anil Pandit had claimed responsibility for the firing in a purported audio clip in which he also indicated that it was linked to the Bishnoi gang. Mahto had been living alone in a rented accommodation in Andheri and used to ride bikes for Rapido, police sources said, adding he allegedly helped the shooters who arrived in the city a few days before the firing.

According to police, the shooters were handled by another gang member and introduced to Mahto in Mumbai after the target was finalised. They are believed to have stayed with him for the past few days, sources said. Mahto bought the bike on September 12 for Rs 24,500 through a friend, the previous owner, who lived in Juhu Galli. Mahto allegedly promised to transfer the vehicle in his name but failed to provide the necessary documents, including his photograph, to complete the move, sources said.

Police are now probing how long Mahto had been working for Lawrence gang and whether he had assisted in any previous operations. "Mahto had initially stayed in a rented room in Juhu Galli, near Gilbert Hill in Andheri West. He allegedly managed to procure an Aadhaar card bearing an address at Noorani Chawl in the same area. Around 4 months ago, he shifted to a rented room in Sahar area," sources said. A senior officer said Mahto's call records showed he had allegedly been in contact with "someone in Delhi for a long time". Police are examining records to determine whether the contact was linked to Lawrence gang.

Kuki-Zo man killed

when they came under attack. Meitei civil society organisations have called for a shutdown in response to the attack.

On Tuesday, Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh convened a meeting with representatives of the INDIA bloc and leaders of various political parties at the Secretariat in Imphal, where the law-and-order situation was reviewed.

The INDIA bloc representatives were led by former chief minister Okram Ibobi Singh and included CLP leader K Meghachandra Singh, MP Angomcha Bimol, MLA Surjakumar Singh and others.

"I gave them a patient hearing and assured them that the matters would be looked into seriously. We also had a constructive discussion on maintaining peace and collective efforts for the restoration of normalcy in the state," the CM posted on X.

Three arrests in Monday's killings

In connection with the killing of the three Meitei men, the Manipur police have arrested three persons and recovered a cache of arms, ammunition and explosives, including three improvised explosive devices (IEDs), ADGP Manipur Lhari Dorjee Lhatoo said on Tuesday.

Lhatoo said two of the arrested individuals have admitted during preliminary interrogation to being part of the assault team involved in the attack.

The role of the third accused is under investigation and efforts are on to identify and apprehend others involved in the incident.

The arrest was made following intensive search and intelligence-based operations launched on Monday evening by joint teams of Manipur police, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) and the Commando Battalion for Resolute Action (CoBRA) in the S Highlandkot area and neighbouring villages under Sagolmang police station, said the ADGP, adding that the arms and ammunition were recovered based on disclosures made by the accused.

The seized firearms included an INSAS rifle, an M16 rifle, an A1 rifle, an AK series rifle, a 7.62 mm sniper rifle, a 5.56 mm Heckler & Koch rifle, three 12-bore single-barrel guns, a Lethod gun and a handmade rocket launcher. The total seizure comprised 12 firearms and 1,095 live rounds of various calibres.

The recovered explosive materials included TNT slabs, PK explosive, gunpowder, Lethod shells, locally made Pompi bombs, M61 rifle grenades, a Chinese hand grenade, handmade mortars and three detonators.

Other items seized included radio sets with batteries, helmets, uniforms, a monocular and poppy seeds.

In a separate operation launched around 4 am on Tuesday, joint teams of Manipur Police, the CRPF, CoBRA, the Border Security Force (BSF), Assam Rifles and the Army conducted searches in the area surrounding Sinai camp, a designated sub-camp of a Suspension of Operations (SoO) group.

Seventeen individuals were detained for verification after their identities did not match those of the cadres listed with the Kuki National Organisation (KNO) and the Kuki Liberation Army (KLA) associated with the camp.

Lhatoo said the verification process was ongoing and could take time, as some of the detained individuals might have come from other places.

He also said ammunition and magazines had been found missing from the camp, adding that their status was being verified against the weapons seized during the ongoing operations.

Senior officers of Manipur Police, the BSF and the CRPF also conducted helicopter surveillance over the areas where the operations were underway. Director General of Police Mukesh Singh visited the site of the Sunurok Hill incident and coordinated the operations, Lhatoo said.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Umesh Kumar, S/o:** Sh. Lalit Kumar **R/o:** H.No. D-131, Hari Nagar Extn, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 107/2015, U/s: 279/337 IPC and 146/196 M.V. ACT PS: Kashmere Gate Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Umesh Kumar,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Umesh Kumar,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Umesh Kumar,** of **FIR No. 107/2015, U/s: 279/337 IPC and 146/196 M.V. ACT PS: Kashmere Gate Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.11.2026.**

By Order
Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
(Central) Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/14127/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Azim, S/o:** Sh. Firoz, **R/o:** H.No. 7816, Nai Basti Bara Hindu Rao, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 487/2023, U/s: 392/394/411 IPC, PS: Kashmere Gate Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Azim,** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Azim,** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Azim,** of **FIR No. 487/2023, U/s: 392/394/411 IPC, PS: Kashmere Gate Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.11.2026.**

By Order
Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
(Central) Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/14130/N/2026
(Court Matter)

LAUNCHED UNDER NEW SCHEME

2,500 low-income DDA flats booked in 2 hours in Narela

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 20

"The strong response shows the growing interest in Narela, which has been transforming into a major residential, educational, institutional and sports hub," a DDA spokesperson said

MORE THAN 2,500 low-income group (LIG) flats in North Delhi's Narela were booked within two hours of the launch of a new Delhi Development Authority's (DDA) scheme on Tuesday, signalling interest in a housing market where the statutory body has historically struggled to sell its inventory.

Online bookings for 2,516 LIG flats in Pockets 3 and 6 of Sectors G2–G6 began at noon on Tuesday under DDA's Awas Nivesh Yojana 2026. The flats were offered at a 25% discount, with tentative prices starting at Rs 14.95 lakh. Of the total flats, 1,020 are located in Pocket 3 and 1,496 in Pocket 6.

The response assumes significance given the statutory body's long standing difficulties in selling flats in Narela, which has faced concerns over civic amenities, water supply, maintenance and security.

According to data submitted by Minister of State for Housing and Urban Affairs Tokhan Sahu in the Lok Sabha last year, the DDA has constructed 62,801 flats in Narela since the early 2000s but has managed to sell only around half of them.

DDA sold 1,284 flats during the April to June quarter of this year and generated Rs 1,020 crores in revenue. While DDA has started to witness demand for Economically Weaker Section (EWS) and LIG flats, the next challenge for the statutory body will be to start selling its flats in the 2BHK and 3BHK categories.

Narela, recently renamed Vindhyachal, is one of the DDA's three major sub-city projects, alongside Dwarka and Rohini. Although planning for the area began in the late 1980s, large-scale construction picked up only in the early 2000s, with flats being offered for sale from around 2010.

Officials have attributed the renewed interest in the area partly to improvements in connectivity. The completion of the Urban Extension Road-II last year has reduced travel time to other parts of Delhi. The proposed Rithala-Narela-Nathupur corridor under the Delhi Metro's Phase IV expansion is also expected to improve connectivity, with operations anticipated in the next four to five years.

A Narela Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) station is also proposed on the upcoming Delhi-Panipat-Karnal Namo Bharat corridor. To be sure, this corridor has not yet been approved.

The area is also set to benefit from an upcoming Education Hub in Sector G2–G6, where land has been allotted to several universities, according to a DDA spokesperson.

Sports infrastructure in the vicinity includes the Narela Sports Complex in Sector A-7 and a proposed Multi-Sports Integrated Stadium and Sports Complex.

A DDA spokesperson said the response to the latest scheme reflected demand for affordable housing and confidence in its housing initiatives.

"The strong response shows the growing interest in Narela, which has been transforming into a major residential, educational, institutional and sports hub. DDA's sustained investment in infrastructure and connectivity is helping position Narela as one of Delhi's important future growth centres," the spokesperson said.

Winter pollution plan kicks in from Nov 1: 'No PUC, no fuel', vehicle curbs, 50% WFH

Alok Singh
New Delhi, October 20



Delhi typically chokes during winter months. GAJENDRA YADAV

STRICTER CURBS on older and polluting vehicles, a 'No PUC, No Fuel' policy, 50% work from home for employees, and restrictions on construction activities: The Delhi government Tuesday announced its 10-point winter action plan for 2026-27 to tackle air pollution from November 1 to February 28.

Announcing the measures, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the plan would be implemented through coordination between the Centre, Delhi government, Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), local bodies, Delhi Police, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and other agencies. She said public participation would be central to the campaign.

- **Fuel policy**: Vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC) and those that have exceeded their prescribed lifespan will not be allowed to refuel at 500 petrol pumps equipped with Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) systems from November 1.
- **Curbs on vehicles**: From November 1, petrol and diesel vehicles registered outside Delhi that do not meet BS-VI emission standards will be barred from entering the city, while CNG and electric vehicles will be exempt.
- **Construction ban**: The plan proposes a complete ban on dust-generating demolition activities and outdoor civil construction work from November 1 to January 31. A broader ban on all types of construction and demolition activities will be imposed from December 10 to January 20. Construction sites will also be required to have 100% CCTV coverage, while registration on the 'Malba App' will be mandatory for building-plan approvals.
- **WFH policy**: To reduce vehicular emissions and traffic congestion, 50% of employees in government and private offices will be required to work from home, or work from home for two days a week, from November 1.

The government has also revised office timings, with municipal corporation offices scheduled to function from 8.30 am to 5 pm and Delhi government offices from 10 am to 6.30 pm.

- **Parking fee doubled**: Parking charges at authorised parking facilities will be doubled, excluding Metro parking facilities, to discourage the use of private vehicles. The government has also set a target of increasing daily ridership on the Delhi Metro to 72 lakh and on Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses to 42 lakh. Delhi currently has 6,840 buses, including 5,088 electric buses.

A campaign to encourage people to download the Delhi Metro Sarathi App took place between October 1 and 10 to improve last-mile connectivity.

Among other measures, the plan also proposes deploying AI-enabled monitoring systems to strengthen enforcement. The government has also set a target of redeveloping 3,000 km of roads to control dust pollution. Work on 1,193 km has been completed, while concrete roadwork has been scheduled to be completed by October 31 and bitumen work by November 15.

Measures such as mechanised road sweeping, water sprinkling, deep cleaning, improving footpaths, paving road surfaces and clearing garbage accumulation points are also being expedited.

Weekly inspections will be conducted at all 37 identified air-quality and traffic hotspots by public representatives, including MPs, MLAs and councillors, along with nodal officers. The government is also working to make 15 major road stretches signal-free and congestion-free by October, of which eight have been completed.

For dust control, 98 mechanical road-sweeping machines have been deployed in two shifts, with deep cleaning of all major roads scheduled to be completed by October 31. On industrial pollution, the government said 2,283 polluting units had been sealed or shut down following a survey of 11,271 units.

As winter nears, Delhi air quality deteriorates, set to turn 'poor'

New Delhi: Delhi's air quality is expected to deteriorate to the 'poor' category from Wednesday, with the pollution levels likely to remain in that category for the next six days, according to The Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM) forecast.

On Tuesday, the Capital Air Quality Index (AQI) rose to 179 in the Moderate category, up from 139 on Monday.

PM2.5 was the prominent pollutant in Delhi on Tuesday, compared with ozone (O3) and PM10 on Monday. The AQI in neighbouring Noida stood at 161, while Gurugram recorded 184, both in the 'moderate' category.

Transport emissions continued to be the largest contributor among the sources tracked by IITM's Decision Support System (DSS). As of October 19, the transport sector accounted for 23.02% of Delhi's emissions, followed by residential sources at around 6%. Industries, construction, road dust, waste burning, and the energy sector together accounted for around 15%. ENS

• Skywatch

Forecast: October 21, 2026
Mainly clear sky, no rain
MAX: 31-33
0.4°C below normal
MIN: 17-19
1.4°C below normal

• AQI Tracker

Mundka	Poor	Burari	Moderate
AQI: 241		AQI: 138	
Anand Vihar	Moderate	Shadipur	Moderate
AQI: 124		AQI: 162	

- Good (0-50)
- Satisfactory (51-100)
- Moderate (101-200)
- Poor (201-300)
- Very Poor (301-400)
- Severe (401-500)

Yamuna set for Sabarmati -style makeover

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 20

BOASTING OF cycle tracks, walking paths, sports grounds and recreational spaces, the Delhi government is planning a Sabarmati-style riverfront along a 52-km stretch of the Yamuna in the Capital, officials have said.

The government is moving a proposal for a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Sabarmati Riverfront Development Corporation to replicate Ahmedabad's riverfront model in Delhi. With the Wazirabad barrage dividing the stretch, this project, according to officials, will be implemented in two phases.

The first phase will cover the stretch from Palla to Wazirabad, while the second will extend from Wazirabad to Kalindi Kunj near the Okhla barrage. Consultants are being engaged to guide the project, officials underlined.

The first phase will be taken up on priority and is expected to serve as a model for the larger riverfront project. "If the plans proceed as envisaged, the riverfront model would take shape during the current government's tenure," said Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh.

The aim, he said, is to develop a clean, green and world-class public space where residents can come for morning walks, yoga and other recreational activities. The Minister, who recently visited the Sabarmati riverfront in Ahmedabad along with officials from the Delhi Jal Board and the Irrigation and Flood Control department, said Delhi would adopt the best practices of the Gujarat project.

JNU students' union calls off 17-day strike

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 20

MEMBERS OF the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union (JNUSU) Tuesday called off their 17-day indefinite protest after the university administration agreed to meet their demands: withdrawing FIRs against students, reviewing contentious clauses in the Chief Proctor's Office (CPO) manual, and revoking the rustication of five students.

The development came after a meeting on Monday between student representatives and a committee headed by the Dean of the School of Social Sciences (SSS).

The university administration, in a statement on Monday, said a committee had held discussions with the students on October 9 and October 14. It said the students had ended their hunger strike after assurances during the October 9 meeting, while the later discussions continued over their demands. The administration also said the university's Chief Medical Officer had been checking the health of students on strike daily.

The minutes also stated that the committee will meet again after 14 working days to take forward the demands and discuss how to implement them.

The university has agreed on revoking rustication of five students, including JNUSU president Aditi Mishra; initiate structural audits of Tapti and Mahi-Mandavi hostels and Teflas cafeteria and provide an audit report on the Equal Opportunity Cell (EOC) within a week.





'Misapplication of law': CJP duo moves HC over extended custody

Sohini Ghosh & Alok Singh
New Delhi, October 20



CJP leaders Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das. FILE

COCKROACH JANTA Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka moved the Delhi High Court on Tuesday, challenging a Special Executive Magistrate's Monday order that sent the two to two more days in jail. The HC is not sitting until October 26 due to Dussehra vacations, and no special vacation bench sitting has been notified yet. Ranka and Das were arrested on October 14 for allegedly breaching security and entering Jantar Mantar. On Monday, the SEM extended their custody by two days, taking the total to seven days.

The order signed by SEM Ritu Raj, an ACP-rank officer with the Delhi Police, said that Ranka and Das's conduct did not inspire "confidence", that they have "no respect for law" and that they have habitually called for protests at a de-notified site. While being taken away, Das had termed the SEM a "police court" and said "there's no justice".

Key challenge

The two are challenging the grounds on which their sureties were rejected and the demand for fresh ones. As per the SEM order, two persons acted as the surety for Ranka and Das. For one person, the SEM court said that the photograph of the person did not match with the Aadhaar card. For the other person, the court said that basic details like parentage were not there.

In their plea, the two are challenging that SEM Ritu Raj sent them to two-days' judicial custody "in default of execution of bond", arguing sureties were presented by them but they were not granted an opportunity to present the said sureties.

Das and Ranka also claimed that the SEM failed to specify the number of sureties, the amount of the surety bond, and the term of the sureties in any of his orders, which is a prerequisite to initiate preventive arrest proceedings.

Pointing out that sureties furnished can only be rejected if they are an "unfit person for the purposes of the bond", Das and Ranka, in their plea, argued that the SEM's grounds for rejection are contrary to the principles of personal liberty and shows "complete misapplication of the law". The two also said the SEM's order "records no independent opinion and "every operative finding is drawn from the application of the Investigating Officer." The plea sought an urgent hearing, including a possible night hearing, alleging violations of their fundamental right to liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution.

According to the plea, Das and Ranka were first detained on October 10 upon their arrival at Delhi airport. They were subsequently detained again on October 13 for allegedly carrying the national flag at Jantar Mantar. On October 14, the SEM remanded them to judicial custody without specifying the duration or amount of the bond, the petition claimed.

The petition has cited the HC ruling in Aldanish Rein vs State of NCT of Delhi, arguing that detainees should be released on personal bonds while verification of sureties is pending. It has also challenged the extension of custody under Section 135(3) of the BNSS, alleging that the SEM relied on police applications without registration of an FIR.

In a statement, CJP legal head Ratna Singh said there was no justification for keeping the two leaders in custody for seven consecutive days. "The grounds provided by the SEM are completely bizarre... and mechanically adopted from police applications," Singh said

She added that CJP had approached the HC to secure their immediate release.

Special Executive Magistrates' powers under lens after action against CJP leaders, Neha

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, October 20

THE CUSTODY extension of CJP leaders Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das and a show-cause notice issued to AISA president Neha Bora, amid protests against the SIR of electoral rolls, have brought the powers of Special Executive Magistrates (SEMs) into focus.

SEMs can exercise certain powers to prevent breaches of peace, but they cannot conduct trials. Courts have repeatedly questioned how these powers are exercised, flagging procedural violations and concerns over the impact on personal liberty.

Who are SEMs

Executive Magistrates function under the government and do not exercise judicial powers. Traditionally, they are revenue or administrative officers. In the Capital, the Delhi Police Act empowers the central government to authorise the Police Commissioner and subordinate officers, not below the rank of ACP, to exercise powers of district and executive magistrates. SEMs have limited powers and operate on administrative measures, especially to maintain public law and order.

Judicial magistrates, on the other hand, are administered by the judiciary, that is high courts. They can conduct trials. Law Commission reports have examined the extent of powers of judicial magistrates vis-a-vis executive magistrates, and if provisions requiring individuals to furnish bonds for good behaviour or initiating preventive proceedings should vest with the executive or the judiciary.

While earlier reports favoured retaining these powers with the executive, the 41st Law Commission report in 1969 had opined that since preventive measures affect personal liberty, the power should vest exclusively with the judiciary.

In 2018, the Delhi HC directed that the period of judicial custody under preventive arrest provisions must not exceed seven days at any one time. It also said "there must be a weekly review by the SEMs... of the need to continue detention".

Preventive arrest and security provisions under the BNSS have roots in colonial history dating back to the Justices of Peace Act of 1361, enacted by the English Parliament. The law empowered "justices of peace" to prevent "breach of peace" by restraining "offenders, rioters and all other barrators" or binding them with sureties of good behaviour. Their role had some parallels with that of SEMs. The provisions subsequently found their way into the Code of Criminal Procedure, in 1861, when it was enacted.

3 decades apart, HC flags similar lapses

In 1984, the Delhi HC received an application from Tihar Jail from death-row prisoner Sunil Batra. It pointed out that "a large number of persons are unjustifiably arrested by the police... under Section 107 Criminal Procedure Code", without following prescribed procedure, and kept in jail without being offered the facility of release on bail. At the time, the court had lamented that where citizens' liberties are "to be controlled by police officers exercising powers of executive magistrates", blurring separation of the executive and judiciary, "need one be surprised at the consequences which must inevitably flow from such a retrogressive step".

In its verdict, the court directed that individuals must be informed of the reasons they were required to execute a bond. If they were sent to jail for failing to furnish sureties, the warrant had to accompany the SEM's order. Over 30 years later, in 2018, a division bench of Justices S Muralidhar and Vinod Goel noted that "nothing much appears to have changed since" the HC had disposed of Sunil Batra's case. The division bench issued directions on procedures to be followed strictly by SEMs.

Noticing rampant misuse, the court asked the Lieutenant Governor to consider setting up an oversight mechanism to periodically review how SEMs exercised their preventive powers.

The court also suggested that the LG consider calling these officials "Special Executive Officers" instead of SEMs, since the word "Magistrate" could lead people to mistake them for judicial magistrates.

It suggested the LG consider issuing instructions to authorities to create separate spaces within jails for people detained under preventive provisions. The HC had also found that there was "palpable bias in the exercise of these powers" because a "significant percentage of those incarcerated belonged to the minority community".

A YEAR'S DATA - STEP-BY-STEP

Police reports to 14 SEMs	Arrested following police reports
14,529	23,012

- **Incarcerated following arrest:** 7,335 (nearly 30% of those arrested)
- **Incarcerated for more than 7 days:** 1,119 (nearly 15% of those incarcerated)

BETWEEN JULY 1, 2017 - JUNE 30, 2018
SOURCE: DELHI HC RECORDS

EXPRESS special

Found in pipes, cisterns & potted plants: 58% phones smuggled into Tihar are thumb-sized

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, October 20



In 17 phones, the IMEI serial numbers were erased. PHOTO COLLAGE FOR ILLUSTRATIVE PURPOSES ONLY.

Hidden beneath potted plants and trees, stuck inside toilet cisterns, shoved into water pipes, inside a RO water purifier and even strapped on an inmate's back -- this is where smuggled mobile phones have been recovered from inside Tihar Jail, Asia's largest prison complex, RTI records accessed by *The Indian Express* show.

There are 15 Central Jails in the complex, including six in Mandoli, and together they house over 10,000 inmates. Of these, only Central Jail No.3 responded to RTI queries from this newspaper on recovered communication equipment, including VoIP sets, with details of each device's recovery.

In all, the jail provided details of 285 recoveries, involving 350 mobile phones, between 2020 and 2025. They include:

- A Chinese Realme phone and an Airtel SIM card found inside the attached toilet of Cell No 26, wrapped in a plastic sheet.
- A Samsung Duos mini mobile recovered from the roof of a common toilet inside Ward No 1, indicating that it was flung from outside the ward but was yet to be collected.
- A Kechaoda miniature Chinese phone found while digging inside the ward temple ground, suggesting that it may have been smuggled in a while ago. An analysis of the details provided suggests that "smaller the better" is the common theme in these recoveries.
- Of the 350 phones recovered, a majority were Android versions with dual SIM cards. 202 instruments, or 58% of the recoveries, were models of the thumb-sized Chinese Kechaoda, described as the world's smallest mobile phone, costing a little over Rs 1,000.
- After Kechaoda, the popular choice for inmates has evidently been the compact Samsung Duos, with 88 instruments, or 25% of the total recoveries. Other brands include Chinese-made phones such as Oppo, Redmi, Vivo, Melrose or Realme. There have also been recoveries of low-budget Indian phones such as Hero, Ringme, Snexian, Blackzone or Lvix. Only two iPhones and six Nokia smartphones were recovered.

YOUR RIGHT to know
AN EXPRESS RTI APPLICATION

Construction workers and masons have on multiple occasions retrieved mobile phones during digging work in the prison, including many from common toilet areas. For instance, a white Samsung Duos was found at the base of a peepal tree and a blue Kechaoda popped up during digging near an MCV box. Once, the inventory shows, another white Samsung Duos was found strapped on an inmate's back. Mobile phones have been pulled out from cavities in walls of barracks and toilets as well as from plastic boxes and tiffins, as well.

In 17 phones, the IMEI serial numbers were found to have been erased. The other electronic items recovered include earphones, memory cards, data cables and pen drives, mostly in ones and twos along with mobile phones.

Among the telling recoveries are 19 "improvised" or "handmade" phone chargers. Jail staff say inmates are adept at "manufacturing" such chargers. For instance, during one search operation in June 2023, the prison staff recovered seven mobile phones and an equal number of improvised, prison-made chargers.

The 67-acre Mandoli complex, located in Northeast Delhi, was completed a decade ago to decongest Tihar with six Central Jails.

One of them, Central Jail No 15, reported that 27 pen drives were recovered between 2020 and 2026. Another, Central Jail No 14, reported the recovery of one pen drive.

The reply from Central Jail No 12 states that on January 1, 2019, the staff became aware of the use of VoIP by inmates. No VoIP equipment, however, was seized. It also states that in five years, 60 penalties have been meted out to inmates found using mobile phones.

The prisons in the complex have also listed steps taken to prevent the use of mobile phones and other internet-based communication, including jammers and CCTV cameras. Other steps include surprise searches in barracks, toilets and other "vulnerable" areas; cross-frisking by Tamil Nadu Special Police; and intelligence gathering to detect incidents of illegal use of communication equipment.

'Cheap politics', says AAP as Delhi Minister burns cockroach effigy along with Ravan's

Alok Singh
New Delhi, October 20



The 30-foot cockroach effigy was burnt at Pitampura. PRAVEEN KHANNA

A WAR of words broke out between the ruling BJP in the Capital and the AAP after Delhi minister Kapil Mishra burnt a 30-foot effigy of a cockroach alongside those of Ravan, Kumbhkaran and Meghnad during Dussehra celebrations organised by the Shri Keshav Ramlila Committee in North West Delhi's Pitampura on Tuesday.

Delhi AAP unit chief Saurabh Bhardwaj termed the move an example of "cheap politics targeting Gen Z" and said the BJP leader should not use the Hindu religion for political gains. He also said the BJP could not demean thousand-year-old Sanatan traditions by turning them into a joke. "The RSS cannot remain silent on this blasphemy," Bhardwaj said.

Bhardwaj also filed a complaint, seeking an FIR against Mishra and BJP MLA Ashok Goel Devraha, who was also present at the event, alleging that they had hurt the religious sentiments of Hindus by altering Sanatan traditions for political gains and promoting enmity between communities.

Mishra, Delhi's Minister for Art, Culture and Language, was invited to attend the Dussehra celebrations in Pitampura. He said Dussehra symbolised the victory of truth over falsehood. He added that no matter how united anti-national forces became, their defeat in India was inevitable. "Look, the effigy of a cockroach is being burnt, and the termites are feeling the pain. A cockroach symbolises filth and anarchy. It emerges from the gutter and eventually returns to it," Mishra said.

Earlier in the day, Abhijit Dipke, founder of Cockroach Janta Party, which has been protesting against the alleged SIR irregularities, referred to the effigy and said it was "free publicity" for the platform.

Pests, cobwebs, staff not wearing gloves: Food safety lapses flagged at sweets units

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 20



Violations were documented during the inspections. EXPRESS

AHEAD OF the festive season, the government's Food Safety department has found hygiene and food-handling lapses at several sweet manufacturing units and establishments across the Capital, including pest activity in storage areas, cobwebs and employees handling food without gloves, officials said.

The department collected samples of *khoya*, *barfi*, *rasbhari*, *laddoos* and other food products from multiple establishments for laboratory testing.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government would not compromise on public health during the festive season

"The true joy of festivals lies in ensuring that every family can trust the hygiene of the food it buys for its home," she said.

During an inspection at Kali Ghata Sweets' manufacturing unit in the Vidya Vihar (Hastsal) Industrial Area, the department found unsatisfactory hygiene, as per an official statement. Improvements were also required at its Uttam Nagar outlet, it read.

Lapses in compliance with prescribed standards were also reported at both manufacturing units of Aman Mithaiwala in the Narela Industrial Complex, where samples of barfi and milk cake were collected.

At Evergreen Sweet House in Okhla, the statement underlined, inspectors found signs of pest activity in the storage area. The establishment could not produce its water testing report during the inspection, while employees were found handling food without gloves.

Inspections at Puri Baker and Bansiwala Sweets in the Badli Industrial Area also revealed deficiencies related to the display of Food Safety and Standards Authority of India licences, training of food handlers and packaging-related documentation.

At Grover Sweet Corner in Naraina, general hygiene was found satisfactory, but inspectors noted open dustbins, employees' clothes kept in the work area and the absence of insect-proof mesh on windows, the statement read.

Singla Sweets in IP Extension was flagged for peeling ceiling plaster, the absence of insect-proof mesh on windows and grease accumulation on the exhaust system. At Meethi Foods in Naraina, inspectors found cobwebs on the chimney.

- KEELING, SISTER OF LONG-TIME DIRECTOR AND CHAIRPERSON OF SHRIRAM BHARATIYA KALA KENDRA SHOBHA DEEPAK SINGH, WILL SPLIT HER TIME BETWEEN DELHI AND HER HOME IN LONDON

Change of guard at SBKK: Keeling wants to 'put things in order' at iconic institute

Suanshu Khurana
New Delhi, October 20





A scene from 'Shri Ram'; (above) Shobha and Gauri. EXPRESS

AT THE full-dress rehearsal of the Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra's (SBKK) flagship production 'Shri Ram', the 22-day Ramlila's 69th edition currently being presented at the institute's open-air arena in Mandi House, Gauri Keeling has a list of concerns and production notes.

Sitting beside the institute's chairperson, Shobha Deepak Singh, Gauri, the new Vice Chairperson of SBKK and Shobha's younger sister, lists the 'issues' to Meenakshi Dass, the executive trustee of SBKK and Shobha and Gauri's niece. King Janaka's beard is all wrong, the subtitles on the screen are crooked, and the lights are not working for her, Gauri says.

The older LED screens have given way to traditional sets, older compositions have been brought in, and few more *chaupais* (four-part verses) have been brought back.

At an institution that has presented the production for decades and is synonymous with the teaching and performance of Indian classical arts, such details are more than matters of stagecraft. They also have to do with the artistic vision and authority that has shaped the Kendra.

For decades, that vision has been identified with Shobha, the institute's long-time artistic director, who has overseen the various productions and shaped them since taking over from art impresario Sumitra Charat Ram. Sumitra, the mother of Shobha and Gauri, played a key role in the revival of performing arts in post-Independence India.

"Back when my mother began, we were fully involved, all of us children were monkeys in the Ramlila. It was rehearsed in the basement of our Curzon Road residence," said Gauri.

With Shobha getting on in age – and after her husband Deepak Singh, who helped her run the place, passed away – most of the financial, cultural decision-making has been taken over by Gauri, who plans to work in collaboration with Jayant Kastuar, Director of SBKK, and Dass. She will also take over the key decision-making for Kamani Auditorium, located next to SBKK, and one of the oldest auditoriums of its kind.

"Shobha has done a wonderful job for about 25-30 years and will always have the respect of the chairperson but she can no longer walk much, and cannot make certain decisions," Gauri told *The Indian Express*.

The history of SBKK, she said, can be loosely divided into two eras – "the Sumitra Charat Ram era based on traditional writing, then post the '70s, the Shobha Deepak Singh era, which was more modern". She is herself traditional, Gauri said, and wants, therefore, to bring back some of the older elements besides "trying to remove all the gimmicks". Gauri moved to London in 1976 after marrying British diplomat David Keeling. She runs an art trust there along with Lekha Poddar, the co-founder of Devi Art Foundation, and Amin Jaffer, an art historian. She will now divide her time between Delhi and the UK, Gauri said.

As Vice Chairperson of SBKK, Gauri's priority will be to "put things in order". "I am determined that this 70-year-old institute is put on the right path for at least the next 10 years," she said. She also plans to look for a professional chairperson.

"I don't believe in the *mai baap* (paternalistic) system of functioning. I am trying to put together a team that will be answerable to a committee. I am training them to work like I do," Gauri said.

"Now, for the first time, every project will have a project report," she said. "A budget will be made for the year. This is a charitable institution and we don't have money to squander. I am Mr Charat Ram's daughter; I was trained by him to be focused."

The change of guard at the institute could alter how the Kendra's legacy is carried forward. "The transition has to occur but it is a slow process," SBKK Director Kastuar said. Getting professionals to manage the show is easier said than done, he said – "finding professionals who don't have their biases"

"Family members may have their own views, but they are all committed to the institute. My role is to ensure a smooth transition," Kastuar said.

Transitions always bring problems, Dass said. "I feel everything is in order; it just needs to be managed better. We are trying to put standard operating procedures in place. SBKK is nothing without Shobha *ji* and she is satisfied that things are moving well," Dass said.

Founded by Sumitra Charat Ram, daughter-in-law of industrialist Lala Shri Ram of the DCM group, SBKK traces its origins to an all-night *baithak* she hosted on Independence Day in 1947 at her house. This grew into Jhankar, a cultural society dedicated to Indian classical music and dance, and in 1952, the institute was formally registered as Shri Ram Bharatiya Kala Kendra. It presented the Ramlila as a dance drama in 1957, a production that remains its signature annual presentation.

The institute also presents the famed Shriram Shankarlal Music Festival.

Maharashtra request prompts four changes to poll panel software

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, October 20

THE ELECTION Commission of India (ECI) has implemented four changes to its ECINet software and procedures sought by Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer S Chockalingam, giving Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) greater discretion in handling notices issued during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The changes allow voters to submit documents beyond the 13 categories listed in notices, make personal hearings exceptional, give EROs greater authority to decide cases involving discrepancies and remove mandatory upload of an extract from the previous SIR roll.

Chockalingam sought the changes in a September 24 letter to senior ECI officials, arguing that software restrictions were limiting the powers of EROs, who are legally responsible for preparing and revising electoral rolls.

The issue concerns voters who receive notices because their records could not be linked to the previous SIR roll or because the software flagged mismatches in their details. Such "logical discrepancies" can include a mismatch in a parent's name or an implausible age gap between parent and child. These flags do not establish that a voter is ineligible.

The first change removes the requirement for voters issued such notices to routinely attend personal hearings at the office of the ERO or Assistant Electoral Registration Officer (AERO). Under the procedure announced by the ECI on September 26, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) visit voters' homes, collect supporting documents and upload them on ECINet for the ERO or AERO to consider. Hearings may be held in exceptional cases, preferably online.

The second change allows voters to submit documents beyond the 13 categories listed. The Maharashtra CEO's office said in an October 1 press note that the BLO App had been updated with an "Any other Documents" option. Chockalingam had argued that the list was indicative, not exhaustive, since voters from tribal, homeless and other vulnerable communities might not possess any of the specified documents.

The third change gives EROs greater discretion in deciding cases involving logical discrepancies. Previously, if an ERO could not resolve a discrepancy on the basis of a BLO's report alone, supporting documents had to be sent to the District Election Officer (DEO) for verification. Chockalingam sought authority for EROs to decide such cases themselves. Under the revised procedure, the ERO or AERO assesses documents and field-level verification material. The Maharashtra CEO's September 30 instructions said that eligible voters should be given opportunity to submit documents.

The fourth change removes the mandatory upload of an "Extract of Last SIR" in every logical discrepancy case. Chockalingam had argued that the software identified discrepancies by comparing voter records with the previous SIR roll, making the additional upload unnecessary. On October 15, he confirmed to *The Indian Express* that the upload was no longer compulsory. He said the change would reduce the workload of BLOs.

The changes follow an *Indian Express* investigation published on September 23 that reported concerns raised by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi that software controls were restricting the powers of officers concerned.

Those undermining India's honour are her enemies: PM

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, October 20

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi said on Tuesday that those who undermine the country's "honor and dignity" and "harbor a mindset of hatred toward our culture" are the enemies of the country and called on people to identify and defeat them.

Addressing the Vijayadashami celebrations at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan, the Prime Minister said, "Vijayadashami is the festival of victory. It is the festival of triumph. This festival gives us the courage to believe that no matter how powerful the enemy may be, when we stand with truth and humanity, victory ultimately belongs to us. This spirit of Vijayadashami has always been India's guiding philosophy."

Quoting a Sanskrit couplet, the Prime Minister said, "Our sages inspired us: *Samano mantrah samitih samani, samanam manah saha chittamesham*. This means that our thoughts should be united, our councils should be united, and all institutions of the nation, all political parties, should stand together in the national interest."

"We must move forward with this spirit. We must unite against the enemies of the nation. Those forces that attack the honour and dignity of the country, those who divide society, and those who harbour hatred towards our culture are enemies of the nation. On this auspicious occasion of Vijayadashami, we must once again renew our resolve. We must identify the enemies of Mother India," Modi said.

"We must defeat them. And, taking the pledge of Nation First, everyone must come together. I am confident that the vision we expressed during the Pran Pratishtha ceremony of the Ayodhya Temple — from "Ram se Rashtra" and from "Dev se Desh" — will certainly be fulfilled," the Prime Minister said.

He further said that a nation progresses only when it possesses self-respect.

"Therefore, today the country is committed to preserving its heritage and identity. For centuries, our treasures were looted and taken abroad. But today, we are bringing those treasures back. In the past twelve years, more than six hundred and fifty ancient idols have been brought back to India... In recent years, many of our sites have been added to the UNESCO World Heritage List. Last year, even Diwali was included by UNESCO in the list of Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. This is the result of the collective willpower of millions of Indians. We must continue to work with the same dedication," he said.



PM Narendra Modi during the Vijayadashami celebrations organised by the Shri Ramlila Committee Indraprastha at IP Extension, New Delhi. PTI

The Prime Minister said that the path followed by Lord Ram shows that difficulties on the path cannot stop our journey.

"Lord Ram taught us that difficulties on the path cannot stop our journey. The ocean stood before him. Lanka was far away. But the resolve was unwavering. Therefore, Lord Ram awakened the collective strength of the people. He made public participation his support. He united the available resources. And he made a goal that seemed impossible. This is the fundamental mantra of success. Faith in our own strength. Confidence in our own capability. Proper utilisation of our own resources. And unwavering commitment to our goal," Modi said.

"Today, we too must move forward with this same mantra. Before us stands the goal of a Developed India," he added.

No justification for terror and no double standards in addressing it: Rajnath at SCO

Press Trust of India
Dushanbe, October 20

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh on Tuesday called on member states of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) to make efforts to "dismantle the ecosystem of terrorism". He was addressing the 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of Government of the SCO in Tajikistan's Dushanbe, when he said that terrorism radicalises societies and deprives youth of the opportunities they deserve.

"There can be no justification for terrorism, no double standards in addressing it, and no place for those who finance, support, or provide safe havens to terrorists," Singh told the gathering, which included Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar, who was seated at the same table. Singh said that terrorism results in the loss of innocent lives and disrupts investment and commerce.



Rajnath Singh at the 25th SCO Council of Heads of Government Meeting, in Dushanbe, on Tuesday. ANI

The minister called upon the SCO members "to make concerted efforts to dismantle the entire ecosystem of terrorism". Singh emphasised the need for the SCO to build consensus and translate it into concrete action to address an uncertain global economic environment marked by geopolitical tensions, trade and supply chain disruptions, concerns over energy and food security, and emerging technological divides.

Underlining the importance of connectivity for shared prosperity, Singh said India supports initiatives that link markets, facilitate trade and create new avenues for development. He added that initiatives such as the International North-South Transport Corridor and the Chabahar Port can significantly help connect Central Asia with broader markets.

He, however, stressed that connectivity must be based on consultation and respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all countries.

Bypoll: NTK candidate held for blocking CM's convoy

Press Trust of India
Dharapuram (Tamil Nadu), October 20

NTK CANDIDATE for Dharapuram M Karthika, who unsuccessfully contested in the October 6 bypoll, was arrested in a case relating to a road blockade during Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay's roadshow in the Assembly constituency, police said on Tuesday.

Her arrest sparked political backlash in Tamil Nadu, with the opposition parties criticising the police action.

Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) functionary M Karthika and her husband Murugachandra Kumar were arrested from their residence in Coimbatore Tuesday. Police said a case was filed against Karthika and seven others, including her husband, two days before the October 6 bypoll, for staging a road blockade on the Dharapuram-Mulanur main road protesting against denial of police permission for her campaign, which clashed with Chief Minister Vijay's roadshow.

Karthika lost to the ruling TVK's P Sathyabama.

NTK chief coordinator Seeman called her arrest an act of "political vendetta", "authoritarian rule" by the TVK government and a "fabricated case".

Former chief minister and DMK president M K Stalin said, "The TVK government is behaving like an authoritarian regime devoid of tolerance and democratic spirit." he said.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (State Environment Impact Assessment Authority, Uttar Pradesh) has granted Environmental Clearance to the proposed Group Housing Project "ROSEMONT RESIDENCY" by M/s Park Town Complex Private Limited, located at Plot No. GH-3/2, Park Town, Integrated Township, Village – Shahpur Bamheta, Pargana – Dasna, Tehsil and District – Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh – 201002, vide EC Identification No. EC26B3812UP5810006N, dated 15/10/2026.

A copy of the Environmental Clearance issued by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change is available on the official websites **https://parivesh.nic.in (https://environmentclearance.nic.in)** and with the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board (UPPCB).

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Call to Action

THE TIGER Shroff firing incident seems to have had some political fallout too. Two key film bodies — the All Indian Cine Workers Association and the Federation of Western India Cine Employees — have written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, seeking the Centre's intervention to ensure the safety and security of film personalities. Many, including senior BJP and NDA leaders, have started wondering whether Bollywood's honeymoon with the BJP government is over. The incident has also given fresh ammunition to the critics of Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis. They claim that the incident and the subsequent reactions from the film industry show that the Chief Minister has failed to control the law and order situation. Party insiders say Fadnavis may be forced to visit New Delhi to explain the situation.

Rocky to Heera

THE ORANGUTAN that was repatriated from Vantara, Jamnagar, to a rehabilitation facility in Sumatra, Indonesia, on Monday was received by a Central minister there who rechristened it. During its post-rescue stay at Vantara, the primate was named Rocky. Indonesia's Minister of Forestry Raja Juli Antoni renamed it Heera (diamond), as the animal was precious, said those present at the welcoming ceremony. The Indonesian minister welcomed Heera with an assortment of fruits.

Kullu Dussehra begins

PREPARATIONS are complete for the week-long international Kullu Dussehra, which will commence in Dhalpur ground in Kullu town on Wednesday, officials said Tuesday. PTI



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar interacts with UAE Deputy PM and Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan during a meeting in Mumbai on Tuesday. ANI

Jaishankar, Al Nahyan discuss West Asia crisis, peace initiatives

Divya A
New Delhi, October 20

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS Minister S Jaishankar Tuesday held bilateral talks with his UAE counterpart Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan in Mumbai and reaffirmed New Delhi's support for every initiative encouraging peace through dialogue and diplomacy in the West Asia Region.

The two sides also discussed ways to enhance energy, trade and defence ties.

Al Nahyan, who is also the Deputy Prime Minister of the UAE, arrived in Mumbai on Monday evening for a two-day visit amid a recent surge in attacks targeting Saudi Arabia, believed to be carried out by Houthi rebels. Last week, Jaishankar had made a visit to the UAE, where he held discussions with the leaders of the Gulf country.

During his opening remarks at the meeting, Jaishankar said: "The situation in the Gulf remains a matter of deep concern... We continue to support free, safe and unimpeded flow of trade, energy and fertiliser. I would also like to thank you, and through you, the UAE leadership, for ensuring well-being of Indian community in the UAE."

While noting how the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) established between India and the UAE has substantially boosted bilateral trade and financial ties, Jaishankar said that despite geopolitical challenges, the commercial partnership between the two nations continues to establish "new benchmarks".

"The bilateral trade has crossed the $100 billion mark since the signing of the CEPA, and two-way investments continue to grow, reflecting the confidence of our businesses in each other's economies," he said, adding, "Cooperation in defence, energy and technology is acquiring a strategic character."

In a post on X after the meeting, Jaishankar said: "A productive meeting with DPM and FM UAE Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan, undertaking a comprehensive review of our wide-ranging ties. The breadth and ambition of our cooperation is visible across domains of trade, investments, energy, technology, logistics, defence, education and people-to-people ties. The India-UAE relationship is living up to its promise as a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership."

The UAE Foreign Ministry said Al Nahyan and Jaishankar discussed strengthening economic ties, expanding cooperation across sectors, and coordinating through international organisations ahead of the UAE-hosted 2026 UN Water Conference, in which India will participate.

e EXPLAINED

How India-UAE ties are expanding

Bilateral trade between India and the UAE has crossed the $100 billion mark following the signing of CEPA, while two-way investments also continue to grow. The UAE is now India's third-largest trading partner globally, after the United States and China.

Shah targets Punjab govt: 'Drug web growing, those raising voices unsafe'

CM: Activist Jhota murder probe to be handed over to CBI

Kamaldeep Singh Brar & Divya Goyal Gopal
Mansa, Ludhiana, Oct 20

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday accused the AAP government in Punjab of failing to protect those speaking out against drug trafficking, as he visited the families of three anti-drug activists who died in separate incidents across the state, assuring them of justice and a thorough investigation.

"The growing web of drugs in Punjab and the emboldened drug traffickers have raised serious questions about the functioning of the AAP government," Shah said in a statement, adding that "those raising their voices against drugs were not safe".

Hours before Shah arrived in Punjab, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann announced that the state government was handing over the investigation into the murder of anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota to the CBI. "We stand firmly with Parvinder Singh Jhota's father and his family at all times as they fight against drugs. Respecting the family's demand, we are handing over this case to the CBI. Our fight against drug traffickers is a battle to the finish. We will not back down from taking whatever stringent steps are necessary to make Punjab drug-free," Mann said.

During the day, Shah met Jhota's family in Mansa, the family of Gulzar Singh in Tur Banjara village in Sangrur district, and the family of Bikramjit Singh in Gurdaspur. The visits came amid mounting concerns over the drug menace in the state and allegations that those raising their voices were being targeted.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah meets family members of Parvinder Singh Jhota in Mansa, Punjab, Tuesday. EXPRESS

Later, addressing the media at Ludhiana's Punjab Agricultural University, Shah questioned the AAP government over its failure to make a single arrest under the PITNDPS Act, forensic reports pending for years and other "loopholes" in tackling the drug menace. "Neither the people of Punjab, nor I have any hopes from you," said Shah, blaming the AAP government for "grassroots level drug trade prevalent in each village of Punjab".

Quipping that Mann "did one good thing" by handing over Jhota's murder case to the CBI, Shah said, "I would like to promise the people of Punjab that all the accused in Jhota's killing, no matter how big or influential they are, we will find and dig them out from paatal (hell) and put them behind the bars to face the law and the court."

The Union Home Minister said the state government should hand over the two other drug-related murder cases to the CBI. "For my entire life, I won't be able to forget this Vijayadashmi... People who speak against drugs in Punjab are either murdered or forced to commit suicide... I never felt this sad and distressed before even as I meet grieving families across country but Punjab's pain has made me extremely sad. The reality of Punjab, as narrated by these families, is even grimmer than what we read in papers sitting in Delhi... it is far worse."

"I want to ask some questions from the AAP-led Punjab government... do they have any answers to someone losing their son, husband, brother? Do they have any answers except making excuses?" he said.

"I would like to remind the AAP leadership that you are ruling here with a pre-poll promise that you made in 2022 that you will end drugs within three months. It has been five years but the drug trade has only increased. Even your police are held with 10 kg heroin in routine," he said.

Slamming the AAP for blaming the BJP for drugs coming via the Gujarat and Maharashtra ports, Shah said: "Let me inform them that instead drugs worth Rs 20,000 crore have been confiscated from these two ports. Are they saying we should not confiscate them? But how does that drug get packed in a pudiya (packet) and reach Punjab? How does it reach Punjab's young boys and girls? Is it possible without the support, protection of political patronage?"

Shah says 'never felt so sad', after meeting drug menace victims

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Mansa, October 20

ON A day-long visit to Punjab Tuesday, Union Home Minister Amit Shah met families of three people whose deaths have been attributed to the state's drug menace. He said he had never felt so sad in his life and assured the families of justice, with a thorough investigation into the deaths.

The three deceased were anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota, who was murdered in broad daylight, Gulzar Singh, who died by suicide, and Bikramjit Singh, who was killed.

The three:

- **Parvinder Singh Jhota, 42:** The son of retired Armyman Bhim Singh, dairy farmer Jhota was shot dead on October 13. Having fought drug addiction himself as a college student, Jhota was a prominent anti-drug activist locally, and would put up videos on social media of medical shops allegedly selling prescription medicines illegally to addicts. He also tried to get young people off drugs by getting them interested in sports.

The family has refused to carry out Jhota's cremation till they are assured of a thorough probe. It has also rejected government compensation and employment offers.

Bhim Singh said Shah told them during his visit that the CBI would take over the case.

Those arrested for Jhota's killing include alleged shooter Ashwani Kumar, his wife Neelam Rani, his cousin Vipin Kumar and an associate, Laadi.

- **Gulzar Singh, 47:** A daily wager from Tur Banjara village in Sangrur, the CM's home district, Gulzar died by suicide on September 7 after allegedly consuming poison.

Gulzar's family said he was fighting a desperate battle to keep his eldest son off drugs, and that he was harassed after he posed questions regarding the easy availability of drugs to Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema during the latter's visit to their village.

The family has demanded a case against Cheema. It has also questioned the "rush" to cremate him, claiming it was done without their consent. Officials said a judicial inquiry has not found any of the allegations to be true.

Five people — Baljit Singh, Gona Singh, Sukhdev Singh, Vicky Singh and Baljinder Singh — have been arrested.

"Pressure on Gulzar, who had opposed the drug trade, had become so intense that he took his own life," Shah said.

- **Bikramjit Singh, 40:** Bikramjit, who did odd jobs to make a living, was killed on October 16 in Mari Panwan village in Gurdaspur, after he and his companions allegedly confronted some individuals selling drugs. A group armed with sharp weapons assaulted them, leaving Bikramjit critically injured. He died during treatment.

The FIR names Jugraj Singh alias Kalu, Shubh, Prince, Balwinder Kaur and Manjit Kaur, along with another unidentified person. His niece Harmeet Kaur said: "The reason for the murder of my uncle was drug smugglers. It was not any accident."

After meeting the family, the Union minister said: "The killing raises serious questions about the safety of people who oppose the drug trade... They are not safe (in Punjab)."

Tiger Shroff attack case: 2 women among four held in Delhi for supplying weapon

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, October 20

THE DELHI Police Special Cell's Northern Range (NDR) on Tuesday arrested four accused in an alleged weapon supply module linked to the October 18 firing incident targeting actor Tiger Shroff's car in Mumbai, a senior police officer said on Tuesday.

The arrested accused have been identified as Kunal (21) and Sumit (19), both residents of Sonipat district in Haryana, and Radha (23) and Babita (23), both residents of Uttar Pradesh.

The Special Cell arrested Radha and Babita at New Delhi Railway Station, while Kunal and Sumit were arrested in Sonipat, the officer said.

The four accused were produced before a court, according to the police.

Subsequently, officials of the Maharashtra Police's Crime Investigation Department (CID) sought permission for their custodial interrogation and formal arrests.

According to the police, Kunal, who was recently released from jail on bail, was introduced to a person identified as Anil Pandit by a friend from Harsana village. He allegedly began communicating with Pandit through an encrypted messaging application.

On Pandit's directions, Kunal allegedly collected a pistol and 20 rounds of ammunition from Amritsar, the officer said.

Around two months ago, Kunal allegedly met Radha, disclosed his activities to her and developed a relationship with her. He subsequently persuaded her to travel to Mumbai with the weapon, according to the police.



Maharashtra minister Ashish Shelar meets actor Tiger Shroff in connection with a firing incident in Mumbai, on Tuesday. PTI

On October 15, Kunal allegedly took Radha and Babita to New Delhi Railway Station. The pistol was in Radha's bag. During the journey, Kunal allegedly remained in contact with them, relaying instructions from Pandit, the officer said.

The two women reached Dadar in Mumbai on October 17 and checked into a hotel.

At around 11 am, a minor boy allegedly collected the bag from Radha near the hotel, the officer added. On the evening of October 18, at around 7 pm, shots were fired at Tiger Shroff's car in Mumbai.

Following the incident, Pandit allegedly contacted Kunal and told him that the shooters were stranded in Mumbai, asking him to arrange their escape. Radha and Babita subsequently left Mumbai for Delhi aboard the Dadar–Haridwar Express on October 18, the officer said.

The four were arrested by the Special Cell on October 20.

Lucknow cafe owner's death: 11-day hunt for model ends in Nagpur arrest

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, October 20

ON THE run for 11 days, model-influencer Shraddha Dubey, 30, wanted in connection with the death of Lucknow cafe owner Shiva Sharma, was arrested from a Nagpur flat on Tuesday along with her sister Rashmi Dubey and driver Tanveer Ali alias Danish, police said.

A joint team of the Lucknow Police and the Uttar Pradesh Special Task Force (STF), with assistance from Nagpur Police, arrested the three. They will be brought to Lucknow on a transit remand.

Shiva, 27, died on the night of October 9 after falling from the fourth floor of Shraddha's rented flat at Awadh Green Apartment in Lucknow's Hazratganj area. Shraddha, his alleged live-in partner, had been on the run since then.

The case attracted attention amid allegations by Shiva's family that he was thrown off the building. Based on a complaint by his mother, Ranjana Sharma, police registered an FIR against the three on murder charges at Hazratganj police station. After they remained absconding, police obtained non-bailable warrants against them and announced a reward of Rs 50,000 for information leading to each of their arrests.

A senior police officer said the three accused left for Nepal immediately after Shiva's death and stayed there for seven days. Police claimed to have found footage of them crossing the border. They frequently changed locations, making it difficult for police to trace them. They returned to India recently.

— WITH PTI INPUTS

6 bouncers held for assault on garba revellers at Navratri event in Gujarat

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, October 20

THE AHMEDABAD Rural Police on Monday arrested six security guards – bouncers – for the armed assault of several youths and aggravated rioting at a mandali garba event near Nasmed village near Thol Lake.

The six bouncers, all from Punjab, many of whom were allegedly carrying sharp weapons, were arrested by the Santej police on Monday night, said Inspector S R Chaudhari. They were presented in court Tuesday.

These included Simranjeet Singh Prabhjeet Singh Bhatia (23) of Jalandhar, Punjab; Gujpreet Singh Sarabjeet Singh Bajigar (29) of Tarn Taran, Punjab; Indrajeet Singh Joginder Singh Ramgadiya (27) of Jalandhar, Punjab; Kashish Gurumat Singh Mistry (29) of Sri Muktsar Sahib, Punjab; Sukhwant Singh Kuldeep Singh Bhatti (33) of Sri Muktsar Sahib, Punjab; and Gurjeet Baldev Siddhu (25) of Sri Muktsar Sahib, Punjab.

The incident allegedly occurred around 1 am on October 19. An FIR was registered at 2 pm following a complaint by Maulik Rashmiji Thakor.

The FIR stated a group of friends attended a mandali garba near Nasmed village. While complainant scanned their entry passes on his phone, his friend Hiren Patel stayed back as the others entered.

The FIR said a bouncer asked Hiren to enter the venue, but he insisted on accompanying Thakor. The bouncer argued with him, and another allegedly struck Thakor on the head with a sword hilt. Around 10 armed bouncers then allegedly chased and assaulted the group, injuring several people.

Mika, Alisha, Harshdeep, Badshah rally behind Daler post 'public humiliation'

Suanshu Khurana & Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, Dehradun, October 20

PLAYBACK SINGER and pop artiste Mika Singh, rapper Badshah, playback singers Harshdeep Kaur, Shaan, Alisha Chinai and actor-comedian Kapil Sharma have come out in support of indie pop-star Daler Mehndi after a video of the veteran performer being confronted on stage at a Navratri event in Uttarakhand's Tehri Garhwal went viral.

Citing Mehndi's recent surgery and ill health, the artistes said respect and kindness should be extended to performing artistes, especially when they are vulnerable.

At the 50th Maa Kunjapuri Mela (an annual tourism and development fair) on Sunday, Uttarakhand Cabinet Minister and Narendra Nagar MLA Subodh Uniyal stopped Mehndi mid-concert, accusing him of performing under the influence of alcohol and lip-syncing the songs.

Uniyal got on stage and told Mehndi: "You are fooling people... We called you because you are a big name... But you are not able to speak; how will you sing?"

The singer appeared disoriented and struggled to perform. During the conversation, he kept requesting the minister to go back to his seat. The encounter, since the Navratri event, has been facing much online scrutiny.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* on Tuesday, Uniyal said, "If he was not physically fit, he should not have come to the programme... You are making a fool of yourself ... and if you cannot speak properly, you should not have come. He should have maintained the dignity expected of a great artiste..."

"The money had been paid, first-class tickets had been booked for several people, and hotels had been arranged. I have got a few calls to issue a statement saying that he was on medication, but I refuse to do so," said the minister.

Mika Singh, Mehndi's brother, said in an Instagram video that his elder brother does not consume alcohol, attributing his condition to ill health and a medical procedure he recently underwent. "It has been spread in the media that Daler Mehndi was drunk while singing... I want to ask you all: he is a superstar for the last 30 years; has anyone ever seen him drinking? Has anyone ever seen alcohol at his birthday party?"



An Uttarakhand minister stopped Daler Mehndi mid-concert, accusing him of performing under the influence of alcohol on Sunday.

Sharing Mika's video on Instagram, actor-comedian Kapil Sharma posted: "@thedalermehndiofficial paji went through some serious surgery which people don't know. All we need to do is to be kinder towards others...We don't know what someone is going through."

Harshdeep Kaur called Mehndi "a legend" and said he did seem unwell because "otherwise when on stage, he not just sings, he roars".

Alisha Chinai, while commenting on Mika's post, said Mehndi "did not need to prove that he can sing... or seek any validation".

She added that everyone uses backing vocals and minus-one tracks on shows. "How dare someone come onstage and insult him in this manner. It speaks of tasteless behaviour and reflects poorly on the minister..."

Indie artiste and playback singer Sona Mohapatra spoke of how Mehndi was disoriented at a festival in the Capital earlier this year as well, where she was also performing and how it was heartbreaking for her to watch that.

She also added that while public humiliation was not the answer, "the conversation has become about the indignity suffered by the artiste and so little about the expectations of the audience and the responsibility of those accepting substantial professional fees".

Rapper Badshah backed Mehndi. "You can express disappointment, but publicly humiliating an artist who has given so much to our music industry is extremely disheartening," he shared on social media.

Singer Shaan, too, defended the artiste, calling him the "original rockstar".

Mehndi emerged as a force in the '90s post-liberalisation and amid the boom of cable television and channels like MTV India and Channel V, which completely shifted India's musical landscape. He was at the peak of India's indie pop scene in those years.

In his music videos, Mehndi came dressed in flowing robes, with a turban and a high-energy voice, and turned Punjabi folk into a pop phenomenon.

From his debut album Bolo tara rara (1995) to the infectious hooks of Tunak tunak tun (1998), the songs took the subcontinent by a storm long before social media could propel artistes and their music to mass success.

‘On US-India deal... it’s down to certain words, phrases... We are weeks from finalising it... 99% of the work is done’

US Secy of State Marco Rubio soothes Delhi’s concerns, says Pakistan or China, ‘our relationship with any country will never come at the expense of India’, and underlines that Trump administration’s tariffs, tighter visa regimes are not directed at India

Shubhajit Roy
Mumbai, October 20



PHOTOS: AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

US SECRETARY OF STATE Marco Rubio’s second visit to India in less than five months comes at a crucial juncture in India-US ties, with the trade deal yet to be finalised and the about-turns in Washington’s tariff regime and its dealings with Moscow keeping Delhi on the tenterhooks. In an exclusive interview with *The Indian Express*, Rubio describes the ties between India and the US as “positive”, and “the feature of our foreign policy”. Edited excerpts:

It has been about two years since you took charge as the US Secretary of State. How do you see the trajectory of India-US relationship in this time?

I think positive, and in many ways, it has become a feature of our foreign policy. It’s one that we are very focused on. In fact... my very first meeting was with the Quad (grouping) that includes, of course, India, and since then I have had multiple interactions with... must be over a dozen... with my counterparts here, at every forum. This is my second visit here, you have also seen at high levels of our government, (people) visit here, and of course, we had the bilateral visit by the Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) to the United States. We are going to continue to build on that.

Now look, we have some challenges because this is not a small country, it is big and important. It has a large economy, it has an enormous business class. So trade has been an irritant, and we are working through on the trade relationship... it needs to be solved. But I also think that, even as that process continues, we have so many areas of cooperation. The Quad being an example, an area of very strong cooperation that is beginning to turn ideas into action... It’s a very, very positive relationship, and that would not be possible without a strong US-India relationship.

While President Trump has just waived sanctions on purchase of Russian oil, which is a relief to India, there is concern that it might be imposed at some point. Does it put some stress on economic ties?

It can, there is no doubt about it. And that is why it has to be managed very carefully, and the relationship we have is so critical... None of these tariffs are meant to punish or harm India. They are part of a broader foreign policy that, unfortunately, involves a war going on between Russia and Ukraine, that we would like to see come to an end. And I’m sure you saw it in our media and our political system (that), when the President issued those waivers and did not impose the tariffs required under a law passed by our Congress, he got criticism for doing it. But one of the reasons why he didn’t impose them is because he understands that it would have a very detrimental impact on a very important relationship with India.

So, it’s part of balancing foreign policy, and it’s difficult because, on the one hand, you want to make sure you can pressure the warring parties to the table to negotiate an outcome in that war... and, on the other hand, sometimes by imposing pressure through tariffs, you’re creating stress on other important relationships... I think the President is trying very hard to balance that... but it will be a challenge.

Washington and Delhi have been negotiating a trade deal for almost a year-and-a-half now... Both sides have indicated they are trying to find a landing ground. How far are we from a deal, and what are the sticking points?

I don’t want to get into the details of the sticking points. I can simply tell you that (they are) there. I won’t call them technicalities, but it’s language-related. It’s basically down to what certain words mean, what certain phrases mean. Because it’s important for both sides to have full agreement, Both sides have to 100% agree on what a deal means. If they don’t, then in the future it can unravel....

I think we’re incredibly close. The way I would say it is, we are weeks, not months, away from I think finalising it. I think 99% of the work is done. The remaining factor, you have to have 100% done. But I feel very positive about the trajectory that it’s on.

You have been an early champion of the Quad framework (including US, India, Australia and Japan), as you said. But there is a sense that the Trump administration’s view of China has changed from the first term to the second. It’s seen as soft on China.

Soft is not the right terminology. I think the right terminology is that China — and you know this well, because India also has relationships with China — is a large economy. It’s a powerful country. It’s a country we have to have relations with... our relationship with them needs to be balanced. We are most certainly going to have disagreements with them. We have them now... There are things they are doing that we consider harmful to the interests of the United States, and so even now action is being taken, whether export controls or measures that cause irritants. So the attitude of this administration has been to try to find a level of strategic stability, an understanding that if things go bad, if the United States and China get into a trade war or any other conflict for that matter, it would be incredibly detrimental to the world.

> One of the few places that can actually refine Venezuelan heavy crude is India, and Reliance... (Jamnagar visit) is an opportunity to identify opportunities to achieve our goal of diversifying energy resources...

But it won’t be easy because you have these two very large, powerful countries, large, powerful economies, large, powerful militaries... So we’re going to continue to press on those items that we think are against our national interest, but at the same time, try to manage the relationship in a way that doesn’t escalate into something far more dangerous or detrimental, not just for us but for the world. A US-China trade war would be devastating to the global economy. It would impact India. It would impact virtually every country... So it’s a challenge this administration has taken on, in a way that has been reasonable and balanced.



There is a huge Indian diaspora. A lot of students travel to the US to study. But in recent times, the H-1B debate, restrictions on visas, and the political anti-immigrant rhetoric are seen as antagonistic towards Indians. A plot to attack a temple was foiled just last week. How do you assuage these concerns?

So the first thing is that every country has to have immigration laws. If they don’t, they are not a sovereign country. And, this is not about India, this applies globally... What has happened in the United States, unfortunately, is that for a number of years, especially under the four years of President Joe Biden, 20 million people entered the country unlawfully... Frankly, we have seen many of these programmes being abused. Again, it is not unique to Indians or India... We have seen a rise in birth tourism, that has nothing to do with India but with other countries. Things of this nature. So we are trying to fix 20 years of neglect of an immigration system... and that is not targeted towards India.

Now, obviously, because of the developments, because of the ties between our countries, because of how developed your economy is, there are certain categories of visas that see a large number of Indians applying for... We are simply trying to fix our immigration system so that we can arrive at one in which we are always going to welcome immigrants and visitors to the United States. We want people to visit the United States. We want people to study in the United States. There are certain people that we want, that want to come work for a time in the United States. We want people to invest in the United States, and we are always going to have people immigrate to the United States. But we want it done through a system of laws that are complied with...

> A US-China trade war would be devastating to the global economy. It would impact India. It would impact virtually every country... So it’s a challenge this administration has taken on, in a way that has been reasonable and balanced

The biggest threat to legal immigration is illegal immigration. The biggest threat to legal immigration is mass migration, which again is not an Indian phenomenon (but) more unique to other parts of the world... That’s what we are trying to solve. And while I know that from your perspective here in India, it may seem targeted at India, (but) it’s not. There is virtually no country on Earth that I visit where I don’t get a complaint about some visa or process, because we are fixing it globally. Once it’s fixed, it will be far more sustainable. I actually think it will be better for the people using those programmes, and right and good for the United States.

The proximity between the Trump administration and Pakistan, particularly its General, has not gone down well in India. Some in India even see a return to the Nixon-Kissinger era, when the US administration backed Pakistan’s military rulers.

Well, I would not use the 1970s as an example because the world looks nothing like it did back then. Back then, we had the Cold War and all sorts of other dynamics that no longer exist. Number two, I would say that our relationship with no country in the world, in any way, comes at the expense of our relationship with India. I hope my visits here, our commitment to doing the trade deal, all of the engagements that we have done, all the work that we do together, is evidence of that....

Pakistan is a country we have a relationship with, and we need to have a relationship with. And, in some ways, it could be a positive thing if we could help discourage actions that could potentially lead to conflict, if we could use our influence in ways that are positive... But what everyone should be assured of in India is that our relationship, not just with Pakistan but with any country in the world, will never come at the expense of our relationship. We don’t view it that way in our relationship with India.

> One of the reasons why President Trump didn’t impose sanctions on Russian oil is because he understands that it would have a very detrimental impact on a very important relationship with India... It’s part of balancing foreign policy

You are stopping over at Jamnagar, Gujarat, during your India visit, and I want to talk about the energy cooperation on the agenda, Reliance investment in a Texas refinery, and your meeting with the Ambanis. Incidentally, this comes a week after Elon Musk accused the Ambanis of blocking the entry of his Starlink to India.

Yeah, well, Elon Musk is a private citizen, so you know he has the right to express himself and say whatever he wants. Our country has free speech, and he is an important private citizen. He owns important businesses, but he is a private citizen. So I can’t speak to that.

What I can speak to is why it’s important that we have this meeting... The whole world is interested in diversifying how we get energy. I don’t think we want a world in which an overwhelming amount of the global energy comes from one part of the world that is prone to conflict. I think this is a company (Reliance) and this is a country (India) that has refining capacity. We have, for example, Venezuela that is going to be rapidly increasing the production of oil and crude, heavy crude, which can only be refined in certain parts of the world. One of those places is the Gulf Coast of the United States, but one of the few other places in the world that can actually refine Venezuelan heavy crude is India, and Reliance.

That is important because it helps utilise and unleash the energy that is being developed in the Western Hemisphere. But also, they have invested in the United States... it’s one of the first new, refining expansions in the United States in recent times. That is a very important investment. So I think it’s an opportunity to see how they operate, but also to identify opportunities to achieve our mutual goal of diversifying our energy resources.

India has initiated a proposal for a Russia-Ukraine ceasefire. How do you see India’s involvement?

It can be very positive. Unfortunately, as I said, the problem with the Black Sea ceasefire has been that the strikes occurring there have strategic value to the combatants. That is what has made it so difficult. But we applaud the very positive work. I reviewed the text that about a week-and-a-half ago the Indian side put together.

I think they have played a very positive role to try solve a very difficult conflict... to sort of save the world from the implications that it’s having on energy. And we welcome India’s involvement. I think they have a very professional diplomatic corps and have done an excellent job of trying to bring the parties together. It has just been difficult.

WEB EXCLUSIVE
Courts must earn confidence, not demand faith
— *Govind Manoharan*
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There is no sincerer love than the love of food.
— *George Bernard Shaw*

The Indian EXPRESS
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RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932
BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

On right to internet, Court ruling isn't enough

THE SUPREME Court, on October 15, delivered a ruling that is significant for two reasons: It tightened the rules on child sexual exploitation and abuse material online, and it declared access to and use of the internet a fundamental right under Articles 19 and 21 of the Constitution. These provisions guarantee the freedom of speech and expression and the right to life and personal liberty. On both aspects of the ruling, however, much depends on whether they remain on paper, and how they translate into practice. On this count, both invite serious questions.

Citing gaps in compliance with existing statutory norms under the Information Technology Rules, the bench directed the government to build a national database of digital identifiers for child abuse material. It requires platforms to remove "known origin" matches from the database, even without verifying them. Intermediaries have been asked to judge content by its propensity to facilitate exploitation, even where it is not explicit. The Court also suggested hefty fines on intermediaries that don't comply with rules to remove such content. To be sure, child safety is an urgent issue and needs more proactive state intervention. However, it will take a meticulous institutional architecture to govern the use and misuse of databases, not just the Court's assurance.

The SC's recognition of access to the internet as a fundamental right only calls attention to the extremely fraught context it comes in — restricting the internet is often the first weapon in the state's toolkit for policing. In principle, elevating it as a fundamental right allows a citizen to directly move the SC for its enforcement and confines future laws on screen time curbs within narrowly defined and constitutionally permissible limits. But the real test lies in how rights are realised. Scholars have long pointed to an anomaly — the Court expands Article 21 faster than it steps in to secure the rights guaranteed under it. Citizens may be told they have a right to a speedy trial or clean air or safe roads, but when the state fails to deliver, they cannot invoke those rights in court meaningfully. Saying that access to the internet is part of the fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression, therefore, is not enough. That recognition must be put to work when internet shutdowns are imposed unreasonably and disproportionately — that is when the Court must intervene to restrain the state instead of kicking the can down the road.

Involve people, focus on what ails Yamuna

REPORTS OF thousands of dead fish floating in the Yamuna near Burari in Delhi last week were a warning of the river's poor health. Experts have not conclusively established the cause of the deaths, but point to possible industrial effluents, low dissolved oxygen levels and inadequate environmental flows. The Delhi government's "Chalo Yamuna" clean-up drive is, therefore, timely. On Sunday, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and other BJP leaders joined volunteers in clearing waste from 70 ghats, while appealing to residents to stop discarding plastic, broken idols and religious offerings into the river. Involving the public in restoring the Yamuna's health is welcome. But the fish deaths, reported from a stretch upstream of the Wazirabad barrage, generally considered relatively cleaner than much of the river flowing through Delhi, underline the scale of the Yamuna challenge. The episode should remind the government to stay the course in addressing the river's chronic problems.

Since assuming office last year, the Rekha Gupta government has announced investments in sewage treatment and drainage. However, even by conservative estimates, close to 200 million litres of sewage continues to flow untreated into the Yamuna every day. At least seven sewage treatment plants failed to meet prescribed water-quality standards in September, according to the Delhi Pollution Control Committee's latest report. The interceptor drain project, intended to capture sewage from drains in the city's slum clusters before it enters the larger drains that empty into the Yamuna, has also been dogged by fragmented responsibilities. These shortcomings point to a familiar problem of river rejuvenation projects — investments not translating into adequate results on the ground.

An approach centred on sewage treatment will not be enough to cleanse the Yamuna. The river needs adequate clean water flows to dilute residual pollutants. Drains carrying urban sewage and industrial effluents from neighbouring areas can undermine efforts in Delhi. Pollution control authorities in the Capital cannot, therefore, clean the river in isolation. The Centre must bring Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh together to set common pollution targets, share data and establish clear lines of accountability. Environmental flows, industrial discharge and sewage treatment need to be addressed as parts of the same problem. The Chalo Yamuna campaign can encourage residents to treat the river with greater care. But public participation will need to be matched by sustained investment, scientific oversight, diligent enforcement and cooperation among the states that share the river.

Never let the sauce go dry

IN VOGUE'S 1948 *Book of Etiquette*, Millicent Fenwick, editor, and later Republican Party politician, noted that one of the most offending habits at the dinner table was to mop up sauces with bread or to dip bread in coffee. But, she added, there were exceptions -- "... sopping up sauces or gravy with a piece of bread is standard practice in the good, hearty eating ways of middle-class Continental Europe; here (in America), it is regarded as a little eccentric..."

Nearly a century later, in Italy, where the pleasures of the table are taken seriously, diners seem to be still torn over that question: To mop or not to mop. After all, a buttery pool flecked with herbs, the last smear of a ragu or the remains of a fresh Ligurian sauce made with basil, garlic, pine nuts, olive oil and a generous drizzle of Pecorino seem to demand the *fare la scarpetta* — to souse the bread in the last trace of jus on the plate in an expression of unabashed gastronomic satisfaction.

As the world grows smaller, such contradictions offer a glimpse of the subtle ways in which culture shapes ideas of pleasure and propriety. In Japan, slurping noodles and a clean plate are a compliment to the host, but not so in China, where good manners insist upon a token morsel left uneaten. In France, mealtimes are meant to be long leisurely affairs, not partaken in the manner of a business lunch. Perhaps the lesson in all of this is that dining etiquette is not merely a matter of knowing which fork to use or whether elbows should be on the table, but to learn to embrace the vibe. And to always leave room for a little sauce.

Rubio in Jamnagar, and a changing map of the new diplomacy



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

THE SIGNIFICANCE of US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit to the Reliance refinery in Jamnagar on Wednesday will extend beyond the familiar debate over India-US relations. Jamnagar offers a window into India's complex energy politics that have shaped Delhi's recent engagement with Washington, Moscow and Tehran. Rubio's interaction with the Tatas and the Adanis in Mumbai and his talks with Mukesh Ambani in Jamnagar also highlight the growing connection between Indian capital and the nation's foreign policy. As Indian companies acquire greater economic weight and wider global reach, they are becoming an important part of India's diplomatic arsenal, much like in other large nations.

The relationship between American business and foreign policy was captured in the adage "what is good for General Motors is good for America". General Motors no longer occupies the commanding position it once did, but the principle remains relevant. American finance and technology companies loom large in US foreign policy today.

The House of Morgan's involvement in the geopolitics of the early 20th century endures in a different form today. The CEO of JPMorgan Chase, Jamie Dimon, is received like royalty in Beijing and other capitals. Meanwhile, the new tech bros of Silicon Valley have begun to exercise great influence in 21st-century world politics. Europeans pioneered this approach through their East India companies in the 17th century. Today, European governments work closely with their companies to win markets and contracts. China's "go out" policy since the late 1990s has encouraged Chinese firms to expand overseas, extending Beijing's economic reach and political influence.

The sight of Mukesh Ambani alongside world leaders might seem unusual to Indian audiences. But it reflects the culmination of a long-running change. A few years ago, foreign leaders visiting India routinely toured the Infosys campus in Bengaluru, when the country's IT companies were emerging as global players. Last October, British prime minister Keir Starmer visited Mumbai (not Delhi!) and met Prime Minister Narendra Modi there. He engaged with Indian business leaders and struck deals with Bollywood producers on film production partnerships with British studios. Where Indian capital commands scale or possesses a distinctive advantage, it increasingly becomes part of the diplomatic equation.

At Jamnagar, that advantage lies in the old economy of hydrocarbons. The world's largest refining complex can process different grades of crude oil and supply refined products to markets across the globe. Reliance is a major crude importer and an important exporter of diesel, aviation fuel and other petroleum products. Its commercial decisions connect oil producers with consumers thousands of kilometres away. Jamnagar's importance has grown since Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 and the disruption of oil supplies through the Strait of Hormuz. Ensuring India's energy security has been a central challenge for Indian diplomacy since the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022. The Biden administration sought to limit Moscow's revenues through a price cap, recognising that shutting out Russian oil would destabilise global energy markets.

> Reliance offers a substantial private-sector partner. The question is how Delhi can turn the company's growing importance in American calculations into an asset for India-US relations

Donald Trump reversed course, threatening sanctions on customers of Russian oil as part of his pressure tactics to promote peace in Ukraine. The US Congress compounded the uncertainty by passing legislation to impose sweeping sanctions on Russian oil exports. As turmoil in energy markets began to affect American domestic politics, Washington had to make a U-turn again. It eased some restrictions on Iranian oil and subsequently on Russian oil exports. Trump is now exploring bilateral energy deals with Russia as part of his renewed outreach to President Vladimir Putin.

Jamnagar has been at the centre of these shifting currents in oil politics. Its ability to switch suppliers and redirect products across markets demonstrates the value of a sophisticated refiner with global reach. As Washington gained control over Venezuelan oil exports, Jamnagar emerged as a preferred destination for the country's heavy crude. Reliance's engagement with the US is also becoming more direct. In March, the US announced the launch of a new refinery in Brownsville, Texas, to be backed by Reliance.

Washington wants greater energy cooperation with India and more Indian investment in the US. Reliance offers a substantial private-sector partner. The question is how Delhi can turn the company's growing importance in American calculations into an asset for India-US relations.

Business has played a role in Indian diplomacy before. The Hindujas used their commercial connections with Iran to facilitate a rapprochement between Delhi and Tehran after the 1973 oil crisis. After the 1998 nuclear tests, Delhi turned to the Hindujas to facilitate engagement with British prime minister Tony Blair. American businesses, too, have been important partners in overcoming India's difficulties in relations with Washington. Companies such as General Electric helped build support in the US for better ties with India during the 1990s. Beijing, meanwhile, has long relied on American business to help moderate tensions with Washington.

The international system has never been shaped by states alone. Capital and technology have long influenced the choices available to governments. Capital cannot replace the state as the principal actor in international relations, but it is becoming an increasingly important part of the diplomatic process around the world. Sensible states prevent the excessive concentration of capital at home and set the terms for its global role. As Indian companies acquire the scale to operate across borders and navigate geopolitical turbulence, they will become more consequential actors in India's external relations.

Rubio's visit to Jamnagar is a reminder that understanding contemporary Indian foreign policy requires a better appreciation of the intricate and inseparable relations between capitalism and modern international relations. That, in turn, means tempering Delhi's abstruse foreign policy debates with Mumbai's commercial logic and Bengaluru's technological imperative.

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In Bhagwat's speech, a hard line on protests



NEERJA CHOWDHURY

USUALLY, RSS Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat expresses his opinion elliptically. His words have to be decoded to glean the underlying message. But on Tuesday morning, the RSS chief did not mince his words as he delivered his customary annual Vijayadashami (Dussehra) day address in Nagpur. As the head of the "cultural" organisation that has mentored the ruling BJP since its inception, the RSS chief ruled out "regime change" in India. He was alluding to the ongoing protests in Delhi, Mumbai and other cities demanding the resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar.

Bhagwat went a step further. He saw a "global conspiracy" behind the recent developments and specifically named the "West" for the "storm that is coming in". Bhagwat also spoke of the violent developments that have taken place in France, Albania, Nepal and Bangladesh, with India remaining the "ultimate target" of forces trying to destabilise the country.

Bhagwat's words showed that whatever the RSS's recent reservations about the BJP leadership's style of functioning, it is in sync with the party's thinking on the protests, led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and the Opposition, particularly Congress. Rahul Gandhi has targeted the PM, Home Minister, Bhagwat and Ajit Doval as those running the present system. He demanded the resignations of the PM and HM and vowed to "destroy" (not replace) the BJP and RSS.

Those who know the RSS chief say that he expresses the views of the Sangh and is not given to speaking impromptu. The RSS's latest stand shows that on major issues, it has decided to be on the same page as the BJP.

Tension had crept into the BJP-RSS relationship during the 2024 general elections. Many attribute the BJP's less-than-majority tally of 240 Lok Sabha seats to the RSS not coming out to campaign for the party as vigorously as it used to. BJP chief J P Nadda's words that the party no longer needed handholding by the RSS — in an interview to this newspaper — only complicated the relationship, for few bought the line that Nadda would say what he did on his own. In his 2024 Vijayadashami address, Bhagwat had spoken of Hindu unity, the plight of Hindus in Bangladesh and women's safety, and launched an attack on "cultural Marxism".

This is not to say that Bhagwat let the BJP off completely in his Tuesday address. Sometimes, people lose trust in politicians, he said, but did not make a distinction between one lot of politicians and another. It is then that society has to take responsibility and that "includes us" (RSS). He also referred to the talk about India as "*vishwaguru*". It is the "*nayi peedi*" (new generation) of leaders, he said, whose bodies and minds are healthy, who will have to accept this responsibility to make India a *vishwaguru*.

The RSS's invitation to the former vice president, Jagdeep Dhankhar, to be the chief guest for the occasion has raised many an eyebrow. Dhankhar has said very little about his dramatic exit from office in July 2025, and there is speculation about his sudden resignation.

The BJP may now decide to up the ante against the protesters, with the RSS chief backing the party line. When the CJP protest took place in June-July 2026 in what came to be known as Jantar Mantar-1, and following the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, Bhagwat had adopted a softer line towards the protestors. He said the era of unquestioned "obedience" was over. He went on to engage with around 2,000 youth at the Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre in Mumbai with a view to reaching out to Gen Z. Now, the RSS chief suspects that the protests may have become a "tool of politics" used by forces seeking to "undermine Bharat".

The RSS cadre may now decide to wholeheartedly campaign for the BJP in the states going to the polls early next year, and that could be another signal in Bhagwat's Vijayadashami speech. By all accounts, the RSS has already knuckled down to work in Uttar Pradesh to ensure that Yogi Adityanath comes back to power. Many in the RSS see him as a leader who could play a national role and take the RSS's "civilisational agenda" forward.

A tougher line against the protestors will exert pressure on opposition parties, more than anything else, to close ranks, as it becomes an existential battle for them.

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The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

China's AI export order is a switch, not a wall



BHARATH REDDY

A DRAFT proposal by China's Ministry of Commerce (MOFCOM) adds advanced AI technologies to its export-control list. Almost nothing changes for exporters today, but China now holds the means to monitor, slow or stop the flow of its AI technology abroad. On October 16, MOFCOM issued two things. The first is a draft revision of the Catalogue of Technologies Prohibited or Restricted from Export, adding 23 AI items within a wider list of 40 technologies (including biotech and solar). Once in force, restricted items will need an export licence and prohibited items cannot be exported. The second is a temporary registration requirement, already in force, under which exporters must disclose any transfer of covered technology (like model weights, code, architecture, hardware optimisations) before it happens. Both apply to transfers of technology, not to the sale of AI services.

Foundation models are a notable inclusion. A model's core technologies are restricted if it crosses one of these thresholds: 10^{26} training FLOPs (Floating-Point Operations Per Second), 2 trillion parameters, or a top-10 global ranking on a qualifying measure. Models trained on "important data" under China's Data Security Law are also restricted, and those trained on "core data" are prohibited. Open-weight models that have been widely adopted across the world get "automatic licensing", which means that a licence is still legally required, but approval is meant to be quick and procedural.

MOFCOM frames the order around safety and risk, but its design makes more sense as an instrument of control. First, the net is wide and discretionary. The restrictions seem to target capabilities rather than its riskiest systems, as indicated by criteria such as presence in global top 10 rankings or training on important data. This would catch almost any Chinese frontier model. Second, the order does not restrict API access: Foreign users can use the same capabilities as a service. But that keeps them dependent on a Chinese provider, unlike a transfer of the model's weights, which would hand over control. Third, the change-of-control clause targets foreign ownership or control changes, even if no code crosses a border. This resembles how Meta's acquisition of the Chinese agentic AI startup Manus was blocked by Chinese regulators. Finally, the other controls target economically valuable technologies, not just the high-risk ones.

Nothing changes for now, but the basis for leverage exists. Developers fine-tuning Qwen or DeepSeek are unaffected, as already released weights are in the public domain. Future releases that cross the thresholds will need a licence that Beijing can control. Diversity matters, of both jurisdictions and model vendors. China has now built a licensing gate for open releases, and the US has shown that it can abruptly cut off access to closed frontier models. An open ecosystem needs more contenders, like a consortium of companies and governments from India, Europe, and the Gulf. Indian builders should design technology stacks that avoid lock-in to a model or agentic framework. India's opportunity lies in diffusion: Investing in the talent and compute to fine-tune, distil and adapt whichever open model is best and available.

> The restrictions seem to target capabilities rather than its riskiest systems, as indicated by criteria such as presence in global top 10 rankings or training on important data. This would catch almost any Chinese frontier model

The writer is an associate fellow with the Takshashila Institution

40 YEARS AGO
October 21, 1986


INDIAN EXPRESS
Mozambique President killed in plane crash
S. African hand alleged

Mozambique president dies

PRESIDENT SAMORA Machel of Mozambique was one of the 34 people killed when the plane in which they were flying from Zambia to Mozambique crashed in South Africa's Transvaal Province, officials said.

Violence in Darjeeling

ONE GORKHA National Liberation Front activist was killed and another suffered injuries amid clashes with CPI (M) supporters as scattered violence continued unabated in a popular tourist resort where Gorkhas are demanding an independent homeland. According to official reports, the GNLF supporters also set on fire at least 11 houses, mostly belonging to CPI (M) supporters.

India offers help on Kampuchea

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, said that India was prepared to play a role in resolving the Kampuchean problem if the countries of the region so desired. Stating this at a press conference at the end of his two-day visit to Thailand, Gandhi said the Thai Prime Minister, Prem Tinsulanonda, had asked him to use India's "immense prestige and influence" to bring about a political settlement.

Murder plot in Tihar

A KNIFE made inside Tihar Jail to attack an official was recently found in a toilet inside the jail. Officials are now investigating the alleged plot to kill a staffer. Babu Khan alias Pahlwan, a life convict, has confessed that he made the knife. Rival groups of officials inside the jail are now accusing one another of engineering a murder plot.

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

The root cause of the unrest is a widespread perception that France's social contract is broken.
— The Guardian

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Redefining we the people — that's the task of a new Demography Committee



G N DEVY

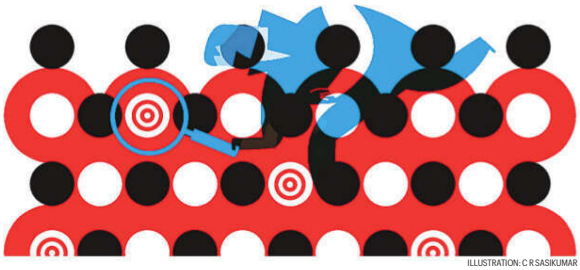


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

DEMOS, THE ancient Greek term, originally meant "people". The meaning was almost identical to that in the Constitution's "We, the people". Several English terms flow from demos, including "democracy", "demotic", "demagogy" and even "epidemic" and "endemic". During the 19th century, the term was combined with another ancient Greek term, *graphia*, by the French scholar Achille Guillard and "demography" as a branch of population study was created. Demography has since then vastly developed as a social science.

During the 20th century, several Indian demographers such as S Chandrasekhar, Ashish Bose and P N Mari Bhat built global reputations in the field. Distinguished institutions like the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) in Mumbai, and several university-based population study centres came up. National policy and planning benefited from the techniques developed by these scholars and institutions to arrive at figures for mortality, fertility, and gender ratio, as well as the National Family Health Survey (NFHS). The IIPS has long been associated with the UNESCO's Asia-Pacific initiative (ESCAP) in mapping populations for social development, resource management and energy distribution. The databases accumulated through the work of decades are developed on a total of 370 indicators and 1,500 data series, providing a robust synthesis of the census data, vital statistics and various studies undertaken by the UN as well as by Indian social scientists.

It was therefore surprising that the Prime Minister announced in his August 15 exhortation in 2025 government plans to set up yet another demography committee. It was also odd that it was constituted on May 26, a date with particular symbolic significance in the RSS's post-2014 history. What's stranger is that not one of the members has any grounding in demography. The chairperson is a retired judge, Prabhakar Naolekar, who was part of the bench that upheld the death sentence of Afzal Guru. One member is an economist from the PM's Economic Advisory Council, another is a former R&AW officer, and a third is a former bureaucrat with housing as his domain. The Registrar General of India and a Home Ministry joint secretary dealing with foreigners are ex-officio members. There is not a single demographer on the Committee, though it is called the "High-Level Committee on Demographic Change".

The Committee has reportedly been asked to do a religion-wise comparative study of birth registration, school enrolment, vehicle registrations, property transactions, ration cards and voter registration for the last 15 years. The stated purpose of the study is to find out "imbalances arising out of illegal immigration". In the simplest words, this is a *ghuspaithiya*-impact study. Towards that end, the Committee is expected to study any unusual spike in Aadhaar enrolment, ration cards or any other forged documents. It is also expected to look at voter registration without established lineage. More importantly, it is to study religious educational institutions, particularly the minority institutions. One special task given to it is to check religious conversion figures for the last 15 years.

> The Demography Committee has been asked to do a religion-wise comparative study of birth registration, school enrolment, vehicle registrations, property transactions, ration cards and voter registration for the last 15 years

Since the established science of demography places population, and not religion, at the centre of any study, the Committee is going to break new ground by paving the way for a "theo-ethnography". There are problems, though. One, other similar counting processes are underway. The much-debated and much more controversial Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls (SIR) is already on. Its central purpose, stated in many ways, is to identify the *ghuspaithiya* voters and to disenfranchise them. The Registrar General & Census Commissioner of India (RGI) is already halfway through the Census. And among the questions to be asked are many that can yield data that the Demography Committee is purposed to seek. Besides, there is also some talk of reviving the National Register of Citizens. If that is the case, the High Level Committee has to have a rather special objective that neither the SIR nor the Census, and not even the existing and refined databases in the country, can fulfil. What could that objective be? It is to identify, in GPS parameters, orchestrated migration and abnormal settlements, and to develop legislative, administrative and technological measures to "manage" infiltrators and execute permanent deportation frameworks.

In the context of these aims, the Akhil Bharatiya Prant Pracharak *baithak* of the RSS held in Belagavi in July assumes a curious significance. The media reports on the conclave mentioned that the only agenda for the three-day discussion and training was the Census. By the way, the timeline for the Demography Committee to complete its task coincides with the declared timeline for Census data publication, which is December 2027. The Census of 2026-27 itself is a striking deviation from the practice established since 1871. The Census is carried out normally in the first year of the decade. Although the Covid pandemic made that impossible, all other countries that follow the UN Principles and Recommendations for Population and Housing Census completed it in 2023. India postponed it, without providing any specific reasons, to 2026-27 — quite obviously to redeem the provision for the Census in the 2003 Amendment. What other use could there be for Census data that cannot be gainfully compared with data from 2011 or 2041?

The Census has added new questions, one of which is the name of the spouse. Together, the SIR, the Census and the Demography Committee will have gathered information on alleged infiltrators, their religious affiliations, land or property transactions these individuals have acquired, interfaith couples across India and their economic status (vehicles, employment, etc.). "*Ghar wapsi*" and "love jihad" are terms made familiar in India through speech and action during the past 12 years. There is now talk of "land jihad" as well. If the Committee's work results in amplifying the fear of infiltration and the task of "executing the mechanism of expelling" is passed on to vigilantes, one knows what can be expected.

Devy is a writer and cultural activist

Harvesting the Sun, and powering the farm



PRALHAD JOSHI AND SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN

INDIA'S JOURNEY towards Viksit Bharat must be built on the prosperity of its villages. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, empowering the *annadata* has been a central purpose of governance. Agrivoltaics, or AgriPV, offers an opportunity to take that purpose forward by enabling farmers to produce clean electricity while continuing to cultivate their land. The successful efforts of the Government of India in the form of PM-KUSUM are already evident in the solarisation of irrigation. Further efforts are being made to accelerate the generation of solar energy through creation of separate space for AgriPV under the next phase of PM-KUSUM.

From October 21 to 23, India will host the seventh AgriVoltaics World Conference at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi. Its theme, 'Powering the Global South', speaks directly to the responsibility India is ready to shoulder. We want the benefits of agricultural innovation and the energy transition to reach the small and marginal farmers who constitute about 86 per cent of India's farmers.

Behind every harvest are months of effort, money invested and a family's hopes. A good crop does not always bring a good income. Weather, input costs and market prices can unsettle the household budget. Public policy must help farmers strengthen their capacity to withstand these uncertainties and create additional opportunities to earn. Agrivoltaics combines cultivation and solar generation on the same land through structures and spacing suited to farming. It can give the cultivator an additional source of revenue from electricity. Where solar energy replaces diesel or purchased power, it can also reduce costs. The favourable microclimate under AgriPV provides additional protection against heat stress, drought, excessive solar radiation, and hail.

Domestic manufacturing, transparent procurement and investment in energy infrastructure have helped create the foundations for further growth. Agrivoltaics can bring more of that opportunity into the rural economy, including work in installation, maintenance and agricultural services.

Optimal crop selection is one of the prerequisites for the successful adoption of agrivoltaics. It should emphasise shade tolerance, morphological plasticity, and stable productivity under intermittent radiation. Appropriate agronomic management, including alley-based planting, adequate irrigation and nutrient supply, is essential for maintaining productivity. The agrivoltaic designs should generally aim to maintain around 70 per cent or more of natural incoming radiation at the crop canopy, while adjustable PV panels can provide additional flexibility during radiation-sensitive growth stages. Agriculture and energy departments must plan together, with state governments, research institutions and local bodies. The farmer experiences the results of all these decisions on one holding. Our institutions should be capable of working with the same sense of unity.

Farmer trust must guide every step. Cultivators should be able to understand an agreement, know the return they can expect and see who bears each responsibility. Land ownership must remain protected. Tenant cultivators and women farmers also need a voice in how projects are designed and how benefits are shared.

India has valuable experience on which to build. ICAR's Central Arid Zone Research Institute in Jodhpur has explored cultivation alongside solar generation and rainwater harvesting. BAIF's Rural Innovation Centre in Pune is testing different configurations across a range of crops. The Government of India has established the Centre of Excellence (CoE) on Agri-Photovoltaics with 100 kW capacity at ICAR-Indian Agricultural Research Institute, New Delhi in 2025. This is jointly led by ICAR and National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE) under the guidance of the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy. The data generated from the CoE for the next two years will help in providing technical suggestions on specific crop suitability, boundary conditions and optimal integration of agricultural fields and solar panels.

Hosting the world conference brings an international scientific community into this national endeavour. Affordable structures and finance suited to modest holdings deserve as much attention as advances in solar technology. This is also an opportunity to deepen India's partnership with the Global South. The International Solar Alliance, launched by India and France, provides a foundation for cooperation on solar energy. Agrivoltaics creates further scope for joint field research, training and the exchange of practical experience. Countries facing pressure on land, water and rural incomes should have access to solutions developed for their conditions. India's scientists, manufacturers and rural entrepreneurs can contribute to that effort.

As we welcome the world to New Delhi, our expectation is practical. The discussions should help produce better-tested projects, partnerships that share knowledge and business arrangements farmers can trust. Viksit Bharat will advance when the small farmer has the confidence and means to take part in new sources of prosperity. Agrivoltaics can contribute to that goal, with agriculture at its foundation and the *annadata* at its centre.

Joshi is Union Minister of New and Renewable Energy and Chouhan is Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Juhu attack

THE RECENT shooting in Juhu highlights the need for stronger policing in Mumbai. Organised criminals must not be allowed to operate with confidence ('Shooting in Juhu is a warning for Mumbai', *IE*, October 20). The police should improve intelligence gathering, monitor known offenders and respond promptly to threats. Better coordination between local stations and specialised units can help prevent such incidents. Equally important are swift investigation and strict action against those responsible.

B A Avyaan, Perundurai

Question of control

THE REAL race unfolding here is not just between America and China; it is between openness and control ('Meta's open-weight gambit, AI's global play,' *IE*, October 20). Open-weight models are like sharing the recipe instead of just selling the dish, which spreads innovation but also means nobody can take the dish back once it is out in the world. A released model cannot be recalled if misused, unlike a faulty product pulled from shelves. Nations chasing AI leadership must build safeguards alongside performance, not after it. History shows that technologies released without restraint often outpace the wisdom needed to govern them, and AI may prove no different. Otherwise, we risk winning the technology race while quietly losing the argument on safety.

K Chidanand Kumar, Bengaluru

Untidy equations

PHASING OUT leap seconds reveals a deeper shift: Physics has increasingly retreated into abstract mathematics, leaving practical realities to engineers ('Measure time, but let lunch hour be an illusion', *IE*, October 20). Where physics once grounded our perception of natural phenomena, such as the Earth's imperfect rotation, digital systems and network protocols now dictate our standards. Engineering has effectively replaced empirical physics as the arbiter of reality. We may quantify every microsecond to satisfy code, but human life still resists such neat equations.

Harsh Pawaria, Rohtak

India's tech sector needs deeper pools of risk capital



ROOPA KUDVA

INDIA HAS never had more developers. Yet, capital for the earliest stage of building new technology companies is shrinking. Recently released Tracxn data reveals that in the first nine months of 2026, seed funding fell 37 per cent to $698 million, even as early-stage funding rose 27 per cent to $4.2 billion. This follows a 30 per cent decline in seed funding in 2025.

That is striking at a time when India's technology talent base has never been larger. GitHub estimates that India had 21.9 million developers in 2025, up from 4.5 million in 2020. It added more than 5 million in just one year. India now has the world's largest base of contributors to public and open-source repositories. AI, cybersecurity, engineering, analytics and product development sit alongside traditional software-services work.

India's developer numbers are impressive. But they don't tell us who ultimately captures the economic value they create. That value has at least four layers:

The first is jobs and salaries. India clearly captures this. The technology industry employs about 5.8 million people. GCCs alone now employ about 2.36 million, and export revenues are roughly evenly split between Indian service providers and global MNCs, including GCCs. The second is profits and enterprise value. A substantial part of this also stays in India. Indian IT companies sell technology services globally and capture the margins, profits and enterprise value here.

The third is high-value work and expertise. GCCs that once handled mainly support increasingly house product engineering, AI, architecture, R&D and end-to-end responsibility for global platforms. That brings better-paid roles, deeper expertise and stronger technology ecosystems into India. And then the fourth layer — products, IP and ownership. Who owns the products and platforms being created? Who receives the recurring revenues and long-term enterprise value?

> If India wants more of its technology talent to create products, IP and enterprise value that are owned here, it needs sufficiently deep pools of risk capital that can back ideas before the evidence is overwhelming

Here, India still has some way to go. NASSCOM estimates that software products account for only about $16.1 billion of India's $282.6 billion technology industry. India remains much stronger in technology services and global delivery than in building and owning globally scaled software products and platforms.

The move from talent to services to high-value capability has already happened to a remarkable extent. Ownership remains thin. This is where the funding numbers become relevant. The fall in seed funding, alongside rising funding for companies that have already demonstrated traction, suggests that capital is becoming more selective. That may be rational from an investor's perspective. But product ownership is often created earlier — when the idea is still unproven, failure rates are high and someone has to fund conviction before there is evidence.

A talented architect or engineering manager in Bengaluru today has more options than at any previous point in India's technology history: An Indian IT company, a global product company, a GCC doing sophisticated work, or a start-up trying to build something of its own. The risk-reward equation across those choices is very different. GCCs can offer high salaries, global work and increasingly attractive career paths. Start-ups offer the possibility of ownership, but also much greater uncertainty. If capital becomes harder to access precisely when founders are trying to turn ideas into products, India's path from capability to ownership becomes more difficult.

India has invested substantially in innovation infrastructure: research centres, incubators, public funding programmes and R&D facilities. But infrastructure and technical capability cannot substitute for capital willing to accept early failure.

This is not an argument for indiscriminate start-up funding. Most early ideas will fail, and capital should remain disciplined. But if India wants more of its technology talent to create products, IP and enterprise value that are owned here, it needs sufficiently deep pools of risk capital that can back ideas before the evidence is overwhelming.

India has built the talent. It has built globally competitive services companies. It has become indispensable to the technology operations of many of the world's largest corporations. The next transition is harder: From building technology for the world to owning more of what gets built. With AI entering the picture, it's unknown whether we need more developers or fewer. But the technology race now goes well beyond having the most developers. It is increasingly about who owns what those developers build.

The writer headed Crisil and ONI

At the Durga Puja pandal, looking back to remember



PRATEEK RAJ

ON SATURDAY, as I was returning from the Durga Puja celebrations in West London, I learnt of the deadly stampede at Chorbagan in north Kolkata. Nineteen people were killed and 25 injured. In crowd crushes like this, women and children often bear the brunt.

Kolkata has celebrated Durga Puja for a long time, and in my living memory I cannot recall a deadly stampede during *pujo*. I have spent several years studying crowded, time-bound and emergent mega events such as the Kumbh Mela. Such events, Durga Puja included, succeed because of the vast institutional memory and knowledge embedded in a diverse set of grassroots stakeholders who make them possible. Durga Puja in Kolkata is a remarkably intelligent system, in which decades — even centuries — of organisational knowledge allow organisers to proactively offer visitors an experience that is both memorable and safe.

People in crowds move in predictable patterns. Good planning rests on a handful of principles: Spillover areas, multiple entries and exits, calm and timely communication, and proactive crowd management through a web of volunteers and security personnel, now further aided by predictive technology. Together, these keep crowds reasonably disciplined and stave off stampedes and chaos.

When stampedes and near-stampedes do occur, they tend to stem from a familiar set of causes: Poor information; rumours; improper flow management; absence of a reasonable spillover area; or the blocking of normal flow for reasons such as VIP movement. Experienced organisers know these factors well, and they proactively work to avoid them. The Chorbagan Puja, now in its 91st year, has nearly a century of organising experience behind it. That is what made it all the more surprising that it could not prevent a stampede.

From what has been reported so far, the crush took place after a sudden downpour sent people rushing towards the popular *pandal* for shelter. Eyewitnesses have described a very narrow entrance, an equally narrow exit, and a lane leading to the *pandal* with no lighting. Initial information from the administration suggests the rush was set off by a hasty announcement asking the crowd to leave, fearing the *pandal* may collapse. None of these is a novel risk. "Surprises" — rain included — are quite common at events like the Kumbh and Durga Puja, and organisers usually know how to handle them.

> While organisation committees often change, they must have ample continuity to ensure that their institutional knowledge and memory are not lost

However, according to reports, the organising committee of the Chorbagan event underwent a change of leadership this year. While organisation committees often change, they must have ample continuity to ensure that their institutional knowledge and memory are not lost. A key question that matters for crowd safety is: Did the operational knowledge of the previous organisers carry over to the new team? Only an independent investigation can answer this question.

What we can say with certainty, though, is that festivals like Durga Puja are complex crowd-management challenges, in which concern for safety must always be paramount. Just as we would always have experts fly an aeroplane, we must always ensure events like *pujo* are organised by people with deep experience.

This stampede is an unfortunate chapter in the glorious history of Durga Puja in Kolkata. All I can hope is that we learn from these mistakes and ensure that no life is ever lost during *pujo* again.

The writer is associate professor of Business Management and Health Sciences, University College London

PERSONAL

I, Mehmooda W/o Vakeel R/o H. No.549, Chausana Vishat Aht, Shamli, UP have changed my name to Mahmuda.
0071066909-1

I, **Praveen** Kumar Agrawal s/o Late J.P Agarwal, R/o-18-A, Third Floor, North Avenue Road, West Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi-110026,have change my name to Praveen Agrawal.
0040884406-1

I, Maharatha Smt Prabhashini W/O Late Sh. Bhagwan Maharatha residing at Hno. 29-D/2 Ward no. 1, old Desu Road, Mehraull South Delhi- 110030 have changed my name to Prabhasini Maharatha for all future purposes.
0050300033-1

I, Saurav Kumar Das S/o Late Samarendra Kumar R/o K-7-405, Smart City Golf Homes, Sector-4 Greater Noida, U.P.-201009 inform that Saurav Kumar Das & Saurav Das both are one & the same person & my name shall henceforth be known as Saurav Kumar Das for all future purposes.
0040884459-1

I Nitin Alias Prince Kawatra S/o Satish Kawatra R/o House No-203, 2nd Floor, Sainik Vihar, Pitampura, Delhi- 110034, have changed my name to Prince Kawatra
0071066905-1

I, Shokat Ali S/o Munshi Ahmed R/oH.No.12, Budh Nagar, Sadullabad, Loni, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Shoukat Ali.
0071066910-1

I, **Shubham** Agrawal s/o Praveen Agrawal, R/o-18-A, Third Floor, North Avenue Road, West Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi-110026,have change my name to Shubbham Agrawaal.
0040884406-2

I Akshay Kumar S/O Arun Kumar R/O of 198, Village Dallupura, Delhi-110096 shall henceforth be known as Akshay Arun Singh Mihir affidavit no IN-DL24300702114091Y sworn before notary Shahjahan dated 16.10.2026 at Delhi.
0050300035-1

I, Ujjwal Seth, declare that my name is recorded as UJAWAL in my 10th certificate. Both names refer to me.
0130070510-1

I Mithilesh Kumar Yadav Alias Solaja Marik S/o Jyotish Marik R/o PS Saryahat, Kendua, PO-Kendua, Dist- Dumka, Jharkhand- 814151, have changed my name to Sanjay Yadav
0071066901-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Preeti wife of Sh. Abhishek Ahlawat & Daughter of Sh. Jai Singh Residence of House No. RZ-21, Indra Park, Near-Tilak Pul, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 after Marriage have changed my name Preeti to Preeti Ahlawat for all intents and future purposes. Inform that Preeti & Preeti Ahlawat both are one & same Person Name. Please add the surname "Ahlawat" to my name on my voter ID, PAN card, Aadhaar card, and passport, and update my address to match the home address of my husband, Abhishek Ahlawat.

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NORTHERN RAILWAY

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19261230	BRAKE SHOE COMPLETE (STANDARD SIZE)	27762 NOS	16.11.2026

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Tender Notice NO. 51/2026-2027 Dated: 19.10.2026 3649/2026

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'Fake stampede videos': Suvendu says those who shared them will be booked

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, October 20

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Tuesday said fake videos on the Chorbagan tragedy originated from Bangladesh and were shared on social media by a section of people in Bengal. He said those who circulated or endorsed such videos will be booked under non-bailable sections.

Nineteen people died and 25 were injured in a stampede at Chorbagan Sarbojanin in North Kolkata on October 17 around 7.40 pm.

The Chief Minister visited the families of the victims on Tuesday.

Later, speaking to media-persons, he said: "Fake videos of the Chorbagan incident were being made viral on social media. This is mainly done from Bangladesh. From Coochbehar to various parts of the state some people shared it. Some commented on it. Action will be taken against them. There are 135 such people. I have asked police to book those people in non-bailable sections."

"I personally went to the hospital and the place of occurrence. Why spread fake videos?" said the CM.

Hours earlier, the Special Task Force of West Bengal Police arrested a man from Cooch Behar district for allegedly spreading misinformation on social media about the toll in the Chorbagan stampede.

'Soft towards terrorists for political gains': BJP slams Coimbatore blast convicts' parole

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, October 20

THE TAMIL Nadu government's decision to grant parole of 60 days to five men serving life sentences for the 1998 Coimbatore serial bombings, whose main target was believed to be senior BJP leader L K Advani, has triggered a political row in the state.

The BJP has accused the TVK (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam) government of "selective softness towards convicted terrorists", for political gains.

The government has argued that the parole is part of the regular process, given the long time they had spent in prison, and on a par with relief given to other accused, TVK MLA V M S Mustafa issued a statement thanking Vijay for the parole.

The five convicts lodged in Coimbatore Central Prison — Mohammed Ansari, Mohammed Ali, Monappa alias Mohammed Hassan, Mohammed Ajam, and Nawab Khan, all between the ages of 46 and 55 — petitioned for parole citing personal circumstances and health conditions, according to prison officials.

A senior official claimed their petitions had been cleared earlier this year, but their release on parole was put on hold during the Assembly elections. Now, their fresh petitions have been approved.

On February 14, 1998, ahead of an election meeting in Coimbatore that Advani was to address, the town that was communally charged saw coordinated explosions across the city, leaving 58 people dead and more than 200 injured. Advani escaped as he had not yet arrived at the meeting.

The Justice P R Gokulakrishnan Commission set up by the then DMK government to probe the bombings traced them to the killing of 18 Muslims in police firing and communal violence in late 1997, and blamed police for failing to ward off the explosions. Coimbatore continues to be a rare BJP stronghold in Tamil Nadu, a state that has remained out of the party's reach.

The police arrested 168 people following the blasts, of whom one died and another turned approver. Of the 166 who were tried, 158 were convicted in 2007, of whom 43 were given life terms. The radical outfit Al-Umma was accused of organising the bombings, with its founder S A Basha and general secretary Mohammed Ansari convicted of conspiracy.

Reacting to the parole to the accused, state BJP chief spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy posted on X: "Personal grounds cannot override the gravity of a terror attack that remains one of the darkest chapters in the state's history."

Thirupathy also mentioned the Supreme Court's October 4, 2023, decision refusing bail to some life convicts in the serial blasts case, while their appeals against conviction and sentence were pending.

However, there have been court concessions before. In January 2023, nine convicts in the case received interim leave on health grounds, with extensions considered periodically by the High Court. Later that year, the Madras High Court granted three months' ordinary leave to another life convict, Abdul Hakeem, after his wife approached the court citing a brain tumour and symptoms of cancer.

In fact, among those who repeatedly received bail, before he died at the age of 84 in December 2024, was prime accused Basha. Supreme Court lawyer Prabhu Balasubramanian, who knew Basha, earlier told *The Indian Express* how the Al Umma founder's regret in his final days was the time lost with his family, particularly grandchildren. Balasubramanian claims that this is why Basha, who was given life too, never appealed against his sentence. "I just want to be with my family, even if only for a few days every year," Basha told him, adding that he feared that an appeal against his sentencing would make that difficult.

While the lawyers for the five accused refused to comment, other legal experts said parole is the normal right of a prisoner, and it should not be viewed as lowering the severity of the sentence of an accused.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE



LANCE NAIK SATBIR SINGH 43 BN BSF MARTYRED ON – 21.10.1990

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Lance Naik Satbir Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in Jagraon area, Punjab and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



CONSTABLE GURNAM SINGH, PMG 173 BN BSF 14.03.1990 – 21.10.2016

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Gurnam Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in area of BOP Bobiya, Indreshwar Nagar, Jammu. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with PMG (Posthumously).



CONSTABLE M KARUNEELAM 108 BN BSF 16.04.1973 – 21.10.2000



CONSTABLE LAXMAN PASWAN 108 BN BSF 01.03.1969 – 21.10.2000

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Constables M Karuneelam and Laxman Paswan on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in Ramban area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



HEAD CONSTABLE GAURAV KUMAR PANDEY 142 BN BSF 03.08.1982 – 21.10.2025

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Gaurav Kumar Pandey on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in Chinturu, Andhra Pradesh.



GDSM RB MANIYAR, VrC
05 Oct 1961 - 21 Oct 1987

We pay homage to Gdsm RB Maniyar, VrC (Posthumous), who was killed in action while fighting the enemy in OP PAWAN-1987 (SRILANKA). His dauntless courage and sacrifice will forever inspire the organisation.

CO & all ranks of 6th Battalion Brigade of The Guards

Priest's arrest under POCSO turns spotlight on initial police probe that cleared him

Atiya Firdos
Bengaluru, October 20

TWO DAYS after a church priest in Karnataka's Mangaluru was arrested on charges of sexually abusing minor boys, an initial police inquiry conducted against him has come under scrutiny as the report concluded that the allegations against the priest could not be substantiated.

The police arrested Father Cyprian Pinto, associated with St Vincent Ferrer Church in Valencia, Mangaluru, from a relative's house on Sunday in a case registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Before his arrest, the inquiry conducted by the Mangaluru South police and detailed in a report dated September 8, 2026 recorded the statements of the church administrator, the priest who succeeded Pinto and Pinto himself. The report, however, does not mention recording statements of the alleged victims or their parents.

Mangaluru Police Commissioner Sudheer Kumar Reddy acknowledged lapses at the police station level in the initial inquiry, saying the inspector recorded the priest's statement but did not record or speak to the victims or their parents.

The case has now been handed over to an ACP-rank officer, who has been directed to inquire into the lapses in the initial investigation and submit a report, the Commissioner said.

The inquiry followed complaints by parents to child protection authorities against the priest. In a communication to the District Child Protection Unit (DCPU), Dakshina Kannada, several parents raised concerns over the safety of their children around Pinto. The DCPU subsequently requested the Mangaluru South police to investigate the allegations and submit a report.

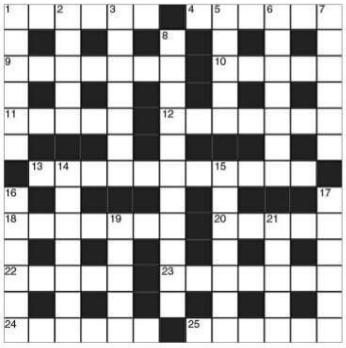
According to the inquiry report accessed by *The Indian Express*, Pinto denied the allegations and claimed that some parents and youngsters were unhappy with the stricter disciplinary rules he had introduced at St Vincent Ferrer Church, including closing its gates at 7 pm. The church administrator also told the police that some people had expressed dissatisfaction with the priest's rules. The report concluded that the allegations of sexual abuse and mistreatment of minors had not been established. The report was submitted to the Child Welfare Committee (CWC) on September 16.

The findings are now under scrutiny following Pinto's arrest in the POCSO case, raising questions about the scope of the initial inquiry and the steps taken to verify the allegations.

According to sources, the children's parents had first approached the bishop with a written complaint in August, expecting the church authorities to take action. However, instead of immediately reporting the allegations to the police or other competent authorities, the diocese conducted an internal inquiry, the sources said.

The sources also claimed the parents were pressured for nearly two months not to pursue the matter, including appeals and threats made in the name of religion and community.

CROSSWORD 6125



ACROSS

1 Such mistakes are holding a sailing man back (6)
4 Entry on the right (6)
9 Plays with the rate of exchange (7)
10 He could get riled if made to work (5)
11 Material that's light when worn (5)
12 A thousand in the back rank came into view (7)
13 One may be powerless without it (11)
18 Daily journalist (7)
20 Loopy sort of topic (5)
22 See cat jump off piano (5)
23 Utterly pompous (7)
24 It holds soup for electrical engineers in turn (6)
25 Repeatedly set about a fly (6)

DOWN

1 Ernest breaks records (6)
2 Oddly dry round central Greece — piping needed (5)
3 Large attic in disorder (7)
5 Breed fish we hear (5)
6 Jubilation of French before the match (7)
7 I am stuck in traffic — abusive words result (6)
8 Considerate about profanity (11)
14 Driver waiting for a chance to pass (7)
15 They have taken cover on hills (7)
16 On a winding road it shows skill (6)
17 It's dull, unimaginative and indigestible (6)
19 One French boy or girl (5)
21 Be considered noble (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6124 ACROSS: 1 Deposit, 5 Scour, 8 White feathers, 9 Lotto, 10 Sponsor, 11 Minute, 12 Scrape, 15 Lapland, 17 Leech, 19 Steering wheel, 20 Arson, 21 Sprites DOWN: 1 Dowel, 2 Printing press, 3 Step out, 4 Theist, 5 Set-to, 6 Overstatement, 7 Reserve, 11 Melissa, 13 Cold war, 14 Adonis, 16 Aaron, 18 Holes

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

One reason people get divorced is that they run ut of __ ____. - Robert Byrne (4,5)

BDAEI

ABCUDT

GMOIS

DEIRFG

SOLUTIONS: Abide, Gismo, Abduct, Fridge
ANSWER: One reason people get divorced is that they run out of **gift ideas**. - Robert Byrne

OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS



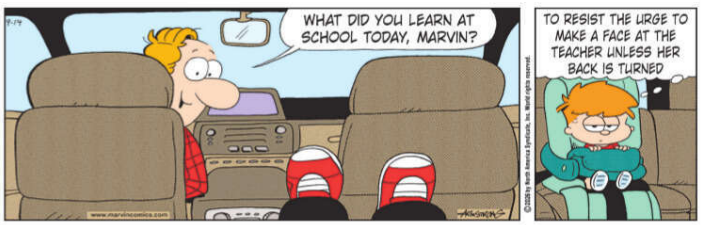
CALVIN & HOBBES

BY BILL WATTERSON



MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG



SUDOKU 6478

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s
INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy;
3s = Medium; 4s = Hard;
5s = Very Hard;
6s = Genius

	6		2		5			
			4			2	3	
		8		6				
8		4				1		9
	2	3				7	8	
1		5				3		2
				8		5		
	1	7			3			
			5		2		4	

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6477

9	8	4	3	5	1	7	2	6
5	1	2	4	6	7	8	3	9
3	6	7	8	2	9	5	4	1
7	4	9	6	1	5	3	8	2
6	3	8	9	4	2	1	5	7
1	2	5	7	8	3	6	9	4
4	7	1	2	3	8	9	6	5
8	9	6	5	7	4	2	1	3
2	5	3	1	9	6	4	7	8

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): If you do your homework today, or explore research, you might get ahead financially speaking. You will certainly be in a good position to negotiate with others. Secret rendezvous and passionate relationships will be hot. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a lovely day to chat with friends and members of groups. Relations with partners, spouses and close friends will be warm and rewarding. A surprise related to money and possessions might occur. Tonight: Be friendly.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): People will notice you more than usual, and some will know personal details about your private life. You look good to co-workers. A romance might develop. Stay flexible. Tonight: You're admired.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Surprising news about foreign countries or people from other cultures might occur today. You also might have an unexpected chance to travel or travel plans might change. This is a great day to enjoy social activities. Tonight: Reach out and learn.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Double-check banking details, because something unexpected could impact your finances or shared property. You'll enjoy entertaining today. You also might buy something beautiful for your home or receive a gift. Tonight: Check your finances.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): It's a mixed bag today. Relations with authority figures, spouses and partners might have a few surprises. However, most of your communications today will be friendly and warm. Tonight: Listen and cooperate with someone.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Your work routine might be interrupted today. Try ways to boost your income. You also might buy something attractive for your workspace. Tonight: Get better organised.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Parents should be extra vigilant today because this could be an accident-prone day for your kids. Social plans might suddenly change. Double-check details. Enjoy the arts. Tonight: Socialise.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Stock the fridge, because today is an unpredictable day at home or if dealing with family members. Anything might happen. However, for the most part, relations with family members will be pleasant. Tonight: Relax at home.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Plans might suddenly change, so give yourself extra time for wiggle room. Pay attention to everything you say and do, because this is also a mildly accident-prone day. It's an excellent day to deal with friends and groups. Tonight: Conversations.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Protect your money and possessions from loss, theft or damage today. Unexpected expenses for social occasions might occur. Your ability to impress someone in authority could bring increased wealth to you. Tonight: Check your money.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today you have warm feelings between you and everyone else, which is why you'll enjoy getting out and having a good time. You'll feel protective about your loved ones. Prepare for a surprise at home, something irregular. Tonight: You win.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• LEGAL

How Army treats adultery, despite decriminalisation

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, October 20

AN ARMY Major was recently issued a show-cause notice for dismissal from service on grounds of extramarital affairs with multiple women. Though decriminalised by the Supreme Court, adultery remains a punishable offence in the Army.

What is the case?

An officer of the Armoured Corps approached the Principal Bench of the Armed Forces Tribunal, New Delhi, challenging a show-cause notice dated August 10. Issued by the Chief of the Army, the notice asks why his services should not be terminated administratively on the ground that trial by court-martial is "inexpedient due to attendant circumstances."

The proceedings arise from allegations of extramarital affairs, including with the wives of two officers. The notice was issued under the Army Rules of 1954, which flow from the Army Act of 1950. Army Rule 19, read with Army Rule 14, governs the administrative termination of an Army officer over misconduct without a court-martial.

A court-martial is a formal military trial under the Army Act that can result in conviction and punishments such as dismissal, while administrative termination under Section 19 of the Army Act is a separate route. It can be used when the competent authority is satisfied that trial by court-martial is inexpedient and retaining the officer is undesirable, after giving a show-cause opportunity.

Commissioned in 2015, the officer got married in 2022. In 2023, his wife filed a complaint alleging adultery, substance abuse, neglect, and extramarital affairs with four women. The Army's Western Command convened a Court of Inquiry to examine allegations of "stealing affection of brother officers' wives" and "misconduct/conduct unbecoming of an officer and a gentleman."

A tentative charge sheet was framed under the Army Act, dealing with unbecoming conduct and violation of good order and military discipline. In 2026, the couple divorced and in the compromise memo, the woman withdrew the complaint, stating it was filed unintentionally due to matrimonial disputes and without undeniable grounds. Despite this, the termination notice was issued.

SEPARATE AFFAIRS

- In 'Joseph Shine v. Union of India' (2018), the Supreme Court struck down IPC Section 497, decriminalising adultery.
- In a 2023 clarification, a five-judge Constitution Bench held that the judgment does not affect the Armed Forces Acts.

Is adultery a crime in the Army?

Yes. In *Joseph Shine v. Union of India* (2018), the Supreme Court struck down Section 497 of the Indian Penal Code, decriminalising adultery. However, in a 2023 clarification, a five-judge Constitution Bench held that the judgment does not affect the Armed Forces Acts.

Under Article 33 of the Indian Constitution, members of the armed forces form a distinct class, and laws may restrict fundamental rights to preserve discipline. Sections 45 (conduct unbecoming of an officer and the character expected of him) and 63 (any act or omission prejudicial to good order and military discipline) of the Army Act and corresponding provisions in the Navy and Air Force Acts continue to apply to promiscuous or adulterous conduct that affects unit cohesion or discipline.

"Stealing the affection of a brother officer's wife" is the traditional military description of such misconduct and remains actionable under these provisions. The term now also includes 'spouse' for women officers.

Remedies available to officers include an appeal to the Armed Forces Tribunal under the Armed Forces Tribunal Act, 2007. The tribunal can re-appreciate evidence and set aside findings that are legally unsustainable, involve a wrong decision on law, or result from material irregularity causing miscarriage of justice.

In the aforementioned case, the officer's defence rests on alleged procedural illegalities, non-compliance with mandatory Army Rules, and changed circumstances after the withdrawal of the complaint.

For administrative matters such as a show-cause notice, the original jurisdiction lies with the tribunal. Further appeal can be led from the AFT to the Supreme Court on a point of law of general public importance (with leave), or by special leave under Article 136 of the Constitution.

• ECONOMICS

The economic mess at the heart of France's protests

Weak growth, high debt, joblessness and a welfare state that is not working out for the young: France's problems are many and solutions are not easy



Udit Misra

FRANCE, EUROPE'S second largest economy and one of the five permanent members of the United Nations Security Council, is burning after violent protesters unleashed some of the worst episodes of vandalism in French history.

President Emmanuel Macron, who seemed to have been taken by surprise, condemned the violence, and urged calm and order. Official figures suggest that more than 5,00,00 mostly young demonstrators took to streets — unofficially estimates go up to 8,00,000 — with thousands arrested.

The protests that started more than a month ago with students demanding better conditions in schools have morphed into bigger calls for better living conditions.

To be sure, street protests, often violent, happen regularly enough to be viewed more as a feature of the French Republic than a bug. It is noteworthy that this is the case even though France has one of the most centralised governments anywhere in the world, with the national government holding much of the power.

The scale of the violence, however, has left both policymakers and observers around the world stunned. What's more, with the next presidential elections just six months away, and a country that looks deeply divided between far-right and far-left political views, the apprehension is that these protests and violence may happen again.

There are two ways to look at this crisis in France.

The people's concerns

From the perspective of the protestors, there are concerns about the high cost of living, which is, in turn, a shorthand for the combined effect of high and persistent inflation, high unemployment, inadequate wage increase, and insufficient support from the government for the welfare state.

Data from International Monetary Fund (IMF) and Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) shows that while inflation hasn't been as high in France as it has been among its peers — Germany, Spain, UK, Italy, Greece and the US — it is the weak economic growth and high unemployment that have been the real causes of worry.

The IMF just revised downwards the growth rates for 2026 and 2027 to as low as 0.4% and 0.7% respectively.

More broadly, France's growth rate completely faltered since the Global Financial Crisis of 2008, and this has had its impact on per capita incomes. In 2008, for instance, France's per capita GDP was $45,754. In 2026, it is $51,448. That's an average annual increase in incomes of less than even 1% each year over the last 18 years. It is unsurprising that the public will grow restless and demand more state support.

The other side of weak growth is high unemployment. Overall unemployment is around 8% but among the youth it shoots up to almost 20%. The picture is even more bleak among migrants coming from Africa. Data on wages also paints a similar picture with France lagging behind its peers.

The central problem

Over the decades, the French have got used to an expansive welfare state.

•

But since the Global Financial Crisis of 2008, France's growth has not kept pace with its ambitions of welfare.

The government's concerns

From the perspective of the government, the picture is equally dire but the variables are different. The French government has been borrowing more and more each passing year — the fiscal deficit this year is pegged at 5.4% of the GDP — thus adding to a growing mountain of debt. Total debt as a percentage of GDP is now more than 118%.

Making matters worse is a stagnant economy. Thanks to a lack of growth, the French government does not have enough tax revenues to support the welfare demands of the public. That, in turn, forces it to borrow more. As things stand, the French government is already the overwhelming player in the French economy, accounting for about 57% of the GDP.

Unsurprisingly, investors are demanding a higher rate of return for lending money to the French government. The yields on 10-year bonds by the French government are now close to the 5% mark. Not only is this much higher than the recent past, it is also higher than many European peers such as Greece and Italy that were until a decade ago, the real problem economies.

Now France, instead of being a large, stable economy in Europe, is fast heading towards a possible debt crisis of its own. That's because its borrowing costs are spiking just as its overall debt has reached uncomfortable levels. As a result, the government has to now shell out more and more money each year from its budget just to pay the interest on past loans.

It is also noteworthy that investors are taking into account the political instability in France (reflected in the rising bond yields). President Macron is becoming increasingly ineffective, and most future presidential candidates are deeply polarising figures. Political instability is a tell-tale sign that the reforms needed to course-correct may not happen in a hurry.

A difficult solution

The charred remains of town halls, looted high-street shops and images of police cracking down may suggest an economy performing far worse than what the data shows. As things stand, France is still not where Greece or Italy were during the Eurozone sovereign debt crisis in the early 2010s. However, it will be there if it doesn't take corrective action.

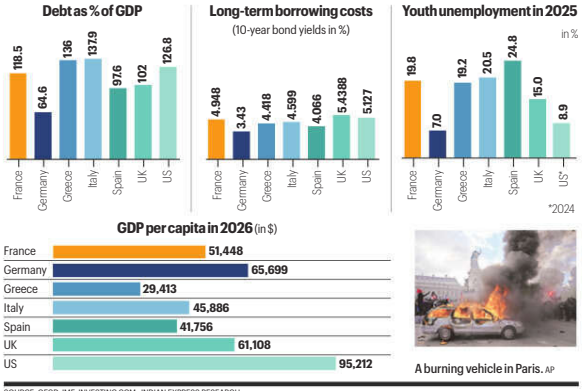
The central problem is this: Over the decades, the French have got used to an expansive welfare state, but since the Global Financial Crisis of 2008, France's growth has not kept pace with its ambitions of welfare.

Given its inability to grow fast, France needs a two-pronged approach. One, reform its economy to unleash a new wave of growth. A government-dominated economy is not delivering growth at the moment.

Two, cut down on excessive expenditure. For instance, thanks to the welfare guarantees on health and pensions as well as the demographic change (read ageing), France is looking at a scenario where a growing number of old will be dependent on the taxes levied on a relatively smaller number of young workers. Efforts to raise the retirement age — thus saving the outgo on pensions — have been thwarted.

In short, France has to figure out a way to grow fast to avoid a debt crisis, and while it tries to do that, it must control welfare expenses. Otherwise, it is set to receive more rude shocks.

KEY ECONOMIC INDICATORS: HOW FRANCE MATCHES UP TO ITS PEERS



SOURCE: OECD, IMF, INVESTING.COM, INDIAN EXPRESS RESEARCH

A burning vehicle in Paris. AP

• SCIENCE

A piece of Mars's moon: Why Japan has sent a mission to Phobos

Arav Shah
New Delhi, October 20

THE JAPAN Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA) on Tuesday launched a rocket towards Mars at 1:11 am IST.

The mission, termed Martian Moons Exploration (MMX), aims to study the origin of the Martian moons Phobos and Deimos — named after the sons of the Greek god of war, Ares, who is better recognised by his Roman name, Mars. The mission aims to retrieve at least 10 grams of physical samples from Phobos and return them to Earth by 2031. Should the mission be successful, Japan will be the first country to return samples from a moon of Mars. But why is the mission interested in exploring the moons instead of the red planet itself?

First, why do scientists want to study the moons of Mars?

Phobos and Deimos were first discovered by the American astronomer Asaph Hall in 1877. These two moons have held the interest of the scientific community because theirs origins are not yet discovered. There are, however, two theories, according to NASA.

The first explanation proposes that both moons are relics of asteroids that were captured by the gravitational pull of the planet. The irregular shapes of the two, combined with certain surface characteristics, make this theory a possibility. But capturing asteroids into stable orbit around a planet is no simple task. Scientists are also yet to establish whether it explains the movement of both moons and their other characteristics.

The other working theory states that both moons were formed due to a collision of a large celestial body or asteroid into Mars. As debris was ejected into the planet's orbit, it came together over time to form both moons. Should this explanation turn out to be correct, the composition of the moons may reveal clues about Mars itself.

Mars' gravity makes landing on the planet and returning samples a challenge. Phobos, however, has much weaker gravity.

How is the mission expected to proceed?

The spacecraft is scheduled to reach Mars around August 2027 and return in 2031. Following its arrival near Mars, it shall enter quasi-satellite orbit around Phobos. This will allow it to remain close to the moon while conducting observations of its topography and chemical composition. These details shall also help scientists determine a suitable landing spot.

Mission specs

- The MMX mission is carrying 13 scientific instruments, including cameras, spectrometers and devices to measure the surface and composition of the Martian moon Phobos.
- One of its key components is the IDEFIX rover, developed jointly by CNES (France) and the DLR (Germany). The main craft will deploy the rover on Phobos before it lands.



The Japanese rocket carrying the MMX mission takes off Tuesday. AP

The spacecraft is made up of three main modules — propulsion, exploration (a rover) and sample return — which will support the journey to Mars, surface operations and eventual return to Earth. The mission also plans to observe Deimos during a flyby. MMX will test technologies needed for future round-trip missions to the Martian system, including autonomous navigation and landing in extremely weak gravity.

Why does it matter?

The MMX mission comes at a time when major space powers are looking to develop their capabilities for planetary exploration. Importantly, the mission shall help assess whether Phobos may be able to serve as a staging point for crewed missions to Mars. Its weak gravity means that landing and taking off from the moon requires a fraction of the fuel needed for a descent on Mars.

The MMX mission and its agenda are "essentially an exercise in leadership, technology autonomy and improving space cooperation between nations", Ashwin Prasad Rao, Staff Research Analyst at Takshashila Institution, told *The Indian Express*.

Although largely headed by JAXA, the mission also includes the European Space Agency, NASA, CNES (France), DLR (Germany), and the Australian Space Agency. The allows nations to share the cost of innovation while advancing shared goals. In fact, NASA's Mars sample-return mission — aimed at bringing back surface soil deposits from the planet — was scrapped earlier this year by US Congressional budget action which dictates federal spending.

Japan is, "climbing a ladder that helps position the nation as one of the leaders in planetary exploration," Rao said. "It (Japan) is already known for expertise in sample-return missions. It is now signalling that it is one of the scientific great powers which belongs at the proverbial table".

• CULTURE

Kullu's distinctive Dussehra: A congregation of deities that starts on Vijayadashami

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, October 20

DUSSEHRA IN Himachal Pradesh's Kullu valley begins on Vijayadashami, when celebrations elsewhere generally conclude.

It is a blend of faith, tradition and tourism. *Devtas*, considered to be living deities, are placed in large palanquins and chariots and brought to Kullu, where they are honoured for an entire week. The arrival of deities began Tuesday, with more set to reach the venue by Wednesday morning. This will mark the beginning of rituals and festivities that will run till October 27.

Dussehra after Vijayadashami

The festival's origins date to the 16th century CE during the reign of Raja Jagat Singh, who ruled Kullu from 1637 to 1662. According to local tradition, the king brought an idol of Lord Raghunath (another name for Lord Ram) from Ayodhya as an act of penance and installed it at Sultanpur near Kullu on the occasion of Vijayadashami. He subsequently accepted the deity as the kingdom's presiding lord, placing the royal authority under it.

The annual congregation of local deities became central to the festival, with Kullu's Dhalpur ground serving as the venue for their assembly. Lord Raghunath remains the principal deity, and the others are gathered to pay obeisance to him. The ceremonial procession is accompanied by drums, trumpets and devotees. Deities are brought from different parts of Kullu valley, including Manali, Banjar, Anni, Nirmand, Sainj, Gadsa and Manikaran.

According to local tradition, the deities also visit Rupi Palace — also known as the Sultanpur Palace — to meet the erstwhile royal family. Former BJP MLA and MP Maheshwar Singh is current scion of the erstwhile princely state of Kullu.

The number of deities

Principally, 284 *devtas* — including *devis* (also addressed as *shaktis*) — were registered in the revenue records of Kullu Valley. This particular record, called Wajib-Ul-Arz, contains the names of deities who have landholdings in their individual names.



The main procession of the Kullu Dussehra at the Dhalpur ground in Kullu. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

This year, the festival organiser, International Kullu Dussehra Committee (IKDC), has invited a record 347 deities

According to Sunder Singh Thakur, Congress MLA from Kullu and president of IKDC, there are many factors behind the increased numbers. "Over a period of time, the followers of the main *devta* reduced and those of the local *devtas* increased. The number of followers also counts in the local recognition. The Kullu Devi-Devta Kardar Sangh decides and recommends the recognition of the devtas to the local administration," Thakur told *The Indian Express*. The Kullu Devi-Devta Kardar Sangh is an organisation representing the *kardars* (caretakers or administrators) of the local deities in Kullu district.

On Friday (October 16), the Himachal Pradesh High Court rejected a petition moved by a *gharelu devta* (household deity belonging to a particular family or clan), Devta Bansheera Maharaj Sidhwan, demanding a special invitation and other facilities, including *nazrana* (ceremonial gift), to attend the seven-day-long gala.

"The number has increased from 284 to 347 since 1948. There are many *gharelu devtas* that are also demanding official recognition and place at the ground, but every *devta* cannot be recognised. The Wajib-ul-Arz, a historical revenue document recording village customs and related rights, is among the references used in assessing traditional claims," he said.

Doti Ram Thakur, president of the Kullu Devi-Devta Kardar Sangh, told *The Indian Express*: "We cannot accommodate every *devta* at Dhalpur ground. The number of *devtas* has been increased but the space is limited. Last year, the number of invited devtas was 332."

"We have to provide space to every *devta* for installing a tent, for accommodating its *kardars*, sewage facility, food, etc. The committee and local administration are also responsible for giving every *devta* a *nazrana*, including expenses of their arrival from their native place and other expenses," an IKDC office-bearer said.

A fillip to the tourism economy

Kullu Deputy Commissioner Amit Sharma, who is also vice-president of IKDC, said the gathering generates economic activity by attracting visitors from across India and abroad. "To attract more visitors, IKDC is going to organise a global dance performance for the first time, wherein folk artists were invited from the US, Russia, Tajikistan, Malaysia, and other countries. Besides this, a laser drone show will also be performed," Sharma told *The Indian Express*.

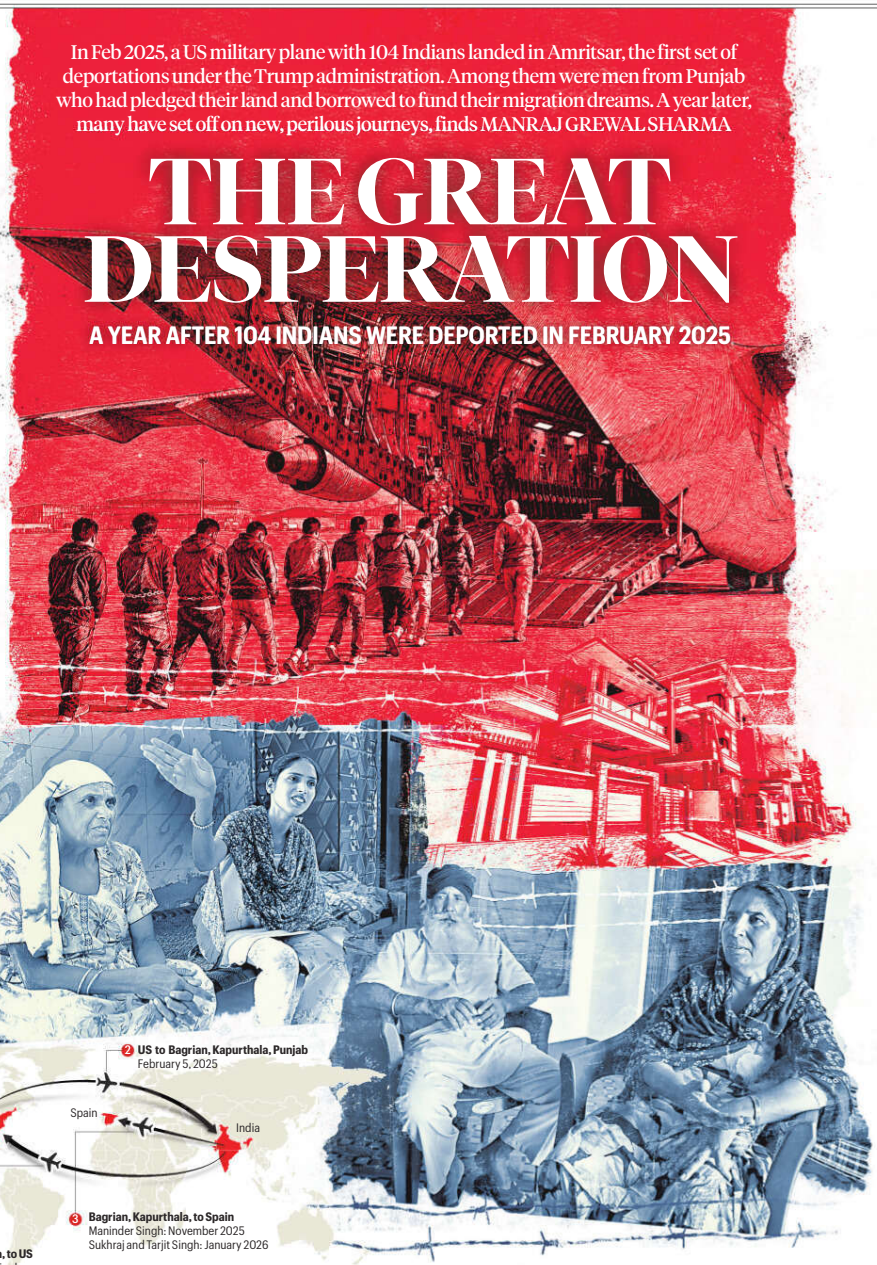
The political connection

Devtas matter in politics. Former BJP legislator Maheshwar Singh represents the erstwhile royal family and performs traditional ceremonial duties connected with Lord Raghunath's chariot. He is the first to pull the chariot of Lord Raghunath. It is believed that *devtas* influence the state's politics, be it on the panchayat level or in legislative and parliamentary elections. No politician can undermine the importance of *devtas* owing to their followers.

In Feb 2025, a US military plane with 104 Indians landed in Amritsar, the first set of deportations under the Trump administration. Among them were men from Punjab who had pledged their land and borrowed to fund their migration dreams. A year later, many have set off on new, perilous journeys, finds MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

THE GREAT DESPERATION

A YEAR AFTER 104 INDIANS WERE DEPORTED IN FEBRUARY 2025



THE NARROW, brick-lined lane in Bagrian village, in Punjab's Kapurthala district, was quiet and dark when Maninder Singh returned in the early hours of a cold February day in 2025. As villagers gathered around the Punjab Police vehicle that stopped near the gurdwara, Maninder Singh shuffled out with two others, looking dazed and spent.

He had just returned after a gruelling 40-hour flight, one of 104 Indians who had been handcuffed and shackled at the ankles aboard a US military aircraft that landed in Amritsar on February 5, 2025.

There were no smiles, no conversation, only grim faces. "*Dukh di ghari si* (it was an hour of grief)," recalls sarpanch Charanjit Singh.

Minutes later, Maninder, 41, was with his stunned family: his parents, an ailing grandmother, his wife and two little daughters, who were asleep. That was the first time the family had seen or heard from him since he left for the US in January 2025.

As news of the deportation flight, the first of its kind, and the ordeal of those on board dominated the news cycle, Punjab watched in anguish and anger. Among those sent back were people who had sold land, pledged homes, borrowed from relatives and moneylenders, and paid agents lakhs of rupees to reach the US. Some had been deported within days; others spent months in detention before being put on flights to India. The Ministry of External Affairs puts the number of Indians deported from the US between January 2025 and July 2026 at 4,800. Of the 3,567 Indians deported from the US in 2025, around 40% were from Punjab.

Many wondered if the deportation would finally end, or at least slow down, the great migration out of Punjab into foreign lands.

In Bagrian village, the answer came nine months later. Of those deported from the US in February 2025, three were from Bagrian. In the months that followed, all three of them packed their bags again. This time, for Spain.

The deportations had not ended the migration story, merely altered its direction.

The representative of a travel agency, who spoke on condition of anonymity, says that while deportation from the US does not bar an applicant from seeking and getting a Schengen visa to enter Europe, it could considerably lower the candidate's chances.

Thus, many of those who left for Europe may have had to take the illegal route, said another travel agent. "Spain has become a preferred destination because it is easy to arrange a tourist visa there for around Rs 8-10 lakh. This is much cheaper than going to the US or Canada. Later, it is easy to extend the visa and even get a work permit. Besides, the borders are very fluid and the boys from Punjab often move to Portugal or even Italy."

'He went for our daughters'

Two roads, narrow and dusty, cut through Bagrian, a village of around 1,600 residents. But it's the houses — most with glass-and-wood facades and ornate gates — lining these roads that speak of Bagrian's aspirations and its remittance architecture. Almost every household has one or two members living abroad.

Until two years ago, Maninder Singh, 42, who belongs to the Dalit Mazhabi community, worked as a doctor's assistant at a clinic near Bagrian. Things were going fine, but he didn't want his children to be left behind. So he decided to try his luck in the United States.

"For our daughters," says Maninder's wife, Amandeep Kaur, 32, taking a break from washing a pile of clothes to sit down on a cot. "He wanted them to grow up in a better house, have the comforts the Jat Sikh families in the village have. He said he would take us there some day and we would all have a better life."

The couple's four-year-old daughter, Rajdeep, attends the government school in Bagrian, while their two-year-old, Gursimrat, goes to the local anganwadi centre.

In 2025, Maninder took a loan of Rs 30 lakh to arrange for the journey to the US.

But his American dream ended before it could start. He was illegally crossing into the US from Mexico, when he was held by US Border Patrol agents. A month after leaving home in January 2025, he was back in Bagrian.

With the loan hanging on the family like deadweight, in November 2025, nine months after he returned from the US, Maninder set off again, this time to Spain on a "temporary visa that can be extended". He is now employed as a farmhand near Barcelona.



1 **Bagrian, Kapurthala, to US**
Maninder Singh, Sukhraj and Tarjit Singh: January 2025

2 **US to Bagrian, Kapurthala, Punjab**
February 5, 2025

3 **Bagrian, Kapurthala, to Spain**
Maninder Singh: November 2025
Sukhraj and Tarjit Singh: January 2026

• PUNJAB MIGRATION WAVE

1 in 7 rural households (13.34%) has at least one family member abroad

41.88% of those surveyed named Canada as their most preferred destination

20.51% of the migration from Majha region (Gurdaspur and Tarn Taran districts), followed by Malwa (14.28%) & Doaba (11.27%)

₹18-25 lakh spent by families on study visa and up to Rs 4 lakh on work visa, spouse visa or permanent residency

₹25-32.5 lakh spent by families of those who went by illegal means

19.38% of families sold assets (land, houses, gold, tractors) to fund their journeys

SOURCE: PAU-LUDHIANA SURVEY CONDUCTED IN 2021-23

"He calls regularly from Spain and says he will soon start sending money," says Amandeep.

But this time, the stakes are higher. Her husband mortgaged their house for "several lakhs" to finance the journey to Spain.

For now, the family is surviving on the old-age pension that Maninder's parents get, free rations, and the monthly Rs 3,000 that Amandeep and her mother-in-law have been getting since July as part of the state government's Mukh Mantri Mawan Dheeyan Satkar scheme for women.

Amandeep is a graduate of Lovely Professional University, but with Maninder away, the responsibility of running the house falls on her, and she can't afford to consider a career of her own.

"I have severe backaches. My husband can barely see. How can she work?" says her mother-in-law Manjit Kaur.

The family that keeps trying

Metres away from Maninder's house is the part of Bagrian village that's inhabited by Jat Sikhs. The houses here are larger and more elaborately designed, with wood panels and glass panes. Jasbir Singh's house, with brown floor tiles, is among the few that are still modest.

> **"My husband wanted our daughters to grow up in a better house... He said he would take us to the US some day and we would all have a better life."**
> **AMANDEEP KAUR,** WIFE OF MANINDER SINGH, WHO IS NOW IN SPAIN

Sitting in the living room that doubles as their bedroom, Jasbir Singh and his wife Baljit Kaur talk of how their world collapsed when their younger son, Sukhraj, was deported from the US in February 2025. He was caught while attempting to scale the wall from Mexico and kept in detention for 20 days before being deported.

Sukhraj was among the first to tell the Indian media that the deportees had been brought back in shackles.

But the experience did little to deter him from trying his luck again. He is now in Spain on a "temporary visa". The family claims the agent sent him by air and he landed in Madrid.

Ask them how much they paid the agent and they claim only Sukhraj would know. "The agent treats him like a son," says Baljit.

Sukhraj's deportation from the US was not the first time the family's immigration dreams had ended in disappointment.

In 2000, Jasbir had spent Rs 4 lakh to move to Greece where he spent four years working as a farmhand before returning home, depressed and barely speaking.

"It was not a good experience. The farmer made him work like a slave but paid him a pittance. He went into depression and still takes medication," says Jasbir's wife Baljit.

Then, in 2012, their elder son, Gurpreet Singh, left for Germany when he was barely 18. The family had paid an agent Rs 9 lakh to arrange his journey.

Gurpreet spent nine years in Germany, working at a local restaurant. He repaid the loan and even applied for permanent residence. But one morning, the German police knocked on his door.

"It was 4 am. They asked him to get his rucksack and escorted him to the airport. He still doesn't know why he was sent back," Baljit Kaur says.

Gurpreet now tends to two cows and sells milk in Bagrian, barely making ends meet.

Baljit is hopeful, now that Sukhraj is in Spain. "He recently found work at a restaurant... It's easy to extend visas in Spain," she says.

Does the possibility of another return haunt the family?

Jasbir shrugs. "What choice do we have? We have no land left. We sold off the little land we had to fund these journeys. Farming land on lease is risky. You have to pay the lease even if you reap a poor harvest. Private jobs here pay little, and employers can dismiss you at their whim. *Te phir, nasheyaan ne kam kharaab kita hai* — and then, drugs have spoiled things. Abroad, you are certain to get your wages, even if the work is hard. You get a salary cheque, no matter what."

'What can he do here?'

At the end of the lane is the house of Tarjit Singh, 32, another youth who was deported in February 2025. With shiny marble floors, trendy wooden ceilings and an SUV in the driveway, the three-storey house speaks of quiet luxury.

With the state government promising to rehabilitate deported youths, his mother Nirmal Kaur says the family approached a local politician, who offered Tarjit a job as a security guard at Punjab Agricultural University, Ludhiana, for a monthly salary of Rs 15,000.

Tarjit instead chose to go to Spain on a "temporary visa" earlier this year.

Nirmal Kaur says her younger son, Dharamjit, 30, too, is in Spain.

"He works in a restaurant there. He went eight years ago, but has not come back home even once. He says he will return once he gets his papers."

Yet, when it was Tarjit's turn to leave, she didn't object. "It's his choice," she says. "He wants to make something of his life. What would he have done here anyway? We have very little land."

Charanjit Singh, the sarpanch of Bagrian, says the village has a long tradition of sending people abroad. "Everyone wants to do better in life with little education," says Charanjit, who himself worked in Doha for eight years before returning home. "Most of the youngsters who migrate haven't studied beyond Class 10 or 12. They don't have the degree or skills to get a good job here," he says.

Not everyone takes the illegal route to citizenship abroad, says Ajaib Singh, who retired as a sub-inspector from the Punjab Police four months ago.

Around nine years ago, his elder daughter Harshpreet went to Canada after clearing IELTS, the English language proficiency test for study, work, and migration across major English-speaking countries. His younger daughter, Sukhman, followed five years ago. Ajaib Singh says he would rather that his son, who studies at DAV University in Jalandhar, stay back in Punjab, but then, "if he is destined to settle abroad, he will".

(above) Jasbir Singh and Baljit Kaur at their home in Bagrian, Kapurthala. Their son Sukhraj is now in Spain; (above, left) Amandeep Kaur, wife of Maninder Singh, with her mother-in-law Manjit Kaur. PHOTOS BY JASBIR MALHI

THOSE WHO STAYED

Narinder Singh, 40

Narinder Singh of Mukerian, Hoshiarpur district, spent around Rs 40 lakh for his US journey in January 2025. He used the money he saved from working as a security guard in Dubai from 2015 to 2018. "We also farm our land and other land on lease. So, money was not an issue," says Narinder, now 40.

He wanted to go to Canada, but the agent persuaded him to go to the US. He travelled by road with four other Punjabi men for 20 days through Ethiopia, Nicaragua and Mexico on what was ostensibly a visitor visa.

At the Mexico-US border, the group faced a wall about 20 feet high. "We climbed up a ladder and then climbed down another," he says.

They were promptly caught by the US Border Patrol, arrested and deported a few days later. The agent returned half of Narinder's money.

Looking back, Narinder understands what a close shave he had. "I am counting my blessings. At least I didn't make the mistake of borrowing money for this journey. There is no point going anywhere by illegal means."

He now says he will farm to earn a living.

Manjinder Singh, 27

After nine years in the US, Manjinder Singh, the son of a retired Indian Army havildar, was deported in February 2026.

From Khurda village near Hoshiarpur, he left for the US in 2018 when he was barely 18. "Those days, there wasn't any high wall between Mexico and the US. I just drove in," he says.

Manjinder says he joined a driving school and passed a test that qualified him to drive trucks across the US. He claims he had a US work permit and life was good in the initial years. "I was earning over 6,000 USD a month. New York is expensive, but I was alone, so I managed."

Over time, he repaid the loan his family had taken to send him abroad.

Then, in late January 2026, he travelled to North Dakota when he was stopped for an inspection. "One look and they declared me an 'illegal' to be deported right away. That's how it works there these days," he says.

At home, Manjinder is still finding his feet. "Things are so chaotic here. No one follows rules anywhere. Even a visit to the bank can take ages."

Lakhwinder Singh, 28

Lakhwinder Singh, from Tepla village in Patiala district, was detained on December 15, 2024, immediately after he crossed the US border. He spent the next seven-and-a-half months at a detention centre in Mississippi, followed by another two-and-a-half months at a New Jersey facility, before he was finally deported in September 2025.

"The conditions were terrible," Lakhwinder recalls of his time in Mississippi. "The food was awful — just boiled rice and boiled rajma." In New Jersey, he says, he was held alongside convicted criminals in a barrack of seven double-bunk beds.

Before he entered the US, Lakhwinder worked on a farm in Italy for six months, but quit when he wasn't paid his due. He then crossed into Spain, Nicaragua, Guatemala and Mexico, from where he scaled a 30-foot wall into the US. The journey cost him Rs 47 lakh, for which he sold two acres at home.

Lakhwinder is now back to farming, on two acres that he has taken on lease. He lives with his father, Sohan Lal, who drives a lorry, and his wife, Shivani, 28, their two-year-old daughter and their three-month-old son. "We are just surviving," he says.

Nishan Singh, early 20s

From Chakoki Dhalwan village in Kapurthala district, Nishan Singh's family paid agents Rs 30 lakh for his US trip. Nishan, however, ended up in France, where he spent three years before he could head for Mexico. From there, he crossed the wall into the US, only to be deported in March 2026.

By then, the family had shelled out Rs 60 lakh to the agents, says his sister Kamal. Of that, they have since recovered just Rs 2 lakh. Their father, who serves in the Sikh Regiment, had even mortgaged their land and has since been attempting to reclaim it.

Kamal, who, after her Class 12, was preparing for her IELTS exam to go abroad, is now pursuing a beautician's diploma. Her plans have been on hold since her brother's return. Nishan, now in his early twenties, has taken up work as a security guard.

Kamal says the family decided to send Nishan abroad when their elder sister, a nurse, returned home after a failed marriage. "The groom's family asked for a motorcycle. We gave everything, but the marriage didn't last. We hoped Nishan would go abroad, earn some money for the family," she says.

Naresh Singh, 30

In September 2024, Naresh Singh left his Ladhu Ka village in Fazilka district for Mumbai via Amritsar, and then to Guyana. He didn't have a visa and says his agents told him he would get one only later.

Naresh says he started out with 12 people, mostly Indians, and was held captive at different points for months. In Ecuador, he says, 50-60 migrants joined the group. In Guatemala, he says, kidnappers threatened to shoot them if they did not pay up.

Crossing forests and rivers, travelling in small boats and on foot, the group reached Mexico. By then, Naresh's family had paid the agents Rs 42.6 lakh. But he was caught at the border and spent days in a US detention centre.

Months later, Naresh remains distressed. "I think about the misery I have caused my parents," he says. His father drives a tractor-trolley during the agricultural season; his brother serves in the Army. His family sold land, a Bullet motorcycle and a buffalo, borrowed Rs 10 lakh, and his mother and sister-in-law sold their gold to pay the agents.

Naresh says he filed an FIR and approached the state Human Rights Commission.

TUNNEL BORING MACHINES CRUCIAL FOR BULLET TRAIN PROJECT

China's TBM curbs raise concerns over infra project impact

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, October 20



The restrictions on the export of the boring machines will come into effect from November 18. NHSRCL

THE FRESH curbs imposed by China on the export of tunnel boring machines (TBMs) are likely to hit several construction projects in India.

China has imposed fresh global restrictions on tunnel boring machines, a key piece of equipment for construction used in metro rail and highway construction.

The 3,000-tonne boring machines played a key role in several construction projects, particularly for India's maiden 508-km bullet train project, the Mumbai–Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail (MAHSR) Corridor. The project also includes a 7-km-long undersea rail tunnel.

TBMs are known to ensure a safer excavation process, and are useful when the tunnel passes through a densely populated area where conventional blasting methods would pose risks. These machines are used in several countries across Europe, Canada, the US, and Australia.

China's Commerce and Industry Ministry on Monday said export operators would need to apply for a license in accordance with the provisions of export control law and regulations on the export control of dual-use items, and that the restrictions will become effective on November 18.

Tension over TBMs with India

While China has announced a fresh licensing mechanism on TBMs, India has been facing delays in its imports since 2024. However, it received the TBMs in March after tensions began easing between the two countries.

In a video of an interaction between Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Germany's then Vice Chancellor Robert Habeck during a metro train ride in Delhi in 2024, Goyal had flagged issues with delayed shipments. He told Habeck that India was supposed to get some TBMs from the German company Herrenknecht AG, a leader in TBMs, that it was making in China. The sale of those machines to India was being blocked.

Herrenknecht told *The Indian Express* in 2024 that for several months, the company has been observing "extraordinary circumstances" in the customs clearance processes for machines to be delivered from China to India. These were hindering them from fulfilling delivery obligations, it had said.

Impact depends on use of control

While a fresh licensing mechanism gives more leverage to the Chinese government in trade talks, the impact on India would depend on how China uses such restrictions. Goyal said last week that India is "working to develop the relationship with China once again, but the last word has not yet been scripted on this journey". However, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman have flagged concerns over economic issues with China, underlining the "one-sided" and "tilted" trade balance. The country's trade deficit with China in the first six months of 2026-27 was $69 billion, 27% higher than in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

India has been opening its door to Chinese investment in certain strategic areas, including the power sector. But India has been ramping up anti-dumping measures on China too. According to Swiss think tank Global Trade Alert, India opened 18 anti-dumping and anti-subsidy investigations in the July-September quarter, more than any other country. The single largest target was China.

Staking up the cards

A series of Chinese restrictions also comes as China is involved in high-level negotiations with the US and the EU. While the US and China have entered a two-month trade truce, China and the EU are also involved in trade talks after the EU moved to limit imports of Chinese-made electric vehicles and EV batteries and imposed measures to protect the European steel industry.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

'RENAULT BRINGS BACK DUSTER, PLANS TO REVIVE INDIA FORTUNES'

Lost some ground, will have 7 cars in lineup by 2030: Renault India CEO



EXPRESS interview | STEPHANE DEBLAISE
RENAULT GROUP INDIA CEO

FRENCH CARMAKER Renault is looking to revive its fortunes in India with new launches, including the return of its popular Duster SUV, a greater focus on hybrid and CNG vehicles, and plans to expand its portfolio to seven models by 2030.

After losing ground while restructuring its European operations, Renault is betting on India's engineering and manufacturing capabilities. The country, with over 6,000 engineers, is its second-largest engineering base after France.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*' **Soumyarendra Barik**, Renault Group India CEO **Stephane Deblaise** acknowledged that a prolonged lack of new launches had hurt the company amid intensifying competition in India since the original Duster debuted in 2012. He said the revival strategy extends beyond the hybrid Duster. Edited excerpts:

You are bringing Duster back to India. How has the response been, and how crucial is it for Renault's revival in the country?

Duster is a name that many people know in India, because we created the segment in 2012. The platform on which we can put a lot of technical solutions. And last, but least, the Duster was successful 14 years ago thanks to diesel, but today, we think that we will be successful thanks to the hybrid. It has a fuel efficiency of 29 litres per kilometre, which is better than the competition.

Duster, though, is one piece of the game. We have a great lineup. For instance, we launched the Triber with a nearly 100 bhp engine, and nobody offers a seven seater car like that at Rs 6 lakh.

What I want to tell you is that we are not only focusing on the Duster, though it is a very important car. We have several cars in our lineup, and we will have more. We have two platforms, we are investing in people because we have more than 6,000 engineers in India, which makes India more or less the second biggest engineering centre in the world after France for us. We are investing in products. By 2030 we will have seven cars in the lineup, and we are investing in our manufacturing plant, which we have bought from Nissan. If you invest in people, technology, and production, you are part of the game.

Despite being a famous name in India, initial traction towards the new Duster was sluggish. How has the hybrid version done abroad, and do you hope it will help the car in India?

It's working amazingly. It's over performing in Europe. There, we sell only the hybrid, and the market share of the Duster is very high. The hybrid Duster is a very good solution for India, where powertrains are very important. In Europe, people are gradually starting to pay less attention to displacement, but India has not forgotten the engine yet. Indians are still preoccupied by having a good engine, a big displacement, and good fuel efficiency. The hybrid Duster has a 1.8 litre engine, you can not be any bigger in this type of a car. India should like the car.

Renault had some big hits in India. But it has not been able to sustain initial traction in a way that leads to long-term growth. What went wrong?

Yes, you are right on all that you said. In fact, between 2018 to 2023, Renault had decided to focus its revival plan in Europe. Apparently, it was a good choice because it worked. But after 2023, it was decided to look at international expansion. But there was this lack of product during a certain time, and it explains why the second Duster did not come to India, and why we lost ground at that time.

We see a broad divergence in powertrain focus among Indian carmakers. Some seem to be leaning more on EV, others on hybrids and CNG. What is Renault's plan for India?

Electrification is at the core of our strategy and development. And we say electrification by purpose, because it doesn't mean only full electric cars. It means plug-in hybrids, regular hybrids, range-extenders etc. Depending on the customers, we will develop either a strong hybrid, or an EV. For India, a key part of our strategy is to acknowledge that CNG seems to be a good solution. So, we will develop many more CNG options, especially for value conscious customers.

FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Jio is a tech company, not just a telco: Akash Ambani

New Delhi: Jio Platforms is betting that its technology, artificial intelligence (AI) and cloud ambitions will drive growth beyond telecom, Managing Director Akash Ambani said on Tuesday, pitching the Reliance Industries unit as a technology company ahead of what is set to be India's biggest-ever initial public offering.

"There is no either-or at Jio: the network is our technology," Ambani said in an interview with *PTI*, highlighting the company's in-house 5G core, cloud-native radio access network and software platform serving 533.3 million customers.

"Connectivity was the first product we built on that platform. Digital services, AI and cloud are what we are layering on top of it now," he said.

Jio Platforms plans to raise over Rs 30,200 crore through the IPO, valuing the business at around $108 billion. The offering comes as investors assess whether the country's largest telecom operator can convert its vast customer base into higher-margin revenue from digital services, enterprise technology and AI, as subscriber growth alone becomes a less powerful driver of expansion. The company has also identified satellite connectivity and next-generation 6G technology as future areas of development. Ambani said Jio's growth opportunities extend across mobile services, to home broadband and enterprise digital solutions. Around 26 crore Indians still use 2G services, while fixed broadband reaches only about 21% of the households. PTI

Corporate profits off to good start in early second quarter results

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, October 20

CORPORATE EARNINGS are off to a strong start in the September quarter, with net profit of a sample of 169 companies, including banks, financials, and insurance, rising 22.8% year-on-year to Rs 1.39 lakh crore, outpacing sales growth of 16.3%.

Aggregate net sales stood at Rs 8.33 lakh crore, while operating profit rose 21.4% to Rs 3.30 lakh crore.

The divergence between revenue and profit growth points to improved operating leverage, with companies generating more profit from each rupee of sales.

Operating margin expanded 167 basis points year-on-year to 39.6%, as expenditure grew 13.2%, slower than sales. Sequentially, operating profit rose 9.5% even as sales grew just 0.3%, suggesting that improved profitability, rather than revenue expansion alone, is driving the early earnings momentum.

The IT sector presents a mixed picture, with AI-led demand providing fresh growth opportunities even as traditional technology spending remains uneven. HCLTech and Tech Mahindra reported double-digit year-on-year profit growth, while Wipro's net profit declined despite higher revenue. TCS reported modest dollar-denominated revenue growth.

TCS CEO K Krithivasan said the company saw broad-based growth across international markets and most industry segments, while demand for AI-led transformation was gaining momentum. HCLTech's C Vijayakumar, however, cautioned that the demand environment remained fluid, despite an improvement towards the end of the quarter.

The contrasting commentary underlines the sector's challenge: converting growing interest in AI into sustained revenue growth as clients continue to scrutinise traditional technology spending. Infosys is scheduled to report on October 23

Consumer businesses are seeing stronger sales, but the extent to which this translates into profits varies. Nestlé India's revenue rose 20.3% to Rs 6,788 crore, while consolidated net profit increased 35.9% to Rs 1,010 crore, supported by double-digit volume growth. However, the company flagged rising food inflation and continued commodity cost pressures, with sugar and edible oil prices remaining elevated and cocoa prices volatile. Chairman and Managing Director Manish Tiwary said the company would focus on product innovation, productivity and operational efficiencies to mitigate the pressure. FE

Qualcomm to slash jobs in performance focused layoffs

Bengaluru: Qualcomm will cut jobs globally in a "performance-focused reduction" following its annual employee reviews, CEO Cristiano Amon told staff in a memo on Monday reviewed by *Reuters*, with notifications set to begin in November.

The cuts are part of an effort to build "a stronger performance culture" and address situations where the company "has consistently fallen short of expectations," Amon said.

The memo did not say how many jobs would be affected, and Reuters could not immediately determine the scale of the cuts.

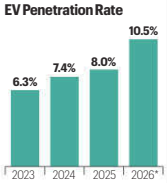
Qualcomm did not immediately respond to a request for comment. It had about 52,000 employees globally as of September last year, most of them full-time. Its financial year typically ends in late September.

One of the world's biggest smartphone chipmakers, Qualcomm has been hit this year by a slump in consumer electronics sales as soaring memory prices weigh on demand in key markets. Its shares have risen just 1.5% in 2026, compared with gains of more than 12% for the benchmark S&P 500 and nearly 60% for the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index. Qualcomm shares were up more than 1% after trading down about 0.5% earlier on Tuesday. In its latest earnings report in late July, Qualcomm forecast quarterly profit below estimates and said revenue from Apple products would decline faster than expected. REUTERS

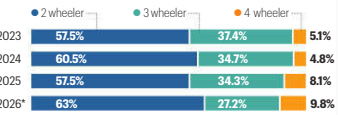
EV PENETRATION CROSSES 10% MARK

- For the first time, the electric vehicle (EV) penetration rate crossed the 10% mark in 2026 (till September 21).
- The share of the two-wheeler (2W) and four-wheeler (4W) segments saw a rise against last year. According to RBI's September bulletin, it reflected the continued efforts for a broad-based transition towards clean energy.

EV Penetration Rate



Share by Vehicle Category in Total EV Registrations



*DATA ACCESSED AS ON SEPTEMBER 21, 2026;
SOURCES: VAHAN DASHBOARD; AND RBI STAFF CALCULATIONS.

CPI inflation for rural labourers outpaces general price increases

Shubham Rana
New Delhi, October 20

THE YEAR-on-year consumer price index (CPI) inflation rate for agricultural labourers (AL) and rural labourers (RL) outpaced headline CPI inflation in September, reflecting the higher burden of price pressures on the lower-income strata in rural India.

According to Labour Bureau data, CPI-AL inflation rose to 6.30% in September from 5.18% in August. CPI-RL inflation was 5.98% in September, up from 4.83% in the previous month. CPI inflation for AL and RL was -0.07% and 0.31%, respectively, in September 2025.

Inflation prints for both AL and RL were higher than the general CPI inflation of 5.54% in September. Rural CPI inflation was 6.08% in September, higher than urban inflation of 4.88%.

Sequentially, prices also rose quicker for agricultural and rural labourers at 1% each from August, while general CPI had risen 0.7% month-on-month in September.

This shows that price pressures are hurting the lower-income strata more, driven by a surge in food inflation. Food inflation for AL rose to 8.24% in September from 6.41% a month ago. For rural labourers, food inflation was 7.84% last month. FE

• BRIEFLY

OYO-parent PRISM to nearly halve IPO fresh issue size

New Delhi: OYO parent PRISM is planning to nearly halve the size of the fresh issue in its proposed IPO to up to Rs 3,350 crore from almost Rs 6,650 crore, sources said on Tuesday. People familiar with the matter told *PTI* the reduction in the issue size follows continued strong cash generation and an improving balance-sheet position, which has lowered the amount of capital the company needs to raise compared with what was originally envisaged. PTI

Number of branded housing projects set to double: Savills

New Delhi: India's real estate firms are bullish on branded residences market on rising demand from super-rich, with nearly 25 such ultra-luxury housing projects to be completed by 2032, according to Savills report. Branded residences are ultra luxury homes developed by real estate companies in association with globally renowned hospitality, design and lifestyle brands. Residents get hotel like services apart from wellness, leisure and lifestyle amenities in such projects. PTI

Turn market access into opportunity: NZ trade body

New Delhi: The India-New Zealand Chamber of Commerce and Industry on Tuesday said it is encouraging businesses, particularly small and medium-sized enterprises, to gear up for the new opportunities opened up by the bilateral trade agreement now in effect. The India-New Zealand free trade agreement has created fresh opportunities for businesses to explore trade, investment and commercial partnerships, it said. PTI

India's online retail market to cross $90 bn in 2026: Redseer

New Delhi: India's online retail market is projected to cross $90 billion in 2026, registering an annual growth of 22-24%, its fastest expansion in five years, driven by everyday consumption categories like grocery rather than mobile phones, Redseer Strategy Consultants said in a report. E-commerce gross merchandise value grew roughly 25% year-on-year to about $38 billion in the first half (H1) of 2026. PTI

• TRADITIONAL SAFE HAVENS HAVE NOT PERFORMED AS WELL AS EXPECTED THIS YEAR

How safe havens stack up as tech, energy and France fears grip markets

Reuters
London, October 20

DEMAND FOR safe-haven assets is strong as AI jitters hurt tech stocks, the Iran war continues and keeps energy prices elevated, while worries about high government debt loads persist.

Yet traditional safe havens have not performed as well as expected this year.

Here is a look at how some safe havens currently stack up.

1) LOVE/HATE RELATIONSHIP WITH THE DOLLAR

Breaking with last year's 'sell US' theme, the dollar has rallied since the Iran war started, up 4% since late February.

That has reinforced its role as a go-to safe haven at times of global stress. A strong economy, higher rates, and the US' energy-exporter status have helped. But factors that caused traders to question the dollar's long-term safe-haven status, such as a more than $40 trillion debt pile and policy uncertainty, have not dissipated. The dollar is also vulnerable to tech selling as it has benefited from record capital inflows into US shares on optimism over the AI investment boom.

The dollar could be nearing the back end of a bull market, Societe Generale chief FX strategist Kit Juckes said.

"It hasn't got that much further to go," he noted

2) EUROPE WOBBLES, BUY SWISSIE

One takeaway from France-driven bond turmoil is that the Swiss franc is a haven of choice when Europe wobbles.

It is up over 2% so far this month against the euro, poised for its biggest monthly jump since late 2023. "Concerns about France's public finances and election uncertainty in France and Spain have supported the franc," said Georgette Boele, senior FX & oil strategist at ABN Amro.

She added that investors were also becoming less keen to use the franc to fund carry trades, preferring not to position against a currency with safe-haven qualities. Swiss rates at 0% make the franc popular in trades where investors borrow in a currency with low rates to invest in higher-yielding assets elsewhere.



Gold, another traditional safe haven, has had a bumpy ride. REUTERS

3) GERMAN BONDS A RELATIVE WINNER

Government bonds' reputation as a safe haven has been battered by fiscal concerns. Borrowing costs from the US to Japan recently hit multi-decade highs. The tech-driven stocks selloff has, however, renewed some demand for bonds. There is another noticeable development. When US and French 10-year bond yields hit 24-year peaks earlier this month, German yields fell as their prices rose.

Investors say that is a clear sign that triple-A rated German Bunds stand out as safe havens among major economies.

Bundesbank President Joachim Nagel said Germany would remain the anchor of stability in Europe amid bond turmoil and was "getting fit" after years of stagnation.

4) SHORT-DATED BONDS

Overall, high debt among major economies will continue to hurt long-dated bonds' safe-haven status, investors said.

But short-dated government bonds provide some shelter because they are less sensitive to debt worries. "We really like short-dated bonds," said Rory McPherson, chief market strategist at Wren Sterling. "Because of all the concerns over debts and deficits, we haven't been buying longer-dated bonds."

5) GOLD KEEPS ITS SPARKLE

Gold, another traditional safe haven, has had a bumpy ride. After hitting record highs at $5,595 per troy ounce in January, it fell after the Iran war started as investors tapped the precious metal, given losses elsewhere.

Gold rallied again in August as inflation fears and concern that the Federal Reserve was not doing enough to contain price pressures returned. It is trading around $4,175. Central bank buying and safe-haven demand support prices above $4,000, analysts say. While high interest rates should limit gold's upside, a tense geopolitical backdrop and US fiscal worries should bolster the safe-haven metal further out.

5 CARGO SHIPS, 2 LOGISTICS HUBS STRUCK, SAYS RUSSIAN DEFENCE MINISTRY

Zelenskyy meets Witkoff as US-Ukraine rift widens

Russia, frankly, has been fine on Ukraine: Trump

Reuters
Oslo, Kyiv, October 20



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy with Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Stoere, Finnish President Alexander Stubb and US envoy Steve Witkoff in Oslo, Norway, on Tuesday. AP

UKRAINIAN PRESIDENT Volodymyr Zelenskyy was meeting US special envoy Steve Witkoff Tuesday in a bid to rescue relations that have sunk to new lows as Donald Trump has courted Moscow and Kyiv has complained about Washington withholding vital defences.

Zelenskyy and Witkoff clasped one another in a hug as they went into the talks hosted by the leaders of Norway and Finland in Oslo. Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner was attending remotely. He held talks with Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Stoere and Finnish President Alexander Stubb ahead meeting with US delegation.

Kyiv says Washington has lately failed to provide early warning of Russian missile launches, throttled SpaceX's Starshield satellite links that guide Ukrainian drones, and failed to deliver air defences paid for by European allies.

Washington denies deliberately hindering Ukraine's war effort. But Trump, who has waived sanctions on Russia in what he says is an effort to lower US fuel prices, has repeatedly rebuked Zelenskyy, and called for him to be replaced.

In the latest comments expressing warmth towards Moscow and coldness towards Kyiv, Trump said on Monday: "Russia, frankly, has been fine on Ukraine." He said Zelenskyy, who has rejected Russia's maximalist conditions for ending its war, was "not helping matters much", and that Kyiv should find "somebody else to negotiate".

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio acknowledged on Tuesday that a consignment of US air defence missiles bought by European countries for Ukraine may not have been delivered, but denied that the US had changed policy.

"The important takeaway for you is that there has not been some deliberate political directive to go out and harm Ukraine," he told journalists.

The Kremlin said it was hoping to set up a meeting soon between Witkoff and Russian President Vladimir Putin, an indication Witkoff could make the latest of several visits to Kremlin after meeting Zelenskyy.

As US ties with Ukraine have deteriorated, Russia has stepped up attacks on Ukrainian cities, particularly targeting power stations and fuel, despite a call from Trump for both sides to spare each other's energy systems.

Trump has repeatedly condemned Ukrainian attacks on Russia while saying little about Russia's far more severe attacks on Ukraine, which have grown even more deadly as Kyiv says US support has been withheld for its air defences.

Russia's defence ministry said on Tuesday it struck three cargo vessels in Ukraine's port of Reni and two other cargo vessels en route to Odesa. Russian forces also hit two logistics hubs, it said.

Ukrainian officials said a Russian drone had struck near a petrol station on a highway heading south from Kyiv on Tuesday, killing three people and setting cars ablaze.

From soaring rents to street clashes, Europe's political order faces a test

Steven Erlanger
Berlin, October 20

CENTRIST PARTIES are in trouble in Europe's largest and most important nations. Anger over low economic growth, high inflation, sizable government debt and poor prospects for the young are feeding protest and populist parties of the far right and far left.

The mass riots in France, which started as protests over underfunded schools, are a shocking example. But the phenomenon has been building for years, with the perceived failure of liberal democracy to make good on its promises of a better future, especially for the young and the salaried working class.

There is a growing perception among many Europeans that traditional parties of the center-left and center-right do not offer real alternatives and are led by an educated elite that has lost its connection to the poor, the workers and the young. Facing rising deficits, expenses and interest rates, governments feel constrained in what they can do to respond.

Instead, many people are supporting parties like the National Rally of Marine Le Pen, leading the polls for the French presidency on the far right, and France Unbowed of Jean-Luc Mélenchon, on the far-left, running second. In Germany, they are turning to the far-right Alternative for Germany and the far-left Die Linke party.

With major elections coming in the next year in four of Europe's most populous states — Spain, France, Italy and Poland — there are significant challenges coming from more extremist parties. Even in Italy, where protests erupted over the weekend, the right-wing prime minister, Giorgia Meloni, faces a former general, Roberto Vannacci, who is running even further to the right.

Hard-right parties also sit in the governments of the Czech Republic, Finland, Slovakia and Croatia, while Slovenia's government relies on outside support from one, Alberto Alemanno, a professor of European Law at HEC Paris, recently noted. And competition from even further to the right is already pushing some of them to harden their positions.

There are many reasons put forward for the decline in optimism and faith in centrist politics. But Daron Acemoglu, a Nobel laureate in economics, puts it simply. "We started taking democracy for granted," he said.

Liberal democracy has failed to keep faith with ordinary citizens, and especially with the larger working class. "If liberalism is to rise again, it must be with the working class at its heart," he said. NYT

PROTEST FLASHPOINTS

Rising fuel costs, discontent with the state of schools, declining public services and a housing crisis are fuelling an autumn of protests in Europe.

FRANCE | Cost of Living
High school students oppose understaffed, dilapidated schools, while unions and activists protest rising living costs and deteriorating public services nationwide.

SPAIN | Affordable Housing
Young renters camp in central Madrid against soaring housing costs, while teachers strike over pay, staffing and worsening working conditions.



Police officers in riot gear stand guard in Paris, day after national day of demonstrations against cost of living and rising fuel prices. AP

SERBIA | Fight Corruption
University students lead nationwide anti-corruption protests challenging Vucic's planned return as prime minister, with elections raising fears of possible violence.

PORTUGAL | Lower Rents
Residents in Lisbon and Porto protest unaffordable housing, as soaring rents and costs make city life unsustainable for young people.

ITALY | Jobs and Services
Demonstrators demand better jobs, healthcare, education and housing, alongside higher wages, as inflation rises and masked groups clash with police.

BELGIUM | Oppose Austerity
Workers and students oppose austerity and budget cuts, warning reforms could erode purchasing power, wages, pensions and access to education.

ALBANIA | Anti-Corruption
Protesters demand an end to corruption and Prime Minister Edi Rama's resignation, alongside stronger protections for healthcare, education and pensions.

Hegseth in surprise Israel visit discusses Iran with Netanyahu

Reuters
Jerusalem, October 20





US Secretary of Defence Pete Hegseth (left), Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. REUTERS

US DEFENCE SECRETARY Pete Hegseth discussed Iran with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu during an unannounced visit to Israel on Monday, three Israeli officials said, as tensions flare between the US and Iran.

Doron Spielman, a spokesperson for the PM, later confirmed to *Reuters* that Netanyahu had met with Hegseth at the Uvda air force base in Israel's southern Negev desert region.

Netanyahu and Hegseth discussed "the threats in the region" and the US-Israel partnership in dealing both offensively and defensively with those threats, he said in a brief phone call.

Hegseth also thanked Israel for hosting US forces, which Spielman said numbered in the thousands, and discussed President Donald Trump's support for the prime minister.

"There's a deep personal relationship here that was at the core of this discussion," Spielman said. On Sunday, Trump endorsed Netanyahu in next week's parliamentary election in Israel, the country's first ballot since the October 7, 2023, Hamas attack on southern Israel.

The Pentagon has not publicly commented on Hegseth's visit. Hegseth earlier posted on X that he had visited US service members in the Central Command area of responsibility, which covers West Asia, northeast Africa and parts of Asia.

He did not specify where he had met with the forces.

Hegseth's visit comes as tensions flare between the US and Iran over the Strait of Hormuz and as Yemen's Iran-allied Houthis intensify their attacks on Saudi Arabia.

Pak army chief visits Iran, meets top leadership

Islamabad: Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir met top Iranian leadership in Tehran on Tuesday as part of Islamabad's efforts to de-escalate tensions in the region, amid indications that the US might be preparing for another round of fighting with the Islamic Republic.

President Masoud Pezeshkian met Field Marshal Munir, who was accompanied by Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi, in Tehran, according to Iran's state-run Press TV. Munir also met Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf.

Ghalibaf told Munir that US violations of the Islamabad MoU and repeated threats have further eroded Iran's trust, stressing that Washington must meet Iran's seven conditions and that threats will not change Tehran's strategic decisions, the channel reported. PTI

France to deploy troops, extend curfew as long as needed, says PM

Reuters
Paris, October 20

FRANCE WILL reinforce police with troops and mount a huge security operation for more protests planned Saturday, the government said Tuesday, acknowledging failures in its response to last weekend's violence.

"The deployment next Saturday will be massive," Prime Minister Sebastien Lecornu said, adding the immediate priority was to restore order after rioting and looting swept Paris, Marseille and Lyon on October 17.

In a sometimes rowdy debate, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said the military would be deployed alongside police, while the government pledged to overhaul tactics after widespread criticism that city centres had been left vulnerable.

Framing the crisis as a choice "between violence and the Republic", Lecornu blamed the unrest on far-left groups, who in turn have accused the government of underestimating public anger over high living costs and declining public services.

A night of relative calm in France followed targeted curfews imposed in several areas affected by the turmoil, which the government said had helped reassert control.

In central Paris, police emptied and guarded the Place de la Republique overnight, with a helicopter overhead. In Lille, in the north, where the curfew only applied to minors, officers patrolled the city centre, checking bypassers' identities. Marseille mayor Benoit Payan said there would be curfews for minors around the commercial areas hardest hit by the weekend's riots, starting Tuesday night.

Lecornu acknowledged shortcomings in the state's response at the weekend, saying there had been intelligence failures, while police deployments had been too static and authorities had decided against cancelling planned police leave.

Italy to expand arrest powers of police after riots

Rome: Italy will approve new security measures on Tuesday targeting minors, politicians said, after days of unrest that have seen demonstrators clash with police, loot shops and vandalise property.

Under the crackdown, law enforcers will be allowed to detain people under the age of 18 at police stations for 12 hours, even if they have not committed a crime, provided there is evidence they pose a danger, Deputy PM Matteo Salvini said.

Rome is also expected to deploy an additional 500 army troops in Milan as authorities fear more unrest. REUTERS

Bangladesh PM visits Puja pandals, vows to ensure equal rights for people of all religions

Divya A
New Delhi, October 20



Prime Minister Tarique Rahman

BANGLADESH PRIME Minister Tarique Rahman Tuesday visited several Durga Puja pandals in Rangpur and called for "ensuring equal rights for people of all religions in the country".

The visit assumes significance as it comes a year after a spate of violent attacks on minorities in Bangladesh and the criticism faced by its then interim government led by Chief Advisor Muhammad Yunus. New Delhi had consistently raised concerns with Bangladesh's interim government regarding the rising wave of attacks on religious and ethnic minorities — including Hindus, Christians and Buddhists — following the political transition in August 2024.

On Tuesday, during his visit to the Puja mandap of a temple, Rahman said: "Just as people of all religions came together to liberate this country, and worked together to establish the political rights of its people, we must also work together, irrespective of religious beliefs and affiliations, if we want to build the Bangladesh we aspire to create."

Rahman's government also announced a hike in grants, holidays and security measures ahead of festivities. According to a report by Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha (BSS), Rahman visited Puja pavilions in Rangpur, Rajshahi and Chattogram and exchanged greetings with members of Hindu community.

His Press Secretary Saleh Shibly said the government had taken necessary steps to ensure peaceful celebration of Durga Puja across the country. He also highlighted the government's principle that everyone has the right to security, regardless of their religion.

According to *The Daily Star*, Rahman recently handed over a cheque of Tk 5 crore for a Durga Puja committee, while Tk 3 crore was provided for the Buddhist community's Kathin Chibor Dan festival.

Earlier, Bangladesh Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed also spoke about security preparations after a high-level coordination meeting. Officials also focused on uninterrupted electricity supply, emergency lighting and coordination between security personnel and volunteers at pavilions, as per reports.

2 held in UK on suspicion of helping Iran over RAF Fairford incident

London: British police said Tuesday they had re-arrested two men on suspicion of assisting Iranian intelligence as part of their probe into activity at the RAF Fairford air base last month.

RAF Fairford had been used by US bombers to carry out strikes on Iran, but American B-1 bombers were withdrawn shortly after five British men were arrested outside the military base in southwest England in early hours of September 27.

Two other men were later arrested by police, though all seven were released on bail. CTP said in a statement they had re-arrested a 24-year-old British national, who was initially arrested outside RAF Fairford, and also a 25-year-old British-Iranian dual national who had previously been arrested in London.

Assistant Commissioner Laurence Taylor, head of National Counter Terrorism Policing in the UK, said in a statement: "This is very much a live investigation, and our evidence gathering continues, but at this time our position remains the same; we consider it highly likely that there is Iranian state involvement." REUTERS

BRIEFLY

KENYA

'Cult' leader convicted of murdering 191 followers through starvation



Good News International Church Pastor Paul Mackenzie

A KENYAN pastor has been convicted on 191 murder charges after he forced followers to starve their children and themselves so they would die and have an opportunity to enter heaven and be with Jesus. Pastor Paul Mackenzie was convicted with 28 others who helped run a sect connected to Mackenzie's Good News International Church in coastal southeast Kenya. A judge said in her ruling Monday MacKenzie and his helpers and guards controlled a system in which religious teachings and a church hierarchy were used to enforce "deadly fasting" on followers after they set up community in a forest. The murder charges involve deaths of 190 children and one adult. AP

COLOMBIA

14 dead, 7 injured after illegal gold mine collapses

14 PEOPLE were killed and 7 others injured following the collapse of an illegal gold mine in Colombia, local officials said Monday. Rescue and search operations have concluded, Nariño Governor Luis Alfonso Escobar said. The governor called on the national government, the National Mining Agency, and the Ministry of Mines and Energy to accelerate formalization process for illegal and small-scale miners. AP

UNITED KINGDOM

Google Cloud outage disrupts UK banking

ONLINE SERVICES for a number of UK banks in and around London were disrupted by a Google Cloud outage Tuesday. The cloud outages began just after 2 am eastern, or 6:08 am GMT. The center of the outage is London, but the impact can extend outside of UK if apps in other countries rely on London-based infrastructure. "Our engineering team continues to investigate the issue," Google Cloud said early Tuesday. AP

• RESEARCHERS SAY THEY USED AN A.I. MODEL, OMNII, TO DESIGN A VIRUS TO ATTACK ONE PATIENT'S ILLNESS

Scientists turn to AI-designed viruses to fight drug-resistant infection

Carl Zimmer
October 20



Radical Numerics is using its AI model, Omnii, to design vaccines and develop phage therapy.

SCIENTISTS SAY they have used AI-designed viruses to treat a human patient for the first time, giving a phage to fight a deadly bacterial infection.

Phages attack bacteria, and researchers hope this one will kill the microbes causing the infection. Radical Numerics, the start-up behind the viruses, posted a technical report online but declined to identify the patient or doctors involved, citing confidentiality.

The report has not been peer-reviewed or published in a scientific journal. The company said the trial was authorized by the Food and Drug Administration.

"We take our responsibility to protect patient confidentiality and maintain the trust of our clinical partners extremely seriously," said Eric Nguyen, Radical Numerics' chief executive.

"If it works, that's incredible," said Michael Baym, a Harvard University microbiologist not involved in the research. He said he would reserve judgment until treatment ends and the viruses' novelty can be assessed. "My impulse is to be skeptical," he said.

Phage therapy dates back more than a century but has gained renewed attention as antibiotic resistance grows.

Yet each phage infects only a limited range of bacterial strains, and finding one that targets an infection can be slow. "Hunting for phages is remarkably time-consuming," said Marisa Azad, an infectious disease clinician at Ottawa Hospital collaborating with the company.

Scientists are trying to design phages for individual patients. In 2025, researchers at California's Arc Institute developed Evo 2, an AI model trained on millions of DNA sequences, including phage genes.

It generated 700,000 virus genomes. Researchers synthesized DNA from 285 and inserted it into bacteria; 16 genomes produced viable viruses.

In June, the company introduced Omnii, an AI model trained on DNA and other biological information, including protein structures.

The team created variants of T7, a phage that infects only E coli. Omnii designed genes that changed the shape of T7's legs, which anchor the virus to bacteria. The infection had resisted antibiotics and all available phages.

Researchers trained Omnii on the resistant strain and told it to design T7 phages able to latch onto the bacteria. They produced the DNA, inserted it into bacteria and generated phages that infected and killed other microbes. After safety testing, the phages were given to the doctors, and the FDA authorized the trial.

There is no guarantee the treatment will work, said Brandon Berryhill, an evolutionary microbiologist at Uppsala University in Sweden. Lab tests cannot reliably predict how well a phage will control an infection, he said, and much remains unknown about why treatments succeed or fail.

Doctors may monitor the patient for months because infections can return after treatment, which can last days or weeks. If the trial succeeds, Nguyen hopes AI can speed the development of phages tailored to individual infections. "We think we can get it done in days," he said. NYT

Shami sets the record straight after sitting out 2nd-round game



Mohammad Shami has been away from the national team for more than 20 months. PTI

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, October 20

WHEN MOHAMMAD Shami skipped Bengal's second-round Ranji Trophy clash against Services this weekend, questions were raised about his commitment and fitness. Just two days before the game, Shami missed the cut for India's ODI and Test squads for the forthcoming New Zealand tour, extending his time away from the national team to more than 20 months.

However, when Bengal wrapped up a 60-run win on Tuesday, Shami's decision to sit out of a low-scoring match at the Air Force Ground in Palam was vindicated. Spinners bagged 39 of the 40 wickets before Shami chose to set the record straight.

The 36-year-old refused to entertain questions on his fitness for long. "*Hum peak main hi hain. Zabardasti jhoot bolne main koi faayda nahin. Jaise bhi hai, hum peak main hi hain* (I am still at the peak of my fitness. Why would I lie?. However I am, I am at the peak of my fitness)," a defiant Shami told reporters.

"You could see the condition of this pitch, right? There was no point in playing on this wicket for 2-4 overs. It was better for the youngsters to get a run here," he explained.

Shami firmly brushed off social media murmurs that suggested he could no longer handle intense red-ball bowling loads and demanded frequent breaks in between spells with the Bengal side.

"How can anyone else from the outside decide whether I bowl long spells or not? That is completely dependent on the demands of the team. It is not like I will keep bowling over after over," Shami said.

"On a wicket like this, how can it be planned that a fast bowler will bowl five or ten overs? This thing depends entirely on the game situation and pitch conditions."

Last week, he sent down over 35 overs for five wickets in Bengal's nine-wicket win over Delhi in Kalyani. Sitting out did not mean a complete halt to his bowling load.

"I bowled for one-and-a-half hours today. There was no issue," he added.

A national recall appears increasingly slim, but Shami reiterated that he hasn't given up. "Why should I give up hope? The hope should always be there. In any profession, you should always have a goal. I don't deny I have that goal."

RANJI TROPHY

A hat-trick and a statement: Sai Kishore bounces back after snub

Left-arm spinner's 6/34 helps Tamil Nadu bundle out Uttarakhand for innings win

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, October 20

THE BEST Na Muthukumar lyrics to sum up R Sai Kishore's situation would be: "*Eri malai vanthal kooda eri ninu por thodupom*" (Even if a volcano erupts, will climb right on top of it and wage war).

It is what he has been doing despite being overlooked for competitions like the Duleep Trophy, Irani Cup and India A squads. In the last four Ranji seasons, he has been among the best-performing spinners. Yet, it seems like the selectors have forgotten him.

On Tuesday, he sent another reminder, taking a hat-trick en route to a six-wicket haul to skittle out Uttarakhand for 113 and give Tamil Nadu an innings and 66-run win at the MA Chidambaram Stadium. "*Irukalam* (maybe)," Sai Kishore said, when asked whether the hat-trick was the headline-seeking performance he needed to put him in the limelight.

"But I don't know what to say. I didn't bowl to take a hat-trick. Was just doing my job. I think when I am very honest to myself and when I am working hard, I think God is giving me all these things. I already have a hat-trick in T20. Very happy to have one in first-class as well. My coach Ramkumar, he had a hat-trick for Tamil Nadu. So he always tells me that 'you still don't have a hat-trick. Now I think we are even," the 29-year-old said.

When Uttarakhand began play on Day 3, they had a big task ahead. Still trailing TN by 170 runs, their only hope was the weather.

The collapse, however, was started by Sai Kishore's fellow left-arm spinner S Ajith Ram, who provided not just control, but also was the enforcer, removing D Nischal and Kunal Chandela off successive overs. Sai Kishore would then take out J Suchith before Ajith Ram removed Avneesh Sudha, caught bat pad as Uttarakhand took lunch at 91/5.

Performance-focused

Thereafter, it was all Sai Kishore. For his hat-trick, he bowled Lakshya Raichandani around his legs when he went for an expansive sweep to a delivery that landed on the rough. Off the next delivery, Baba Indrajith pouched a low catch at slip before Aditya Rawat nicked one to the wicketkeeper to hand Sai Kishore the hat-trick.

"I think I'm someone who is very grateful for what I have in my life," Sai Kishore said of the selection setbacks.

"When I first played for Tamil Nadu, I never thought I would even play even one season. Since I come from a non-cricketing background, I felt cricket is not the go-to thing. So, God has been very kind. Been able to play for Tamil Nadu for so long. And Indian cricket is filled with talent. To be fair, last year to my own benchmark, it wasn't my best season. I still had like three, three-and-a-half wickets per game, but still, for my own standard, it wasn't my best season. So, I just take it in my stride and focus on my performance," Sai Kishore added.

After being omitted from the Duleep Trophy squad, Sai Kishore joined Gloucestershire for a county stint, where he was regularly among the wickets, with his dismissal of Ben Stokes even going viral.



Sai Kishore sent back Lakshya Raichandani, Saurabh Rawat and Aditya Rawat off successive balls. PTI

During that stint, Sai Kishore showed a different side to his bowling, where he delivered from different angles, including over the wicket to right-handers.

Dhoni's role

It is something he did during this fixture as well, and he credited MS Dhoni for it. "I think that is something that I learned during my stint with CSK. MS Dhoni was heavy on that. But at that time I didn't have that understanding to know what he was telling. Last two years, I've started embracing it. When bowling from different angles, my ball behaves differently, and that is reaping rewards," he said.

Last year during the IPL, he delivered a carrom-ball, which he tried in the Ranji Trophy, taking the wicket of Vidarbha's Yash Rathod. "I think most bowlers should be having that control. Because we don't have freedom we might think we cannot bowl it. I think once you open up, once you're just playing for the team — I'm not doing it for myself, then you will start executing it," he said.

The freedom that Sai Kishore speaks of is also the by-product of how he dealt with rejection. With the likes of Manav Suthar climbing the radar, he felt the necessity to add more to his arsenal. "I think the more I started exploring my game, I got freedom. Like, what can I actually do better? When you asked about setbacks, I was asking myself where can I get better and that's when I remembered what MS told me. So it was instinctive. I'm adding small, small puzzles to my bowling," he added.

BRIEF SCORES: Uttarakhand 134 & 113 in 45.4 overs (R Sai Kishore 6/34, S Ajith Ram 4/33) lost to Tamil Nadu 313 by an innings & 66 runs. Pts: TN 7, Uttarakhand 0.

Kartik grabs five in UP win; Vidarbha beat J&K in thriller



BHUTE, DUBEY HOLD FIRM

VIDARBHA EDGED past Jammu & Kashmir by three wickets in a low-scoring Group A thriller in Srinagar. Chasing 79, Vidarbha slipped to 26/6 before **Harsh Dubey** (22) and Nachiket Bhute (13) steadied the chase. Sunil Kumar's four-wicket haul and Umar Nazir's two wickets kept J&K in the contest until Vidarbha crossed the target.
BRIEF SCORES: Jammu & Kashmir 260 and 123 all out in 39.2 overs (Abdul Samad 39; Nachiket Bhute 5/48, Praful Hinge 2/13) lost to Vidarbha 305 and 81/7 in 22.5 overs (Mandar Mahale 25, Harsh Dubey 22 not out; Sunil Kumar 4/30) by three wickets. Points: Vidarbha 6, J&K 0.



SPIN SQUEEZE BY BENGAL

Bengal's spinners squeezed the life out of Services' chase as they secured a 60-run win in their Group C clash at Palam. Pradipta Pramanik led the attack with four wickets, while **Shahbaz Ahmed** took three. Services never found momentum after losing regular wickets, with Nitin Tanwar's 49 unable to prevent their collapse. Shahbaz was named Player of the Match for his 7/79 match haul.
BRIEF SCORES: Bengal 184 and 146 beat Services 122 and 148 all out in 68.5 overs (Nitin Tanwar 49; Pradipta Pramanik 4/48, Shahbaz Ahmed 3/44) by 60 runs. Points: Bengal 6, Services 0.



YADAV STEALS SHOW

KARTIK YADAV'S five-wicket haul powered Uttar Pradesh to a 68-run win over Goa in their Group A clash in Kanpur. Chasing 236, Goa were in the hunt through Suyash Prabhudessai's 72, but Yadav's spell tore through their middle and lower order. UP's bowlers kept chipping away as Goa were bowled out for 167.
BRIEF SCORES: Uttar Pradesh 202 and 197 all out in 58.4 overs (Aryan Juyal 74, Karan Sharma 31; Yash Kasvankar 5/69) beat Goa 164 and 167 all out in 46 overs (Suyash Prabhudessai 72; Kartik Yadav 5/37, Vaibhav Chaudhary 3/33) by 68 runs. Points: Uttar Pradesh 6, Goa 0.



GAIKWAD, BAWNE SHINE

RUTURAJ GAIKWAD struck an unbeaten 101 as Maharashtra piled up 527/5 declared against Jharkhand in their Group C clash in Pune. Gaikwad shared an unbeaten 182-run stand with Ankit Bawne, who made 169, after Digvijay Patil's 148. Trailing by 358 runs, Jharkhand made a positive start, with opener Shikhar Mohan unbeaten on 74.
BRIEF SCORES: Jharkhand 169 and 130/1 in 47 overs (Shikhar Mohan 74) trail Maharashtra 527/5 decl. in 150 overs (Ankit Bawne 169 not out, Digvijay Patil 148, Ruturaj Gaikwad 101 not out) by 228 runs.

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE

Ton-up Hingrajia stonewalls Delhi to help Gujarat recover from 153/4

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, October 20

NAVDEEP SAINI and Money Grewal, Delhi's two express quicks, put in hard shifts all morning before settling into their quiet outposts in the deep. On a flatbed where Gujarat lost two early wickets, the seamers still carried heavy workloads.

Manan Hingrajia had played himself in watchfully last evening after Gujarat's openers fell to impetuous shots. Soft dismissals also accounted for Vedant Trivedi and the hard-hitting Urvil Patel early in the third morning before Hingrajia and Jaymeet Patel struck a chord.

While Jaymeet's vigil ended halfway through Tuesday, Hingrajia navigated a full shift at the Air Force B Ground in Palam. Pedalling to an unbeaten 108 off 274 balls, Hingrajia guided Gujarat to 363 for five at stumps, trimming Delhi's hopes of an outright victory.

Starting the day with a 550-run first-innings lead, Delhi held a distinct edge over the visitors. The specks of dust that emerged from the strip following their declaration the previous evening must have enticed Ayush Badoni's men. The pitch, however, refused to belie its nature and offered Gujarat time to course-correct despite reeling at 153 for four in the first session. With their main stroke-makers sent back, Hingrajia and Jaymeet's left-handed pairing dropped a stubborn anchor, foiling Badoni's plans and distracting his two lead pacers.

Keeping themselves busy on the sidelines, Grewal and Saini occasionally turned for updates from the adjacent Ground A, where Bengal and Services were locked in a tight skirmish. The quicks from both grounds, separated by only a few metres, exchanged messages at their mid-wicket stations. The pacers were restricted to one wicket in the entire game on the other side.



Manan Hingrajia scored an unbeaten 108 off 274 balls. INSTAGRAM

Having rested himself this round, Mohammad Shami summed up the contrasting nature of the pitches crisply, both invariably spelling bad news for the fast bowlers. "*Udhar run on ki bauchhaar ho raha hai or idhar run ke lale pad rahe the.* (Runs were splashing over there and here we were desperately lacking runs)," the Bengal veteran quipped.

The 28-year-old Hingrajia led the Gujarat side last season, but had now returned to his primary role as the specialist number four. His progression from the age-group circuit where he topped the under-23 run-scoring charts across the country eight years ago wasn't straightforward. His white-ball career for the state was ever so fleeting, ending with two List A caps in four days in 2019.

Back home in Ahmedabad, though, he is the omnipresent crisis man for his home association. This summer he found himself in a unique T20 World Cup cameo when the Netherlands side put in a rare request to the local association before their group-stage match against India in Motera. The absence of skilful left-handers in their ranks prompted the Dutch to turn to a local 'net batter'. Hingrajia responded to Gujarat's SOS and signed up for a special range-hitting session.

But Hingrajia's uncomplicated defence and endurance suggest a natural affinity for the whites. Only in the post-lunch session did Delhi find momentary relief from Hingrajia's steely rearguard. It came at the other end when Jaymeet poked Saini to second slip, ending a 242-ball fifth-wicket stand.

Hingrajia dawdled with purpose and did not cede an inch. In the first hour past tea, he jotted only four runs. It took him 251 balls to reach his century, his fifth to across six wavering years of persistence in the Ranji circuit.

Delhi's bright spots were confined to the first 90 minutes of the day when Badoni's tight close-in fields denied free-flowing runs.

Pacer Divij Mehra soon dismissed Vedant, caught around his pads, before Urvil squandered his brisk start with a mistimed slog that popped up to the first-slip fielder against offie Hrithik Shokeen.

The top order's uninspired shot-making could have proven fatal on another day. But for Hingrajia's unperturbed blockathon, Gujarat held on, denying Delhi a facile path through their entire batting line-up.

BRIEF SCORES: Delhi 648/6 decl. vs Gujarat 363/5 in 120 overs (Manan Hingrajia 108 batting, Jaymeet Patel 72; Hrithik Shokeen 3/94). Gujarat trail by 285 runs.

TIMELY KNOCK

Harmanpreet turns back clock, powers India to clean sweep

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, October 20

INDIA COMPLETED a 3-0 sweep of Zimbabwe with a 92-run win in the third T20I in Raipur on Tuesday, but the series finale also exposed some concerns around their experiments. Harmanpreet Kaur's sublime unbeaten 91 off 41 balls and Shafali Verma's 69 powered India to 216/7, but some of the players given opportunities may have been left disappointed.

With the series already sealed after Sunday's nine-wicket win, India chose to bat first for the first time in the series and made several changes to their batting order.

Smriti Mandhana gave up her opening position to Anushka Sharma, who started cautiously before cutting and punching short deliveries outside off. She also dispatched Tendai Makusha's half-tracker over mid-wicket for six, but fell for 28 while trying to clear the same fielder, with Nyasha Gwanzura taking a fine catch.

Niki Prasad was promoted to number three but fell for nine after scoring a boundary early in her innings. She miscued an aerial shot and Loryn Phiri eventually completed a juggling catch at mid-off, giving Gwanzura her first wicket.

Shafali and Harmanpreet then took control with an 84-run third-wicket partnership. Shafali struck Kudzai Chigora through backward point before punishing Gwanzura with a six over wide long-on. She then smashed Phiri for two sixes, reaching her fifty off 27 balls. Her aggression eventually cost her wicket as she holed out to long-on for 69.

Steady start

Harmanpreet, meanwhile, took her time initially, reaching 11 off 11 balls. She shifted gears in the 13th over against Chigora, hitting a length ball over mid-off for four before pulling a short one over long-on for six. Another six over deep backward square leg followed, and Harmanpreet was suddenly in full flow.

Beloved Biza faced the onslaught next as Harmanpreet danced down to hit her over long-off, followed by an 82-metre six over long-on in the 16th over. She reached her 19th T20I fifty off 25 balls with three successive boundaries off Sibanda.



Harmanpreet Kaur stayed not out on 91 off just 41 balls. CREIMAS

Even as wickets fell around her, Harmanpreet maintained her aggressive intent, striking Makusha twice through point before launching Biza over long-off. Richa Ghosh, Deepti Sharma and Arundhati Reddy fell cheaply, but Harmanpreet stayed till the end to ensure India posted a formidable total.

The bowling offered another opportunity for a fringe player, with leg-spinner Prema Rawat coming in for N Sree Charani. Against an opposition that had managed 102 and 114 in the previous two matches, Rawat had a chance to make a case for herself.

Instead, she conceded 36 runs in her first three overs without taking a wicket.

Introduced in the seventh over with Zimbabwe 31/2 and well behind the required run rate, Rawat immediately came under pressure from Beloved Biza and Sharne Mayers. Mayers picked the length ball outside off and launched it over mid-off for six, after which Mandhana took Rawat out of the attack.

Rawat returned in the 12th over and looked to have settled her nerves, conceding just seven runs. That gave Mandhana enough confidence to bring her back for another over, hoping she could find a breakthrough.

Instead, Mayers went after her again. She struck a six over long-off, then used the width when Rawat went short to find a boundary behind point before going over long-off for another maximum. The final six brought up her fifty. Rawat conceded 20 in the over and finished wicketless.

The others had to complete the job. Nandni Sharma emerged as India's best bowler, claiming 3/18 in four overs. Niki took 1/5 in two overs, including Mayers' wicket in the 15th over after the batter had raced to 60 off 49 balls. Deepti took 1/18, while Kranti Gaud and Arundhati picked up a wicket apiece.

BRIEF SCORES: India 216/7 in 20 overs (Harmanpreet Kaur 91 not out, Shafali Verma 69) beat Zimbabwe 124/7 in 20 overs (Sharne Mayers 60, Beloved Biza 44; Nandni Sharma 3/18) by 92 runs.

Bavuma's 179 puts SA in control against Australia

Associated Press
Gqeberha, October 20

SKIPPER TEMBA Bavuma struck a Test-best 179 to help South Africa recover from 110-6 to post an imposing 425-9 declared on Day 3 of the second Test against Australia on Tuesday. Bavuma came out to bat on the opening day with the Proteas 12-2 and then saw them limp to 92-5 as rain and a wet outfield disrupted play a day later.

But he held South Africa together in stoic fashion, hitting 18 fours and one six in 334 deliveries, to put his side in control at St. George's Park. He had good support from the lower order, Marco Jansen scoring 85 and Simon Harmer adding 82 as the duo put on big partnerships with Bavuma in the first innings. In reply, Australia were 3-1 at stumps.

South Africa slumped to 110-6, having lost Wiaan Mulder (13) early in the morning session. He was caught at slip off Mitchell Starc, who picked up his 450th test wicket. Bavuma and Jansen then put on 106 for the seventh wicket before lunch.

They only added another 26 in the post-lunch session, taking their stand to 132 before Jansen was caught at short midwicket off seamer Scott Boland (5-81). Harmer then added 183 with Bavuma to turn the Test around for South Africa.

Bavuma reached his fifth test hundred off 226 balls, while Harmer smashed a six and 10 fours to score his maiden Test fifty. Bavuma continued to up the scoring rate. Harmer fell short of his hundred and the declaration came when Bavuma was caught behind off Starc.

BRIEF SCORES: South Africa 425/9 decl. (Temba Bavuma 179, Marco Jansen 85, Simon Harmer 82; Scott Boland 5/81) vs Australia 3/1 (Kagiso Rabada 0/1). Australia trail by 422 runs.

DAY 2 HIGHLIGHTS



Pranav Soorma. PTI

ATHLETICS GETS FIVE GOLDS
Nishad Kumar and Deepthi Jeevanji surpassed expectations as India's Asian Para Games campaign soared on a solid athletics performance that brought in five gold medals on Tuesday. The gold rush continued with the visually impaired Simran (women's 200m T12), wheelchair-bound Pranav Soorma (F51/52/53 discus throw) and Devender Kumar (F44/64 discus throw) also fetching gold medals.

NARWAL CLINCHES LA QUOTA
Manish Narwal clinched silver and secured a 2028 Los Angeles Paralympics quota place for India, while debutant Shrishti Arora won a bronze as Indian shooters collected two medals in the men's and women's 10m air pistol SH1 events.

LIFTERS, SWIMMERS SHINE
A silver medal was won in powerlifting with Ashok Kumar Malik finishing second in the men's 65kg competition. Indian swimmers Himanshu Nandal and Niranjan Mukundan also added two bronze medals to the tally.

HISTORIC TT MEDALS
Ravi Baby Sahana and Prachi Pandey made history by becoming India's first to make the podium in the standing category, as the country picked up four bronze medals. The haul took India past its tally from the Hangzhou edition.

EXPRESS NEWS SERVICE

ASIAN PARA GAMES 2026

Long jump, high jump — Nishant's giant leap

The para-athlete from HP's Badaun becomes only third-ever Indian to win two golds

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, October 20

MOMENTS AFTER he won the high jump T47 title at the Nagoya City Mizuho Park Athletics stadium, two-time Paralympics silver medallist Nishad Kumar waved at his coach Jeremy Fischer in the stands. Having topped long jump on Monday, Kumar became only the third Indian to win two gold medals in a single edition of the Asian Para Games after athlete Ankur Dhama and archer Sheetal Devi.

Shortly, he called his parents Rashpal Singh and Pushpa Devi, a former volleyball player, in Himachal Pradesh's Badaun. "I had told my parents as well as my sister Rama that I will come back with two gold medals. We had an emotional talk after my gold medal today," Kumar tells *The Indian Express* from Japan.

He was only eight when he lost his lower right arm in a fodder cutting machine when helping his mother in their farm. But the setback didn't deter him from pursuing his athletic ambitions. His efforts paid off when he won the men's T47 high jump title in last year's World Para Athletics Championships in Delhi with a best jump of 2.14m, in a tough grid including five-time world champion Rodrick Townsend.

Shortly, Kumar had a lengthy discussion about competing regularly in long jump with his long-time coach Jeremy Fischer, whose disciples include multiple Olympic medallist Will Clay. But with knee pain emerging again, Kumar decided to reverse the training load—70 percent high jump and 30 percent long jump— this year.



Nishad Kumar with coach Jeremy Fischer. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Under Fischer at Chula Vista in California, he started recalibrating his mind and body. "The first thing I understood was to switch off the mind as a high jumper, where I have to control my speed at the curve. In long jump, you need more speed. Once we decided to spend about 70 percent training for long jump, the aim was to increase the speed," he recounts.

"It came through special quick reaction drills as well strength work in gym so that the ground reaction was less and the muscle memory of the controlled curve run in high jump was reshaped. Once we achieved that, the next focus was on the running as well landing techniques," adds Kumar.

Finding rhythm, gear

Finding rhythm was the first step. "The first task was to get his rhythm for long jump. It came from a lot of short sprints as well transitioning from 13m to 26m runs and then from 26m to 39m runs," coach Fischer says.

"He had a couple of fouls yesterday but I guess he has the jumps of 7.60m in him for the next few months. He sometimes loses 30-40 cms on the take-off board but with more practice, he can reduce that," he adds.

Kumar, who had matched his personal best high jump of 2.14m last year, competed in long jump competitions in the USA during his training stint. He also clocked his personal best in long jump (7.22m) in the Oman Athletics Grand Prix in Muscat.

The 27-year-old got carbon fibre prosthetics worth Rs four lakhs in 2023, although he regularly started using it this year. But he sheds it for high jump. "I had tried wearing the prosthetics for high jump too but it did not work for me. It weighs close to 1.5kgs and provides me with the right balance in the run-up for the long jump. It helps in landing as well. The key was to train wearing it for most of the time as well as compete in long jump events in regular intervals. Then when I compete in high jump, I have to adjust my mind that I am not using it, as I have done all these years" says Kumar.

During the US stint, he spent more time strengthening the right arm, besides visualising it as the power source. His run-up became wider and take-off more vertical. Whereas once he largely watched videos of Tokyo Olympics high jump champion Gianmarco Tamberi, he added Paris Olympics champion Miltiadis Tentoglou, bronze medallist Mattia Furlani as well compatriots Murali Sreeshankar and Jeswin Aldrin to his watch-list. "The way Miltiadis, who started as a high jumper, uses vertical lift and body control off the board as well his quick acceleration down the runway to hit the board with horizontal velocity is something I should learn and work on," he says.

With the LA Paralympics two years away, Kumar knows he can emulate Townsend's feat of winning multiple Paralympics medals in high jump and long jump. "I have to balance with the knee pain and yes, it remains my target to win twin medals at the LA Paralympics," Kumar signs off.

Simran equals championship record to win gold, eyes one more

Nitin Sharma
New Delhi, October 20

SIMRAN SHARMA displayed a handwritten note that read, 'For my husband and two little ones. Next target world gold'. This happened immediately after she won the gold medal in the women's 200m T12 final. She also equalled the Para Asian Games record with a time of 20.80 seconds at the Nagoya City Mizuho Park Athletics Stadium. Watching from the stands was Gajendra Singh, her husband and coach. Soon, 26-year-old Simran, missing her 15-month-old twins — Akaay and Akshvi — made a video call to her home in Ghaziabad.

Childbirth was a tough phase, but she bounced back to finish atop the podium again.

"When my twins were born, I had hormonal issues. It took me a while to train again. I felt dejected, but my husband and my training group motivated me to return. I dedicate my medal to my husband Gajendra and to both Akaay and Akshvi. I want to win one more medal at these Para Asian Games so I can get one more Games' mascot toy for the kids," Simran, who is visually impaired, told *The Indian Express* from Nagoya.

Over the past two years, Simran changed her guide runner three times. A month after she won gold and silver in the 100 metres (T12) and the 200 metres (T22) at the World Para Championships in Delhi, her guide runner Umar Shaifi failed a dope test. This was after she ended a successful partnership with her first guide runner Abhay Singh. After Saifi's positive test, Simran teamed up with Shivam after seeing his reels on Instagram.

"It's tough when one has to start with a new guide. It takes a lot of practice to adjust as well as align with the running guide. We would have seven-to-eight short sprint training sessions," Simran said.



Simran Sharma (C) and bronze medalist Tejalben Damor (R). PTI

> **When my twins were born, I had hormonal issues. It took me a while to train again. But my husband and training group motivated me to return. I want to win one more medal at these Games so I can get one more mascot toy for the kids."**
> **SIMRAN SHARMA,** WOMEN'S 200M T12 SPRINTER

On Tuesday, Sharma first clocked 25.22 seconds in Heat 1 but it was clear that the competition in the final would be tougher as Iranian Hajar Safarzadeh set a new Asian Para Games record of 24.80 seconds in the second heat. However, Simran was up to the task and matched Safarzadeh's record time in the final to win gold, with the Iranian winning the silver medal with a time of 25.02 seconds.

Sharma believes she could have run faster if she had sorted out her diet in Nagoya. "One of the problems I faced here in Japan was food. Since I am a vegetarian, I could not find proper vegetarian meals here, and it posed problems in my recovery post-training. But then it's something I need to adjust. I feel I can go below the 24.40-second mark," Simran said.

Road to LA

Simran says she needs to improve her endurance and explosive speed too to fulfil her dream of winning two medals at the Los Angeles Paralympics. She watches videos of 11-time Paralympic gold medallist Omara Durand Elías of Cuba.

"Most of last year as well as this year was spent recovering and regaining strength. Because I compete in both 100m as well as 200m, I need the right balance of speed, endurance and strength. I also idolise Elías and listen to commentary during her races to understand her running tactics," Simran said.

The mother of two has overcome challenges to win a gold medal at the Asian Para Games. Now, she will pursue bigger dreams.

With attacking game & sharp angles, Ashmita downs Xi

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, October 20

ASHMITA CHALIHA is priming to launch her qualification bid in badminton women's singles for the Los Angeles Olympics, and her steady string of results is both pushing up her rankings, and giving her confidence to take on the big names next year.

Playing Chinese 4th best shuttler in rankings, Han Qian Xi, a 24-year-old, the Indian World No.36, secured a fine 21-18, 24-22 victory at the French Open at Tremblay-en-France, showing finishing finesse, as her left-handed free-stroking attack downed an opponent she had previously defeated to win the Korea Masters title.

Ashmita's southpaw game has always held the sting and speed to attack. The consistency was missing, though she's remedied that diligently at Guwahati and will move to her career-best ranking next week as 4 Indians get into Top 32.



Ashmita Chaliha defeated Han Qian Xi 21-18, 24-22. BADMINTON PHOTO

Ashmita's southpaw game has always held the sting and speed to attack. The consistency was missing, though she's remedied that diligently at Guwahati.

Relentless attack

Against the Chinese who was at a loss of ideas after Ashmita swamped her with deep attacks onto her backhand side, the Assamese showed relentlessness that has been missing — besides PV Sindhu at the elite Tour level. She always had a zipping smash, at times from a hop-jump. But Ashmita is sending down round-the-head, down-the-line zingers with devilish venom that is beginning to bother Top 30 shuttlers.

But it wasn't just the smash. Her attacking intent blazed from her backhand, which paired with a side stance is bringing her winners in a big bunch. She uses the backhand on defense, on the whipping back corner retrieve for a straight clear and for snappy drops and smashes, that left the Chinese perpetually short of reaching the shuttle.

The true test of her temperament though came after she had pocketed the opening set 21-18, and had fallen back 7-14 in the second. But what Ashmita has is an elite attack with several kill options that come powered with her free-flowing, fearless shot-making that travels at speed.

So, she worked her way back into the second set with an attacking flurry. Coach Park Tae Sang told *The Indian Express*, "We have worked hard on Ashmita's strengths. Her biggest is her attacking game. As left-hander, she has really good power and can create sharp angles which make her a very dangerous attacking player."

The first Super 300 title took time coming, but it has injected confidence in her to adopt the elite mentality. That entails not waffling about in the second set. So she took 7-14 as a challenge and made it 19-19 with a breath-taking barrage on the leaden-footed Chinese — zapped by the lefties angles.

Defensive rigour

Still, the Chinese was offered a chance from a rare Ashmita error, to level the sets. That next point at 19-20 down, was played with all the maturity and menace she could summon as she worked the court using the full expanse of it to shut out the Chinese.

The most prominent part of her backhand game however is how she is using it on lunges, picking shuttles inches off the floor and proceeding to win points. It's not ideal, but it's getting her winners two shots down the rally and frustrating opponents. The defensive rigour really helped her stay in rallies after which she transitioned into attacks with much glee and gusto.

"Earlier Ashmita used to give away easy points through errors. But today even if she was 7-15 in the second game, she refused to give up. She stayed patient. Kept believing in her attacking game. And found her way back into the match. I believe that her fighting spirit was an important part behind her victory," Park said.

The win came with a roar, and a promise of a likely Round 2 with Akane Yamaguchi who will test her mettle properly on Thursday. But for the moment, Ashmita's game had propelled her deeper. "At NCE, we work on her defense using multi-shuttle drills at least twice a week, which has made her much more solid and consistent in defense than before. We are trying to make her game more complete by strengthening her defense while maintaining her attacking strengths," Park explained.

The goals are set, and the intent is clear. "Breaking into Top 32 is very important to secure entries into Super 1000 and 750," Park says before adding, "From December, bigger goal is to compete for place in the 2028 Olympic Games when qualification begins on May 1, 2027."

Ten Hag says Ronaldo let him down at Man Utd

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 20

FORMER MANCHESTER United manager Erik ten Hag said that Cristiano Ronaldo let the team and him down during their time together at the club. Ten Hag said he had been keen to work with Ronaldo and had travelled to Portugal to discuss his plans with the forward before taking the United job in 2022.

"He let the team down, and he let me down, because we planned with him," Ten Hag told *The Athletic*.

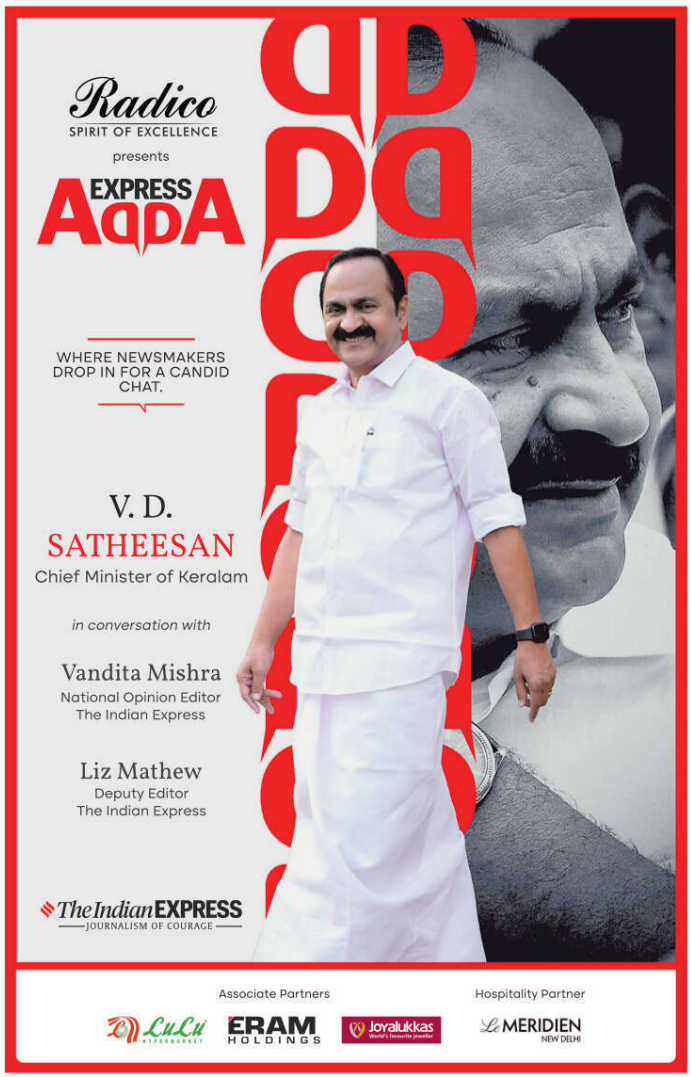
"I flew out to Portugal to speak with him about what I was aiming for before I came to United. Obviously, he's one of the best in football history. I respected him. But at that time, as a manager, I had to make a rational decision and keep the players I admire in," he added. Ten Hag said Ronaldo's preparation was another source of frustration. According to the former manager, he missed some training sessions, did not work at the required intensity in others and stopped short of completing the running exercise set for the squad after the 4-0 loss to Brentford early in the 2022-23 season.

"I confronted him with this," the Dutchman said. "Many times I say, 'Ronnie, everyone wants to work for you to bring you in the right position, but if you can't bring yourself in the box, you can't score'. He was not capable to do this. It's the wrong idea to put this to me, that I expected him to do the pressing, that he's exhausted. But he couldn't. He ran neither in possession nor out of possession. The reason was because he didn't prepare himself.

"Every top team has to embrace the top player, but the top player has to work for the team.

"He was telling the players, 'Save your legs at the training'. I understand it when you are top fit; you have sessions, you can save the legs. But first you have to train yourself to get into the right fitness levels."

Ronaldo returned to Manchester United from Juventus in August 2021 and scored 24 goals in 38 appearances in his first season back at Old Trafford.



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